

sadler explains the game



 **ECF** *Chess* **Moves**

June 2025

CONTENTS

Events

Forthcoming ECF Events by Nigel Towers	4
UK Open Blitz Championship 2025	5
3rd Cambridge International Open 2025 by Peter Wells	6
FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Team Championships 2025 by Matthew Wadsworth	15
Hammersmith Chess Club Wins the U2200 Category at the FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Teams Championships 2025 by Gaston Franco	24
Cotswold Chess Congress 2025 by Michael Ashworth	25
Hampshire Women's Individual Championship 2024/2025	27
South Lakes Congress 2025 by Dave Cole	31
Durham Chess Congress 2025 by Mick Riding	31
Yorkshire County Chess Update by Steve Westmoreland	32

Features

Endgames All Club Players Should Know by Glenn Flear	34
Book of the Month by Ben Graff	41
The Chess Trust	43
From the Archives by Dr Natalie Hayton, DMU	44
It's a Puzzlement!	46
Twenty Years After	49

News and Views

ChessMood – Free Access for Ten Days from 20th July	51
ECF Level One Arbiter Course (Online)	51
ECF Awards 2025	52
Membership Fees 2025/26	52
ECF's President's Award for Services to Chess - Roger Lancaster	52
4NCL 2025-2026 Dates	53
Seniors Events and Dates for 2025	53
New ECF Directors	53
ChessFest Returns – 13th July	55
2025 Northumbria Masters and First Darlington ChessFest	57
So You Want to Be a Master? by Charles Higgie	57
2025 King's New Year's Honours Stephen Rigby, British Empire Medal - New Photo	57
Gosforth Chess Club – Chess in the Park 25 and Stuff by Mick Riding	58
Delight for Durham University Alumni in World Chess League 2025 Season by Peter Hornsby	58
Kazakh Chess Players Play Historic Match in the British Parliament	59

Junior Moves

Littlewood's Choice	60
-------------------------------------	----

Improvers

Paul Littlewood on Tactics	62
Gormally's Coaching Corner	63

Studies and Problems

Monthly Conundrum by Christopher Jones	69
Winton British Chess Solving Championship 2025/2026 – Starter Problem	71
How to Solve a Study by Ian Watson	71
How to Solve a Study – Answer	74

Calendar	73
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EDITORIAL



Welcome to June's edition of *ChessMoves*!

Many congratulations to GM Mickey Adams on his third win in a row in the Cambridge International Open; GM Peter Wells provides comprehensive coverage of the event inside. Peter's article (and this month's cover) includes artwork from Cambridge by Dutch artist Pia Sprong – there's more information about Pia's work at the end of Peter's article. June also saw many of the world's top players converging on London for the third edition of the FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Team Championships; this was the first official FIDE event held in the UK since the 2013 Candidates, and it was great to see so many English teams take advantage of the opportunity to participate, with fifteen of the fifty-two teams entering the event predominantly English and over a hundred English players in total. GM elect Matthew Wadsworth reports.

Forthcoming ECF-organised events include the English and English Women's Championships on 18th to 21st July, the British Chess Championships on 31st July to 10th August, and the UK Open Blitz Championships, where the qualifying events kick off on 30th August. Full details on how to enter all three events inside!

In addition to our reports above we have our usual comprehensive range of regular articles and news stories from around England. It's very encouraging to see so many congress organisers sending in reports – please keep them coming! Last month we reintroduced our 'Readers' Games' feature - if you have a game that you would like considered for annotation and publication do please send it to me at the email address below.

Finally, our friends at ChessMood are unlocking access to all their courses completely free from 20th to 30th July – and if you decide to subscribe after the free period you get a 20% discount. This is a chance to explore hundreds of hours of top-quality training material with no commitment for the initial trial period. If you're interested in having a look, here's the link: <https://chessmood.com/?r=england>

All the games within are presented in PGN format here: <https://www.englishchess.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/ChessMoves-June-2025-.pgn> but note that you will need to use ChessBase or a PGN viewer to access the games.

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EVENTS

Forthcoming ECF Events by Nigel Towers

English Championships 18th to 21st July 2025



Last year's English Championships play-offs

The 2025 English and English Women's Championships have been rescheduled for Friday 18th July to Monday 21st July at the Holiday Inn Kenilworth. This year sees the introduction of an U1700 Women's tournament, which will run alongside the Women's Championship. Each of the three competitions will consist of seven rounds over five days, with play-offs to determine the respective champions if required for the championship events. The winners of the English Championship and the English Women's Championship will be awarded the Tony Miles trophy and the English Women's trophy respectively. You can find further details and an online entry form on the link below:

<https://www.englishchess.org.uk/english-championships-2025/>

British Chess Championships (31st July to 10th August 2025)



View across St George's Hall from the 2008 British - courtesy Steve Connor

This year's 111th British Chess Championships will be held at St George's Hall in Liverpool and the Liverpool Holiday Inn, Lime Street, with events running over 11 days from 31st July to 10th August 2025.

St George's Hall is a landmark building on St George's Place, opposite Lime Street railway station in the centre of Liverpool. The Liverpool Holiday Inn is located in Lime Street and is a four-minute walk from St George's Hall. All Championship and supporting tournaments will take place in St George's Hall, apart from the Weekend Congress from 1st – 3rd August and the final Saturday Rapidplay on 9th August, which will both take place in the Holiday Inn.

The Championships will open with the British Junior Blitz and Rapidplay Championships running from Thursday 31st July to Saturday 2nd August.

The standardplay Championship events start on Saturday 2nd August, with the main British Championships for qualifying players and the Major Open Tournament, which is open to all players. Both events will be played over nine rounds, with a round a day from Saturday 2nd August to Sunday 10th August.

Other standardplay Championship events include the 50+ and 65+ British Seniors Championships, with seven rounds from Monday 4th August to Sunday 10th August, and the British Junior Championships, with five age-limited Championships (U8, U10, U12, U14 and U16) running from Sunday 3rd August to Saturday 9th August.

There will be a full programme of supporting tournaments including the Weekender Congress from 1st to 3rd August, and the Weekday Morning and Afternoon Congresses from Monday 4th August to Saturday 9th August. There will also be a number of quickplay events, including evening blitz tournaments on Tuesday 5th August and Thursday 7th August, and a rapidplay tournament on Saturday 9th August.

As in previous years we will be running a social chess programme at St George's Hall alongside the Championships and supporting events, including outdoor social chess, simultaneous displays, team events, and chess masterclasses. There will also be a wider wrap-around programme of social chess and chess-themed cultural activities.

This year's Championships have benefitted from support from Liverpool City Council, Visit Liverpool, Liverpool Culture, the Chess Trust, and the John Robinson Youth Chess Trust.

Further details and online entry form are available on the link below:

<https://www.britishchesschampionships.co.uk/>

UK Open Blitz Championship 2025



Nigel Towers with Open Champion Eldar Gasanov



Nigel Towers and Women's Champion Eunice Hng

The UK Open Blitz Championship returns in 2025, featuring an expanded format with 16 qualifiers in 14 cities around the United Kingdom. Eldar Gasanov will be aiming for a hat-trick of Open titles after winning back-to-back in 2023 and 2024, while Eunice Hng will look to defend the Women's title. Full details for the tournament can be found here:

<https://www.englishchess.org.uk/uk-open-blitz-championships-2025/>

All qualifiers start at 11 am unless otherwise specified below.

30th August: London 1 (Hampton) White House, 45 The Avenue, Hampton TW12 3RN

6th September: Newcastle Sandman Signature Newcastle Hotel, Gallowgate, Newcastle upon Tyne NE1 4SD

7th September: Nottingham Nottingham High School, Waverley Mount, Nottingham NG7 4ED

7th September: (10am) – Glasgow Wellington Church, Glasgow University, 77 Southpark Avenue, Glasgow G12 8LE

13th September: Cardiff Mercure Cardiff North Hotel, Circle Way East, Llanedeyrn, Cardiff CF23 9XF

13th September: Southampton Barton Peveril Sixth Form College, Chestnut Avenue, Chestnut Ave, Eastleigh SO50 5ZA

13th September: (12pm) – Sheffield Sheffield Chess Centre, 329a Coleford Road, Darnall, Sheffield S9 5NF

14th September: London 2 (Harrow) Harrow High School, Gayton Road, Harrow HA1 2JG

20th September: Bristol St Michael's Centre, North Road, Stoke Gifford BS34 8PD

20th September: Liverpool North Liverpool Academy, 120 Heyworth Street, Everton, Liverpool L5 0SQ

20th September: London 3 (Golders Green) St Luke's Church, Kidderpore Avenue, Golders Green NW3 7SU

21st September: Belfast NICS, Maynard Sinclair Pavilion, Stormont, Upper Newtownards Road, Belfast BT4 3TA

27th September: Birmingham Quinborne Community Centre, Ridgacre Road, Quinton, Birmingham B32 2TW

28th September: Edinburgh Edinburgh Park Novotel, 15 Lochside Avenue, Edinburgh EH12 9DJ

28th September: Leeds Crowne Plaza Leeds by IHG, Wellington Street, Leeds LS1 4DL

28th September: Manchester Bolton Arena Sports Village, Arena Approach, Horwich, Bolton BL6 6LB

Online entry to the qualifiers can be found here:

<https://britchess.wufoo.com/forms/2025-uk-open-blitz-championships/>

The finals will be 16-player round robin tournaments, once again taking place at Woodland Grange in Leamington Spa on Saturday 22nd November.

3rd Cambridge International Open 2025 by Peter Wells



Matthew Carr with Brandon Clarke (2nd), Michael Adams (winner) and Wenxiang Li (3rd)

When I reported on the second edition of the Cambridge International Open for the March 2024 *ChessMoves* I went to some lengths to convey quite how special this tournament feels. Cambridge is a wonderful city, the University Arms a quite exceptional hotel which makes for a splendid and perfectly located venue, and the organisation has been really excellent. All this enthusiasm was entirely genuine, but there were also rumours by the end of the event that its future may be uncertain, and it seemed important to me to emphasise quite how enthusiastic the players are for this thing. So when it became clear that there was to be no Cambridge tournament in February 2025, I was very disappointed but not entirely surprised. The surprise came rather with the announcement, relatively late in the day, that the tournament would after all happen at the end of May, still boasting the same magnificent venue. Its popularity was once again very much in evidence, as even with a relatively late announcement the places filled up with awesome speed.



Image © Pia Sprong, used with permission

It would be fair to say that all the praise which I lavished upon this event last year is equally applicable this time. By this time of the year there was more evidence of the greater crowds with which such a famous tourist destination has to grapple in the summer months, but the lighter evenings provided a lot of compensation. The hotel continued to provide a very friendly welcome alongside all the grandeur, and a huge debt of thanks is due to the organisers: to Nigel Towers and Shohreh Bayat behind the scenes, and Adrian Elwin and Matthew Carr, who headed the team of arbiters. It was great to have both commentators Natasha Regan and Matthew Sadler in attendance for the later rounds, and it was easy to see how their being present to soak up the atmosphere carries through in the quality and empathy of the commentary.

In short, the tournament passed one of the acid tests: I still enjoyed it even when I was struggling at the board! Last year I had started well, which gave me just the strong and highly-rated opponents I was looking for. This year the accelerated pairings failed to come to my rescue as I struggled consistently to beat substantially lower-rated players in the early rounds. Yet the tournament has so many charms that I survived, and so did my enthusiasm.

In among all the praise, I must sound just one note of concern – intended less as a criticism than as food for thought for future years. I wonder whether the minimum entry limit (at 1600) is pitched a little low, given the public appetite for the tournament and the speed with which places filled up? At the risk of sounding elitist, I think a higher limit – which would have given more time for additional strong players to enter – might have enhanced

the tournament still further. Comparing with the 2024 tournament, this seemed to affect two groups in particular. There were (with some notable exceptions) fewer of our top juniors present this time, and fewer women, and – thinking back to the excellent publicity which surrounded the successes of both Bodana Sivanandan and Ruqayyah Rida last year – this was perhaps especially missed where the two categories overlap. While congratulations are due to Audrey Kueh for winning the women’s prize just ahead of Cambridge’s own Julia Volovich, it would have been good to see more female players in the mix. Having said all this, I can’t stress enough that even as I write ‘food for thought for future years’ I can’t but stress that the priority is that there should be future years. Nothing would give me more pleasure than to see Cambridge firmly established as an annual event.



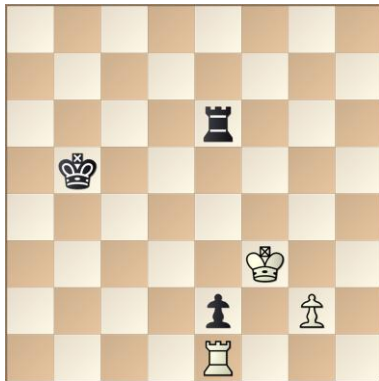
Image © Pia Sprong, used with permission

It might be reasonable to suppose that I have written sufficient tournament reports that I would, by now, approach them with some kind of clear formula. In reality, I mostly find myself liable to be preoccupied by similar dilemmas each time. In particular, how much weight should be given to the games which were pivotal in deciding the event, as opposed to just seeking out various moments which were both instructive and hopefully entertaining too. Is there merit in taking a round by round approach, or is it better (if considerably more challenging) to try to weave together the narratives of the many players whose performances were worthy of note, or who even had a significant impact on events? I tend towards the latter, but here at least was a tournament which offered so much entertaining fighting chess that it really would have been possible to find a worthy tussle from

every single round. I have to confess that occasionally I have had to report on tournaments from which it was a struggle to find a group of truly entertaining games, but here I am delighted to say that my problem was completely the opposite – one of trying to choose the most memorable dishes from a veritable feast.

I guess another approach would be to build up the tension by trying to approach the thing like some kind of whodunnit. Yet the narrative flows more easily if we start with the winner, and, after all, the fact that for the third year in a row the indomitable Michael Adams ‘dunnit’ would hardly constitute a twist. Once again he succeeded in achieving first place – winning, as last year, on tie-break with the excellent score of 7/9. Given the very promising position he achieved in the final round against the tenacious Sergei Tiviakov – one of the joint winners from 2024 – Michael might well have felt that it could have been even more. However, I think it is once again worth emphasising that even as the player who has been the ‘rating favourite’ by a decent margin on each occasion, the level of consistency which he has demonstrated over these three events represents an extraordinary achievement, not least for a player no longer in the first flush of youth. When he has had ‘off days’ they have ultimately done no harm beyond impacting the margin of victory.

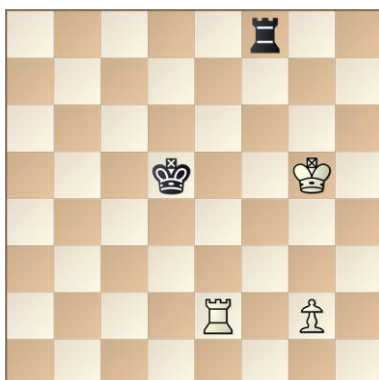
Intriguingly, each of Michael’s winning campaigns has kicked off with a draw. Part of this is just that sometimes a little time is needed to get yourself into the ‘zone’ needed to play high-level chess – a phenomenon with which I suspect many players (myself included) can identify. However, it is hardly surprising that when I chatted with Michael just after the last round our conversation veered – as conversations between players seeking to protect their ratings often do these days(!) – to the subject of the difficulty of beating players post-Covid against whom a very strong showing could once upon a time have been reasonably counted upon. My overwhelming feeling about my own tournament was that – up until the last round, when I suffered badly against Matthew Wadsworth – I sometimes struggled to feel the difference in strength between opponents rated over 2400 and those several hundred points below. Michael’s response suggested to me that he believed this might sometimes be more than just a failure of perception – a rating system still struggling to catch up with the depth of strength out there. I cannot resist at this point giving Michael’s rook ending from the second round. Yes, this is partly about the narrow margins between a win and a draw, but I also find it very instructive – if quite complex – in its own right.



White is clearly picking up the once-dangerous passed e-pawn. Yet there are aspects of the ensuing rook and pawn vs rook endgame – probably the most heavily studied of all endings – which struck me as fascinating, and even a little counter-intuitive.

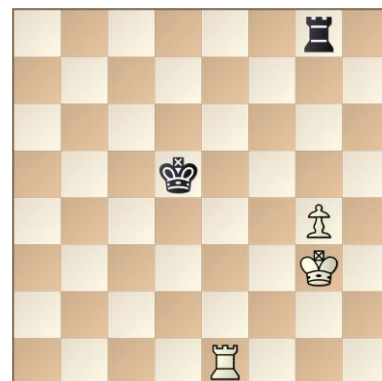
61...Kc4? By this stage of the game – in a tournament where, as so often these days, the schedule permits no added time at move 40 - it is fair to assume that both players were feeling the pressure of the clock to some extent. Given that the key resource for the defender in such endings (with the king cut off, but White's pawn not yet far advanced) is checking distance from the front – sufficient space between the black rook and the white king to ensure that the king cannot escape checks by approaching the rook – it would make more sense to force the king to capture on e2 and thereby force it all the way back to g1. It is therefore no great surprise that something like 61...Rf6!+ 62.Kxe2 Re6+ 63.Kf2 Rf6+ 64.Kg3 Rg6+ 65.Kh2 Rh6+ 66.Kg1 Kc5 67.Rd1 Rg6! (necessary, with the king cut off by an extra file to prevent 68.g3! and Kg2) should hold comfortably enough. It is perhaps less clear that 61...Kc5!? 62.Rxe2 Rf6+ 63.Kg4 Rf8! (re-establishing checking distance) should also suffice, but the reasons that this is the right route for Black's king should become apparent in due course.

62.Rxe2 Rf6+ 63.Kg4 Kd5 64.Kg5 Rf8



65.g4?! I guess convention might require a harsher marking, since this technically lets the win slip – but it really is the most natural move in the world, and the winning alternative is very far from easy to spot under pressure. The problem, in essence, is that Black still retains 'checking distance' after this advance, and he gets a moment to send his king back in the right direction. By contrast, the subtle 65.Ra2! prepares to meet 65...Ke6 with 66.Ra6+!, when the threat of a pawn ending prevents the black king heading via the f-file, while after 66...Ke7 67.g4 White's rook is ready to block the checks with decisive effect. The alternative defence would be to try to put the rook on g3, but after 65...Rg8+ 66.Kf6 Rg3 67.Kf5 Kd6 68.Re2 Black has no good move, since after, for example, 68...Kd7 69.Kf4 Rg8 70.g4 Rf8+ 71.Kg3 Rg8 White has 72.Re4! – a familiar theoretical idea which enables the white king to approach the rook without having to keep guarding the pawn – and Black's king is unable to harry this rook in time.

65...Rg8+ 66.Kh4 Rh8+ 67.Kg3 Rg8 68.Re1



68...Kd4? In a sense an echo of Black's previous mistake, but also, I suspect, an interesting case in which theoretical knowledge can serve to mislead. My guess is that Black knew the idea mentioned in the last variation, and was loath to retreat the king, since he knew that a rook coming to e4 absolutely needs to be challenged. However, after the correct move 68...Kd6! 69.Re4 the king can simply return with 69...Kd5!, when any attempt to use the rook to shield the checks (by 70.Re7 Kd6 71.Rh7 for instance) simply permits the defender's king back across the f-file. Now, though, White's rook is free to penetrate to the sixth rank in the manner we saw before, setting Adams on to a vital second-round victory.

69.Re6! Kd5 70.Ra6 Ke5 71.Kh4 Kf4 72.Rf6+ Ke5 73.g5 Rh8+ 74.Kg4 Rh1 75.Ra6 Rh2 76.g6 1–0

What of the players who had shared the honours with Adams in 2024? Well, Sergei Tiviakov performed perfectly respectably, and notably scored a very convincing win with Black against the talented young Aaravamudhan

Balaji together with a win in the penultimate round against Martin Haubro to reach the group on 6½/9 and an equal third place. However, he looked to me a little too solid to be really threatening. I drew fairly comfortably with Black against him in round 3, and when he took a bye in round 5 (understandable enough given the tough schedule, but not the ideal way perhaps to build momentum) I suspected he probably wouldn't be repeating last year's success. It was, of course, Haubro who was one of the sensations of 2024, but he seemed unfortunately rather out of shape this time. He initially recovered quite well from blundering a piece against Liam Varnam in the second round, but he also finished with a final loss against the always dangerous Stanley Badacsonyi.

This year there was a different group of players who performed way above expectations, by no means all of them especially young 😊. Liam Varnam – whose achievements extended well beyond converting the aforementioned extra piece – picked up the rating prize for 2000-2200, and a smooth 50 rating points on a 'k' factor of just 20. Some were younger, of course! Wengxiang Li impressed once again with a stellar performance, going unbeaten against a field which included both winners, as well as Daniel Fernandez and Matthew Wadsworth. I was very pleased in round 7 to put an end to a similarly amazing run from the Polish junior Adam Nawalaniec, who by then had accumulated two victories and four draws against two GMs (including Michael Adams) and two IMs (including GM elect Matthew Wadsworth). Perhaps the most striking of all was the form of Indian IM Siva Mahadevan – already quite a familiar name on the English tournament circuit – who could do no wrong in the early rounds, and who was clear leader prior to his round 6 reversal against Michael Adams. Talented GMs Marin Bosiocic and Daniel Fernandez were both among the early victims, the latter in the following hugely entertaining encounter.

Daniel Fernandez - Siva Mahadevan

3rd Cambridge International Open 2025 Round 4

1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 c5 3.e3 Nc6 4.c3 Qb6 5.Qb3 c4 6.Qc2



This position is far less well known than its counterpart with the two knights already developed to f3 and f6, which is something of a main line – albeit one with a deservedly healthy reputation from Black's point of view. The reasons for White declining to capture on b6 are well documented – the open a-file is a significant asset - as are the reasons that deflection ideas with...Bf5 work well with the knights developed. However, from the diagram 6...Bf5? essentially fails to 7.Qxf5 Qxb2 8.Qxd5 Qxa1 9.Qb5! when the white queen is optimally placed to embarrass both black monarchs. Hence the gambit flavour which Siva now injects into the play.

6...e5! 7.Bxe5 A very sharp solution, and the only way to prepare to meet ...Bf5 ideas by lopping it off! White can play 7.dxe5 Bf5 8.Qc1 (but not 8.Qxf5 Qxb2, when the white e-pawn now shields d5, and 9.e6 fxe6 10.Qxe6+ Be7 just favours Black, not least as 11.Qxd5 Rd8! would be a catastrophe), which has been played a few times by Aman Hambleton, but Black has compensation, with 8...g5 probably the critical choice. For a player of his theoretical erudition, Daniel Fernandez showed a strong desire to seek original and at times almost chaotic solutions, which if nothing else made his games a source of endless fascination. Since he also reached 6½/9 and equal third, this is also a quite unfair representation of how things mostly worked out for him!

7...Nxe5 8.dxe5 Bf5 9.Qxf5 After 9.Qa4+ best play is likely a repetition with 9...Bd7 10.Qc2 Bf5 – definitely not in either the spirit, or the style, of either player!

9...Qxb2



10.Kd1? There are two elements to White's compensation for the exchange - most evidently, the potential entrapment of the black queen, but also threats to Black's king as well. In essence, though far from obvious, I believe this emphasises the wrong one, and I find it very instructive (indeed I have already used this position in one coaching session!) that the key idea for White should be to develop as rapidly as possible with 10.Bxc4! dxc4 11.Nf3!. It is perhaps not surprising that immediately taking either rook will not end well, e.g. 11...Qxa1 12.e6! fxe6 13.Qb5+ Kf7 14.Ne5+ Kf6 15.0-0, with a very strong attack. Black can apparently preface a rook capture with 11...g6 12.Qe4 Qc1+ 13.Ke2 Qxh1 14.Qxb7 Rd8



which the engine confidently awards 0.0, although Black would need strong nerves to be certain that White cannot try for more (providing he keeps the mate threat on d1 in mind 😊). 11...Ne7 12.Qe4 0-0-0! 13.Qxc4+ Nc6! 14.0-0 Qxa1 15.Qb3 Na5! Is also a valid defence, although all of this would have been very hard to calculate over the board.

10...Qxa1 11.Qc2 b5!? The engine also mentions another attempt to rescue the queen, involving 11...Ne7 12.Nf3 h5! with ...Rh6-b6 to come, but Black plays with great precision to justify the move chosen.

12.Ke2 Bc5 13.e6 Daniel's main problem here is that his king on e2 impedes his natural development, and thus offers Black more time to rescue the queen. For example,

after 13.Nf3 all Black would really need to do is to be mindful that the ...b4 break requires preparation (since 13...b4?! 14.Qa4+! complicates matters), and find 13...Rb8! 14.g3 b4 15.cxb4 (15.Qa4+ Kf8) 15...Rxb4, with a fairly painless route out.

13...Nf6 14.exf7+ Kxf7 15.Nf3 Rhe8 16.g3 Rab8?! 17.Ng5+ Kg8 18.Bg2 Rbd8



19.Rd1 Of course White would like to play 19.Nd2, but despite his slight inaccuracy Siva still has the very elegant 19...d4! available, when the counter-threat to the white queen decides.

19...d4 20.cxd4 Bxd4! Not 20...Rxd4 21.Nd2, when Black would be forced to return the exchange.

21.Bc6 Bxe3! 22.Rxd8 Rxd8 23.fxe3 Qe5



The painful irony for White is that he has momentarily restored something approximating to material equality, but the horrible lack of coordination of his forces and the weakness of e3 affords his opponent an almost automatic attack.

24.Ne4 Rd3 25.Nbc3 Qh5+ 26.Kf1 Ng4 27.Kg1 Nxe3 28.Qe2 Rd1+ 29.Kf2 Ng4+ 0-1

Another player who impressed with his uncompromising chess was Croatia's Marin Bosicic. For instructional purposes I would commend his superb construction of a

model attack for Black in the Queen's Gambit Exchange Variation against Richard Pert in round 5, while my own game with him showed both how he can generate attacking chances from seemingly innocuous positions and perhaps push a little too hard on occasions, as I missed a clear win in time trouble in the complications. However, it was his creative (if hardly perfect) clash with Michael Adams when they were both leading on 5/6 which felt like a really pivotal moment for both.

Marin Bosiocic – Michael Adams

3rd Cambridge International Open 2025 Round 7

1.c4 e5 2.e3 Nf6 3.Nc3 Nc6 4.a3 g6 5.b4 Bg7 6.Bb2 0–0



7.g4!? Very sharp and challenging, but not necessarily playing percentage chess. I am not sure why, but (by way of an aside) Michael Adams seemed to attract some quite eccentric opening choices from his opponents in Cambridge this time. The talented Lorenzo Fava, whose play never quite reached the heights of his 2024 tournament, but who nonetheless put in a strong performance decided to essay the somewhat baffling 4.a4(!?) in the Four Knights in round 5, and even obtained some advantage before being later outplayed. However, the prize for sheer audacity (and getting away with it!) should go to Richard Pert, who essayed the hardly plausible gambit 1.e4 d5 2.exd5 c6?! (essentially a kind of Göring Gambit minus a tempo!), and somehow drew after a nice exchange sacrifice much later in the game. In the case of Adams, all this can hardly be indicative of a lack of respect. I suspect rather the kind of Karpov-Miles 1...a6 phenomenon, where the player looks at the awesome preparation of their very strong opponent and says, 'OK, we have to at least make some mess'. As for the text move, it was played in a blitz game by Arjun Erigaisi, but I am not predicting a lengthy career for it in classical play...

7...d6 Solid and sensible, but I would probably have taken a look at 7...e4!/? too (probably for too long if truth be told!).

8.g5 Nd7 (8...Nh5!?) 9.h4 Nb6 10.d3 Bf5 11.Nf3 e4 12.dxe4 Bxe4 I wonder whether Mickey noticed that the paradoxical 12...Bg4!/? was an interesting option here? What I like about it is the extent to which it highlights the weakness of c4, and hence makes perfect sense of the knight which he manoeuvred to b6. Given the obvious recapture on e4 I think it is quite hard to even think of it, but if you do you would probably play it!

13.Nxe4 Bxb2



14.Ra2?! I find this slightly odd. Given White's super-aggressive opening I would expect him to be keen to press on with his king-side aspirations with 14.h5!, and to regard any capture on a1 as an unexpected bonus! The text affords Black more time to create play along the centre files.

14...Qe7! 15.Nfd2 Bg7 16.f4?! This, however, feels like a more serious slip, since any failure to maintain the knight on e4 is going to result in the weakness of e3 really hurting. Again, 16.h5!/? feels more natural, even though White is unlikely to give mate without a dark-squared bishop. After this I would suggest that White could claim his experimental opening as a qualified success – reaching complex and unusual play without any concrete downside.

16...d5! 17.cxd5 Nxd5 18.Qf3 Nc3 19.Rc2



19...Rfe8! An efficient way to intensify the pressure along the e-file, since either 20.Nxc3 Nd4! and 20.Rxc3 Bxc3 21.Nxc3 Nd4! 22.Qe4 Qd8! would be fairly disastrous for White.

20.Bg2 Rad8 21.0-0 Rd3 I suspect 21...Nxe4 22.Nxe4 Rd3! might have left White with fewer defensive options.

22.Nxc3 Bxc3 23.Rxc3! The only way to fight. It seems unlikely that the knight landing on f6 is going to cause a catastrophe, but it does offer White chances to select a tenable ending.

23...Rxc3 24.Ne4 Rxa3!? Quite a brave decision, given that the alternative way to return the exchange - 24...Qxe4! - would have resulted in favourable endings with somewhat fewer options for White.

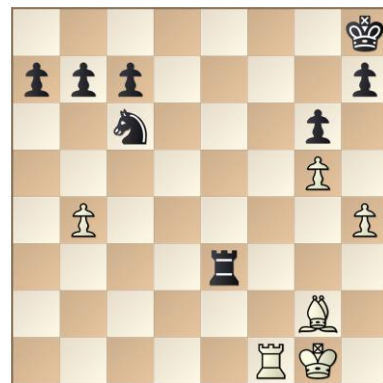
25.Qf2!? Since after 25.Nf6+ Kf8! 26.Nxe8 there is a useful Zwischenzug in 26...Rxe3!.

25...Rb3 The engine prefers 25...Rd8!, with the idea that 26.Nf6+ Kg7 27.Qb2 can be met with 27...Qxe3+ 28.Kh1 Qc3!, blocking the treacherous diagonal. However, White could throw in something like 28.b5!?, and may have ideas with either h4-h5 or f4-f5 to boot. It is difficult to convey quite how complicated this all is to navigate at the board!



26.Nf6+ Kh8 27.Nxe8 Qxe8 28.f5! Qxe3 It's wise to continue liquidating. In the event of 28...Ne5 29.fxg6 hxg6 30.Qf6+ Kh7 31.h5 White keeps a share of the chances.

29.Qxe3 Rxe3 30.fxg6 fxg6



31.Rf8+ I tuned into the game live a couple of moves later than this, but even then I was convinced that a rook ending would have offered White the best chances to hold. However, the possibility of generating mating threats with a timely Bd5 is an obvious source of temptation! The best way seems to be 31.Bxc6 bxc6 32.Rf8+ Kg7 33.Ra8 Re4 34.Rxa7 Rxh4 35.Rxc7+ Kf8 36.Kf2 (36.Rxc6 Rg4+ 37.Kf2 Rxg5 38.Rc8+ Kg7 39.Rc7+ Kh6 40.Rc5! should also hold, but this feels much less clear - trying to get Black's h-pawn in return for the g-pawn makes sense) 36...Rh5 37.Kf3 Rxg5 38.Rxh7, and White should be able to defend.

31...Kg7 32.Rc8 Re7 33.b5? A curious misjudgement. Of course, we should be cautious about the phrase 'all rook endings are drawn', but they tend to be more drawn than others! 33.Bd5 h6 34.Bxc6! bxc6 35.gxh6+ Kxh6 36.Kg2 still offered decent chances to hold.

33...Nd4 34.Bxb7 Nxb5 35.Bd5 h5 36.gxh6+ Kxh6 37.Kf2 Nd6 38.Ra8 c5 Black still has a few difficulties to navigate, but Mickey was clearly back in the driving seat, and his technique was as usual admirable.

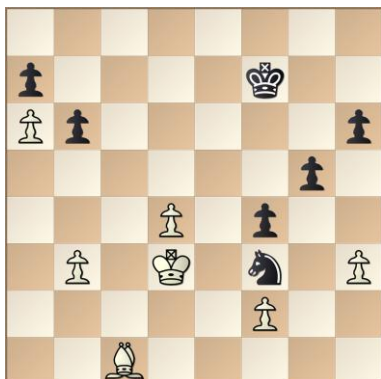
39.Kf3 Rc7 40.Kg4 c4 41.Rd8 Nf5 42.Be4 c3 43.h5 c2 (43...Rc4!?) 44.Bxc2 Rc4+ 45.Kf3 Rxc2 46.hxg6 Kxg6 47.Ke4 Rc5 0-1

If this evokes a degree of sympathy for Marin Bosiocic, I guess his survival against me that evening as well as the turn of events in his last round game might dampen those feelings a little. The very likeable Welsh IM and my White Rose teammate Jose Camacho Collados was another player who played an excellent tournament which probably deserves a more generous representation than as the victim of this curious endgame. Still, I found White's idea very instructive in itself, and it again brought home to me (nursing my own wounds from another bruising last-round defeat) just how brutal the final round can be, and how narrow the margins between victory and defeat so often are.



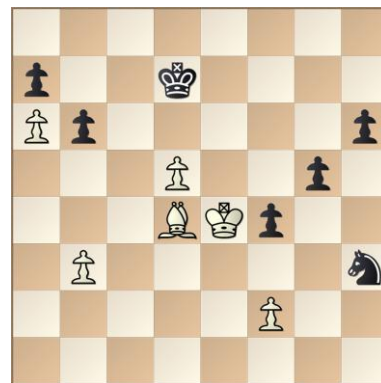
Even as we approach this endgame, the contours of the game in which Jose sacrificed a pawn for decent enough positional compensation are still much in evidence. First, although objectively nothing special, a reminder that the reasons that engines love putting pawns on h6 or a6 do not just revolve around direct attacks on the king!

31.a6(!) b6 32.Rc1 Rxc1 33.Bxc1 Nxf3 34.h3



34... Ke6? One of those moves which, as you are playing it, might look like the safe option, but which is actually a decisive error. Attending first to the knight by 34...h5! 35.Ke4 Ng1 36.h4 would work really well due to 36...Ne2 37.Bd2 gxh4 38.Bxf4 Nxf4 39.Kxf4 Ke6, when it is White who probably needs to be careful.

35.Ke4! Ng1 36.d5+ Kd7 37.Bb2! Nxh3 38.Bd4!



This is the problem. For the first time in the game the bishop emerges to a great square to be a clearly better piece than the knight! The bishop not only defends f2, containing Black's counterplay, but Black's king is disastrously overworked – unable to defend against the threat of Bxb6 and also the advance of the d-pawn. Jose does his best to complicate, but there is no way back.

38...Kc7 39.Ke5 g4 39...f3 40.d6+ Kd7 41.Bxb6 Nf4 42.Ke4 Kxd6 43.Bxa7 Kc6 44.Be3 Ne6 45.Kxf3 h5 46.b4 g4+ 47.Kg3 is also lost.

40.d6+ Kc6 41.Ke6 g3 42.d7 Ng5+ 43.Ke7 Nf7 44.fxg3 fxg3 45.Bxb6 g2 46.Bxa7 Kc7 47.Bg1 Nd8 48.Bh2+ 1–0

Finally to the co-winner of the tournament, the very strong English IM Brandon Clarke. It was only when talking to him straight after the tournament that I appreciated that this tournament represented an extraordinary comeback after quite a lengthy break from playing. There are many possible ways to interpret this. We know that in general playing is beneficial, but that over-playing is also not an unusual occurrence, and that a break can be a great way to rekindle passion for the game. It is also possible that a break from putting pressure on yourself, and playing in a more relaxed manner – if only as a consequence of reduced expectations - can on occasions be quite a liberating experience. In the event Brandon started relatively slowly, including a defeat at the hands of Lorenzo Fava. However, he recovered superbly, beating both Badacsonyi brothers and then the strong IM Marcos Comacho Collados. However, it was his last-round game which inevitably garners attention for the boldness of Brandon's play, the quality of preparation, and because it was over (and with it Siva Mahadevan's chances of a final result worthy of his performance, and sadly a GM norm) so incredibly quickly. Which leaves us owing congratulations and commiserations in something like equal measure.

12...Bxe6 13.Bb6 Qc8 14.Nc7+ Kf8 15.Nxa8 Qc6



stronger was 16.0–0–0 Qxa8 17.Qxd6+ Kg8, when there is nothing too much wrong with White's position with rook and two pawns against the two minor pieces, so long as he prioritises exchanging something – most obviously the bishops with 18.Bd4!?, or possibly even the rooks with 18.Qc7 Kh7 19.Rd8. After the text move things go bad very quickly.

18.Bxb8? This just looks like nerves to me. Surely White must look to the dark squares, and indeed after 18.Bxd6+ Kg8 19.Rxa1 Qxa8 20.Be5 Brandon would still have had a lot of work to do.

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FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Team Championships 2025

by Matthew Wadsworth



Mike Truran making the first move on the first day of the FIDE World Blitz Team Championships

From 10th to 16th June many of the world's top players converged on London for the third edition of the FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Team Championships. The venue for the event was the Novotel Hotel in Hammersmith. This was the first official FIDE event held in the UK since the 2013 Candidates, and it was great to see so many English teams take advantage of the opportunity to participate. Fifteen of the approximately fifty teams to enter the event were predominantly English, and there were over a hundred English players in total. Naturally these teams were mostly concentrated towards the bottom of the seedings, while the top of the tournament was dominated by a series of international super-teams. A notable exception was Malcolm's Mates, who began the Rapid section as the third seeds and were headlined by English Olympiad team members GMs Adams, Jones, Vitiugov and Mcshane.

I have always enjoyed playing in team events; it brings a more social element to competitions, and it is nice to always be invested in games beyond simply your own. I also thought that the specific format of this event, in which each team had to have at least one female player and one amateur (defined as below 2000 FIDE), worked positively. My team of Wood Green consisted of IMs Marcus Harvey, Jonah Willow and Maciej Czopor, FM Viktor Stoyanov, WFM Audrey Kueh, Madara Orlovskaya, Carmel Barwick, Alaa Gamal and myself. We were seeded towards the bottom of the top half in both the Rapid and the Blitz events, so placing highly in either event was always going to be a long shot. However, the U2400 rating prize in the Rapid felt like a reasonable goal.

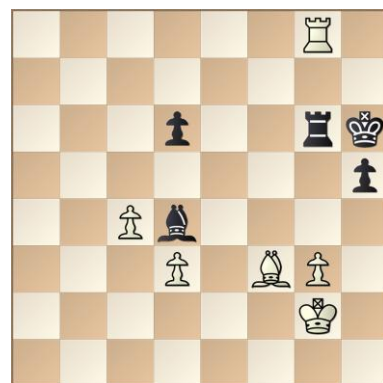
The schedule was surprisingly tiring: the Rapid event was a 12-round Swiss, with four games per day on each of Wednesday, Thursday and Friday, while the blitz was split into a 13-round all play all on the Saturday and a knock-out tournament on the Sunday for the highest-placed teams. Compared with a classical tournament, you are probably at the board for a shorter amount of time; however, the constant time pressure at the board, as well as the frantic periods between games, made the event very much a test of stamina. I ended up playing all 12 rounds of the Rapid and 11 of 12 possible games during the Blitz, so was absolutely exhausted by Saturday evening!

The Rapid event began somewhat nervously for us; none of us were particularly well-practised in rapidplay time controls (for example, my last rated rapidplay tournament was back in 2019!), and we were paired against a Romanian team mostly consisting of juniors. Thankfully we ended up winning 5-1 in a match that should have been much closer; my win on board 2 turned into a nice endgame grind with rook and opposite-coloured bishop each.

Wadsworth, Matthew J (2367) - Rusu, Lucas (2130)

2025 FIDE World Rapid Team Championship London, United Kingdom (1.20), 11.06.2025

1.Nf3 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.Nc3 Nc6 4.g3 g6 5.Bg2 e5 6.d3 Bg7 7.a3 0-0 8.Rb1 a5 9.0-0 d6 10.Ne1 Be6 11.Bg5 h6 12.Bxf6 Bxf6 13.Nc2 Qb6 14.Ne3 Bg7 15.Ned5 Qd8 16.b4 axb4 17.axb4 Rb8 18.e3 Bxd5 19.Nxd5 b6 20.Qa4 Nxb4 21.Nxb4 cxb4 22.Rxb4 f5 23.Qc6 Qf6 24.Rxb6 Rxb6 25.Qxb6 h5 26.h4 f4 27.Qc6 Bh6 28.Qe4 g5 29.hxg5 Qxg5 30.exf4 exf4 31.Qd5+ Qxd5 32.Bxd5+ Kg7 33.Re1 fxg3 34.fxg3 Bd2 35.Re7+ Kg6 36.Kg2 Bc3 37.Be4+ Kg5 38.Re6 Rf6 39.Re8 Bd4 40.Rg8+ Kh6 41.Bf3 Rg6



Throughout the game I had kept a reasonable advantage, but after some good defence Black is relatively close to a draw, despite the material disadvantage. However, when both sides are low on time the chances of missing a

tactical detail become much higher, and my next move set up a trap.

42.Re8!? Be5? Clearly Black's idea, and what I was hoping for.

42...Rg5! is the engine's choice, which by the look of it essentially secures the draw.

43.c5! A nice tactical shot that puts Black under serious pressure. My opponent will win the g3-pawn, but can't stop my pawn from reaching c6.

43...Bxg3 43...Rxc3+ was the alternative, but after 44.Kf2 h4 45.c6 Black is really struggling to hold. A sample line is 45...Rg7 46.Ke3! Kg5 47.Bg2! Kg4 48.d4 Bf6 49.Ke4 h3 50.Bh1 h2 51.Rb8!, and the threat of Rb7 is very unpleasant.

44.c6 d5! Good defence by Black to give up the d-pawn.

45.Bxd5



45...Bd6+?! 45...h4 is supposedly Black's last holding chance, but playing this kind of position accurately is a tough ask in classical chess, let alone rapidplay.

46.Kf3 Kg5 47.Rd8 White's immediate threat is Rxd6 and c7.

47...Be5 48.Rd7 Rd6



49.c7! Black must either allow promotion or give up the bishop; either option leaves White with a fairly easy technical win.

49...Rxd7 49...Rf6+ 50.Ke4 Bxc7 51.Rxc7+--.

50.c8Q Rg7 50...Rxd5 51.Qg8++-- to win the rook is a nice final point.

51.Ke4 Ba1 52.Qc1+ 1-0

In our round 2 match we got to play one of the favourites for the entire tournament: Hexamind Chess Team, who boasted super-GMs Aronian, Murzin, Giri, Vidit and Dominguez in their squad. Our 6-0 loss was disappointing, but not surprising; Marcus came closest to a result, getting into a pawn-up endgame against Aronian before faltering.

Harvey, Marcus R (2460) - Aronian, Levon (2746)
2025 FIDE World Rapid Team Championship London,
United Kingdom (2.49), 11.06.2025

1.Nf3 Nf6 2.b3 g6 3.Bb2 Bg7 4.g3 d5 5.c4 dxc4 6.bxc4 c5 7.Bg2 0-0 8.d3 Nc6 9.0-0 Qc7 10.Nc3 Rd8 11.Nb5 Qb8 12.Nd2 Bd7 13.Rb1 b6 14.Nc3 Qc8 15.Re1 Bh3 16.Bh1 Qd7 17.Nd5 Rac8 18.Nxf6+ Bxf6 19.Bxf6 exf6 20.Ne4 Kg7 21.Qc1 h5 22.Qb2 Qe7 23.Nc3 h4 24.Nd5 Qd6 25.f4 Rh8 26.Kf2 Rcd8?



Aronian has undoubtedly outplayed Marcus in the first 25 moves, but his last was a surprising mistake. 26...Nb4 was better.

27.Qxf6+! Exploiting the undefended knight on c6.

27...Qxf6 28.Nxf6 Nd4 29.Nd5 Bf5 30.Bg2 Rde8 It would be easy for either side to panic here, and it is impressive that neither does so. White's best path to winning this is a gradual consolidation in the centre, while Black should avoid creating further weaknesses, and look to exploit any small mistake.

31.e3 Nc6 32.Rbd1 Rd8 33.a3 g5 34.Bf3 34.Rh1!



34...Rd6 34...hgx3+ 35.hgx3 Rh2+ 36.Bg2 Bh3 was the best way to continue. After **37.Rg1** White is quite tied down, and struggles to make progress.

35.g4 Bc8 36.f5 Maybe a bit impatient. **36.h3!**, and Black is starting to struggle.

36...Ne5 37.Be2 Bb7 38.d4!?



Things get very concrete after this move. **38.e4** was the more solid alternative.

38...cxd4 39.exd4 Nxc4! 40.f6+! Marcus finds the one continuation to keep an advantage.

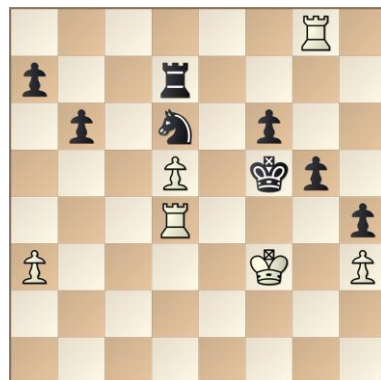
40...Kh6 41.Ne7! Rxf6+ 42.Nf5+ Rxf5+ 43.gxf5 Nd6



We reach this endgame essentially by force after move 39. White is still doing well with best play; however, Aronian quickly takes charge in instructive fashion.

44.Bf3 44.Rc1!

44...Bxf3 45.Kxf3 Nxf5 46.d5 Rd8 47.Rd3 Kg6 48.h3 Rd7 49.Re8 Nd6 50.Rg8+ Kf5 51.Rd4 f6

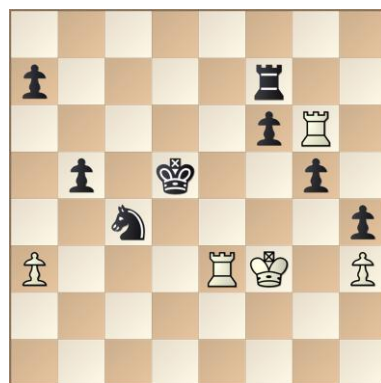


The evaluation remains equal, but the last five moves have clearly gone Black's way.

52.Rd3 b5 53.Ke2 Ke5 54.Re3+ Kxd5 55.Rg6?! 55.Rd3+ Ke6 56.Rf8 is supposedly still equal.

55...Rf7 56.Kf3? 56.Rg8.

56...Nc4



Suddenly, out of nowhere Black is winning at least an exchange due to the fork on e5.

57.Rd3+ Kc5 58.Ke4 f5+ A very unfortunate finish for Marcus. Nonetheless, part of the unique appeal of these events is getting to play over the board against world-class opposition, and I'm sure he will look back on this game fondly. **0-1**

Next, we beat English Knightmares 4-2 in round 3, before losing to Rishon Le Zion of Israel by the same scoreline in round 4. What the first day showed us was that creating upsets in team events was not easy at all, given that

multiple individual results would have to go our way. Nevertheless, we went into the second day with some optimism about where we would finish.

Unfortunately, day 2 of the rapid was a bit of a disaster for both the team and me. I had a disappointing two draws and two losses in four rounds, probably leaving a full point on the table, while the team as a whole also underperformed. We started well with a 4½-1½ win against the Wood Green Youth team, before another 6-0 loss in round 6 dampened our spirits. We then finished the day with two underwhelming results (a 3-3 draw, followed by a 4-2 loss) against two Mongolian teams that we outrated. The pick of our games from day 2 was probably Jonah's win in round 5 against IM-elect Freddie Gordon of Wood Green Youth.

Willow, Jonah B (2322) - Waldhausen Gordon, Frederick (2153)

2025 FIDE World Rapid Team Championship (5.28),
12.06.2025

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bb5 a6 4.Ba4 Nf6 5.O-O Be7 6.Bxc6 dxc6 7.d3 Bd6 8.h3 O-O 9.Bg5 h6 10.Bh4 c5 11.Nbd2 Be6 12.Re1 g5 13.Bg3 Nd7 14.Nc4 Qf6 15.Nh2 Qg6 16.Ng4 f6 17.Nge3 Rad8 18.a4 Nb8 19.Qf3 Nc6 20.c3 h5 21.Nf5 g4 22.hxg4 hxg4 23.Qd1 Kf7 24.Nce3 Rh8 25.Qxg4 Qxg4 26.Nxg4 Bxf5 27.exf5 Ne7 28.Ne3 Rh5 29.Kf1 Nxf5 30.Nxf5 Rxf5 31.Ke2 Rh5 32.Rh1 Rdh8 33.Rxh5 Rxh5

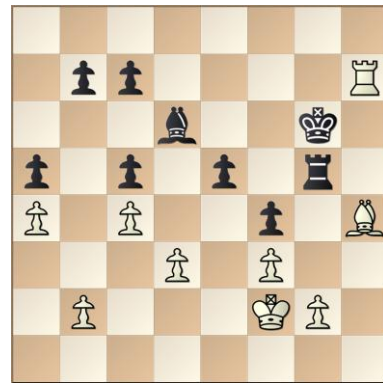


The endgame is definitely equal, but Jonah does well to create a small edge before ruthlessly punishing a single mistake.

34.c4 A good start, fixing Black's queenside pawns on dark squares.

34...a5 35.f3 Rg5 36.Kf2 f5 36...Rh5 in hindsight, returning to the h-file, was probably simplest.

37.Rh1 f4 38.Rh7+! Kg6 39.Bh4!



A nice idea, setting Black an uncomfortable choice. He can either exchange rooks or keep them on the board, but remains under pressure in every line.

39...Rh5 39...Rf5! 40.Rd7 Rf7! was the best way to force the rook trade; **39...Rxg2+?** looks tempting, but White is actually winning after **40.Kxg2 Kxh7 41.Kh3 Kg6 42.Kg4+**. This is nearly identical to the game, but without White's g-pawn.

40.Rxh5 Kxh5 41.Bd8 Black is always going to be under heavy pressure in this endgame, and is already in the 'zone of one mistake', where any slight inaccuracy will likely cost the game.

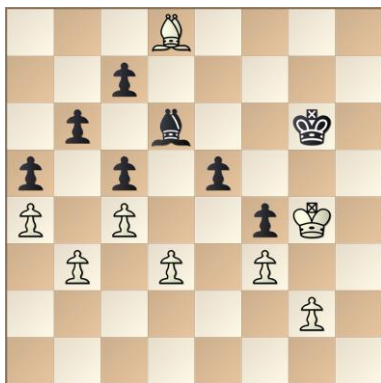
41...Kg6 42.Kg1



42...Kh6? **42...Kf7!** **43.Kh2 Ke8!** **44.Bh4 Kf7 45.Kh3 Be7!** is Black's only way to draw.

43.Kh2 Kg6 44.Kh3 Kh5 45.Bh4 Bf8 46.Bf6 Bd6 47.Bd8 A nice triangulation by the bishop, after which Black is in Zugzwang and has to concede ground on the kingside.

47...Kh6 48.Kh4 b6 49.b3 Kg6 50.Kg4



Black can't stop the invasion on the f5-square, after which he will start to lose material.

50...Kh6 51.Kf5 Kh5 52.Bf6 A really nice endgame by Jonah. **1-0**

We thankfully managed to leave behind the disappointment of day 2 with a much-improved showing on day 3: we bounced back with wins in round 9 and 10 before narrowly losing to Generation XYZA in round 11. They were a team headlined by Mamedyarov on board 1 and prodigies Ediz Gurel and Yagiz Kaan Erdogmus on 2 and 3. Maciej's win in round 9 was probably the most convincing win by any of us across the Rapid event.

Czopor, Maciej (2382) - Muetsch, Annmarie (2188)

2025 FIDE World Rapid Team Championship (9.27),
13.06.2025

1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 e5 4.Nf3 Nbd7 5.Rg1 c6 6.g4 h6 7.Be3 Qa5 8.Nd2 Be7 9.d5 cxd5 10.Nb3 Qd8 11.exd5 Nf8 12.h4 N6h7 13.Ne4 Nf6 14.Nxf6+ Bxf6 15.g5 hxg5 16.hxg5 Be7 17.Bd3 Bd7 18.Qe2



Maciej played the trendy 5.Rg1 against the Philidor, and reached this interesting position with an advantage on both the board and the clock.

18...a5 18...Ng6 was best. After 18...a5 White gets a powerful initiative across the board.

19.Nd2 Rb8 20.0-0-0 b5 21.f4! Blasting open the centre.

21...a4 22.Ne4 a3



23.b3 23.fxe5 was even stronger, but b3 kept full control of the position, and was an easy move to make quickly in a rapid format.

23...Ng6 24.fxe5 Nxe5 25.Bd4 Qc7 26.g6 26.Bxe5! dxe5 27.d6! won on the spot, e.g. 27...Bxd6 28.Nxd6+ Qxd6 29.Bf5, and White wins at least a piece.

26...f6 27.Bxe5 fxe5 28.Rg1! Kd8 29.Rf7!



The invasion onto the seventh rank puts far too much pressure on the black position.

29...Re8 30.Rdf1 Kc8 31.Rxg7 Bf8 32.Rh7 After this move the game looks essentially over. Nevertheless, I saw plenty of games throughout the week where one side managed to salvage a completely hopeless position. Maciej does well to prevent any counter-chances for the rest of the game.

32...Kb7 33.Bxb5 Be7 34.Bxd7 Qxd7



35.Nf6! Qc7 36.Nxe8 Qc3 37.Qb5+ A really well played game by Maciej, and a crucial one for the team given that we won the match 3½–2½. **1–0**

Unfortunately we concluded the Rapid section with a pretty poor 5-1 loss against Sharks 4NCL, leaving us in a disappointing 34th place out of 53 teams. However, there was plenty of success for the other English teams: Malcolm's Mates finished in the top 10, while Sharks, Chess Rising Stars, e-therapeutics and Wood Green Youth all finished on at least 50%. Meanwhile Hammersmith Chess Club managed to win the £5,000 U2200 rating prize with 11 match points, despite being among the lowest seeded teams. On an individual basis, some of the most impressive English performances were: IM Aaravamudhan Balaji (Wood Green Youth, 9½/12 and with a 2537 TPR); IM Richard Pert (e-therapeutics, 7/8, 2566 TPR); GM Ameet Ghasi (Sharks 4NCL, 7/12, 2560 TPR); and Kai Hanache (Hammersmith, 6/9, 2252 TPR and gaining over 100 rating points).

As for the overall event, the predominantly Indian Team MGD1 won outright with 21 match points out of a possible 24, and were absolutely deserving winners. Their stand-out performers were GM V Pranav with 7½/8 and a TPR near 2900 playing on board 4, and P Tayade Atharvaa with an incredible 11/12 (including 11 consecutive wins!) on the amateur board. Hexamind and Freedom took home the silver and bronze medals respectively.

After three intense days of chess we then moved on to the Blitz section. With 13 rounds scheduled to be played over the course of six hours, the Rapid event seemed sedate by comparison. It also put a huge amount of strain on both the live board operators and the arbiters, who all things considered did a pretty good job of keeping the event running smoothly.

The section was split into four groups of 13 or 14, and the top four from each group would qualify for Sunday's knock-out bracket. We were put in group B as the sixth or seventh seed behind Freedom, Hexamind, Malcolm's Mates, Theme International Trading and Rishon Le Zion,

while we were about on a par with the Sharks, whom we would be playing again. Qualification was therefore an outside shot, but by no means impossible; unfortunately, we dug ourselves into a massive hole with a first-round 3½-2½ loss to Sassy Seniors, another English team. I just about won my first-round game, but found the adjustment from 15'+10" to 3'+2" incredibly tough, and I'm sure that I was not alone in this.

We then proceeded to win our next two rounds, before getting crushed by Hexamind for the second time in the event in round 4 (we at least got a half-point this time, as Maciej impressively drew with Vidit on board 3). In round 5 we were paired against Malcolm's Mates, and scored a 4-2 upset in what was undoubtedly our best performance of the entire week. Marcus, Jonah and Maciej defeated GMs Adams, Vitiugov and Saric on the top 3 boards, with Marcus' win the pick of the games.

(5) Adams, Michael (2700) - Harvey, Marcus R (2449) B12

2025 FIDE World Blitz Team Championship London, United Kingdom (5.19), 14.06.2025

1.e4 c6 2.d4 d5 3.e5 Bf5 4.Bd3 Bxd3 5.Qxd3 e6 6.Ne2 c5 7.c3 Nc6 8.0-0 a6 9.Be3 cxd4 10.cxd4 Nge7 11.Ng3 Qb6 12.Nd2 Qb5 13.Qc2 Rc8 14.Qd1 Qd3 15.Nf3 Qxd1 16.Rfxd1 Nf5 17.Nxf5 exf5 18.h4 Be7 19.h5 h6 20.Ne1 Nd8 21.Rac1 Rxc1 22.Rxc1 Kd7 23.Nd3 Ne6 24.Kf1



Marcus has equalised with Black relatively comfortably, and from this move onwards starts to put Mickey under pressure.

24...g5! 25.hxg6 fxg6 Black has a simple plan of a gradual kingside advance, while White's best play is a lot more uncertain. The protected passed e5-pawn looks nice, but is easily contained.

26.Nf4 Nxf4 27.Bxf4 g5 28.Bd2 b6 29.Ke2 29.e6+! would have been better with hindsight, as White gets good activity after 29...Kxe6 30.Rc6+ Kd7 31.Rxb6.

29...Rc8 30.Bc3 30.e6+! Kd8 31.Rh1! was another interesting option.

30...b5 31.Rh1 Bf8 32.Kd3 Ke6 33.g3 Kf7 34.Bd2 Rc6 35.Ra1 Kg6

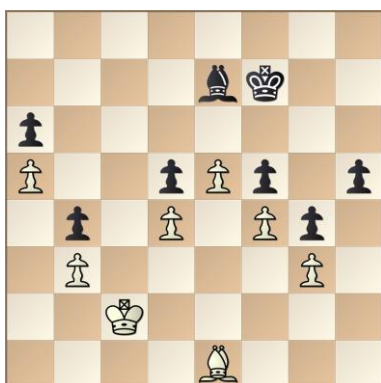


A good reorganisation by Marcus.

36.a4 b4 37.a5?! In the long term the a5-pawn proves to be a lot weaker than the b4-pawn. 37.b3=.

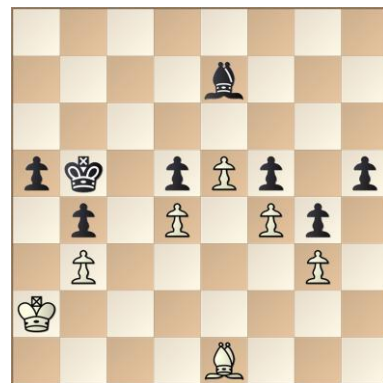
37...h5 38.f4?! g4! 39.Rh1 Be7 40.b3 Rc8 41.Rh2 Rh8 41...h4! immediately was very strong.

42.Be1 Rc8 43.Rc2? Rxc2! 44.Kxc2 Kf7



The bishop ending is simply winning for Black, who can grab the a5-pawn before preparing simultaneous a5–a4 and h5–h4 breaks.

45.Kd3 Ke6 46.Kc2 Kd7 47.Kb2 Kc6 48.Kc2 Kb5 49.Kb2 Kxa5 50.Kc2 Kb5 51.Kb2 a5 52.Ka2



52...Kc6 52...a4!. Marcus decided to bring his king back to the kingside before opening up the position, but an immediate a4 was the clearest way to win. 53.Kb2 a3+ 54.Ka2 Bf8 55.Bd2 Bh6 56.Be1 h4! 57.gxh4 Bxf4 58.h5 Be3→.

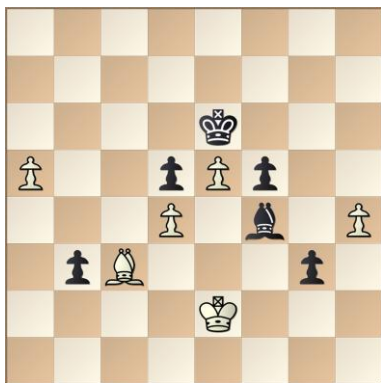
53.Kb2 Kd7 54.Kc2 Ke6 55.Kb2 Kf7 56.Kc2 Kg6 57.Kd3 Bf8 58.Ke2 Kh6 59.Kd3 Kh7 60.Ke2 Kg8 61.Kd3 Kf7 62.Ke2 Ke6 63.Kd3 Kd7 64.Kc2 Be7 65.Kd3 Ke6 66.Kc2 Bf8 67.Kd3 Bh6 68.Bd2



68...h4? After a prolonged period of manoeuvring, Marcus eventually decided to make this break. White can actually draw with best play, but under serious time pressure this was close to impossible.

69.gxh4 g3 70.Ke2 a4! The idea, creating a second advanced passed pawn.

71.bxa4 b3 72.Bc3 Bxf4 73.a5?



73.Bb2!, and White is in time to draw; if anything, Black has to be a little careful. 73...g2 74.Kf2 Bg3+! 75.Kxg2 Bxh4 76.a5, and White should not lose.

73...Bd2!! A really nice winning move. Capturing the bishop either way allows a promotion.

74.a6 g2 75.a7 g1Q 76.a8Q Both sides promote, but it is Black's move, and he is therefore able to create a mating net first.

76...Qe1+ 77.Kf3 Qf1+ 78.Kg3 Bf4#



0-1

Round 6 saw us hold Rishon Le Zion to a 3-3 draw that could have gone either way, followed by a 4½-1½ loss to Theme International Trading of Singapore in round 8. The latter match essentially ended our hopes of qualifying; nonetheless, we finished the event well with four consecutive wins before a 5-1 loss to Freedom in the final round. We therefore finished fifth in Group B on 15 match points, an impressive performance by the team and a good recovery from the underwhelming Rapid performance. Across the other groups, Malcom's Mates were the only English team to qualify for the knock-out stages; other strong English performers were Wood Green Youth and e-therapeutics, finishing seventh and eighth respectively in Group C, and English Knightmares finishing eighth in Group D.

You can always count on shorter time controls to introduce an element of randomness to proceedings, and therefore there were plenty of impressive upsets scored by English players. Ben Purton's win over GM Saric was a very nice example, with a fantastic tactical shot to conclude the game.

Saric, Ivan (2597) - Purton, Ben J (2185)

2025 FIDE World Rapid Team Championship (10.52),
13.06.2025

1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 c6 4.f4 Qa5 5.e5 Ne4 6.Qf3 d5 7.Bd3 g6 8.Nge2 h5 9.0-0 Nxc3 10.bxc3 Bg4 11.Qe3 e6 12.Bd2 Qc7 13.c4 dxc4 14.Bxc4 Nd7 15.Rab1 Nb6 16.Bd3 Bf5 17.Nc3 Rd8 18.Ne4 Be7 19.c4 Qd7 20.Bc3 c5 21.d5 exd5 22.Nd6+ Kf8 23.Nxf5 d4 24.e6 Qc7 25.Qe4 dxc3 26.Nxe7 Qxe7 27.f5



Up to this point Saric has played a good game, and is significantly better after 27.f5. Nevertheless, Ben does a great job of fighting back over the next few moves.

27...g5 28.Qe5 28.Bc2! was a major improvement, with the idea of immediately contesting the d-file.

28...f6 29.Qxc3 Rd4! 30.Be2 Kg7 31.Rbd1 Rhd8



Black is still clearly worse, but there are now definite signs of counterplay.

32.Bxh5?! 32.Qb3.

32...Nxc4 33.Be2 Ne5 The knight is fantastic on e5, and Black has clearly gained more from winning the c4-pawn than White has done from winning h5.

34.Rde1 b6 35.Bb5 R8d5 36.Qg3 c4! Another well-timed move.

37.a4 Nd3 38.Re3 Nf4 39.Qg4



Black is winning with best play here; however, both sides had less than a minute on the clock, and the position is exceptionally complicated. It is therefore no surprise that the evaluation swings wildly over the next couple of moves.

39...Rd3 39...Qc5! 40.e7 Re4!, and Black wins material.

40.Re4 Qc5+ 41.Kh1 Rxf5 42.e7?



Tempting, but wrong.

42.Bxc4! keeps full control, and White should win with e6–e7 next move. **42...Nh3**, and Ben's idea from the game no longer works due to **43.Qxf5! Qxf5 44.Rxf5 Rd1+ 45.Bf1**.

42...Nh3!! An exceptional move, after which White is simply lost. White surprisingly has no way to solve his back rank issues and deal with the nasty threat of **Qg1+**.

43.e8N+ Not a bad try by White.

43.Ree1 Qg1+! 44.Rxg1 Nf2#



would have been a particularly nice potential finish.

43...Kf8 However, after this calm move White has no further checks, and the game is over. **0–1**

The final day saw the 16 qualifying teams enter a knock-out bracket. Teams played two matches against each other, followed by a third match and then an Armageddon eliminator if necessary. Malcolm's Mates unfortunately drew the top seeded WR team in the round of 16, where they lost 5-1 and then 4½-1½ to be eliminated and end English hopes of the title. WR made it all the way to the final (admittedly with some controversy after one of their quarter-final matches was replayed – see Leonard Barden's recent Guardian article <https://www.theguardian.com/sport/2025/jun/20/star-studded-wr-chess-repeat-world-blitz-title-amid-controversy-in-london> for further details), where they defeated KazChess 4-2 in both matches. Hexamind took the bronze medal after beating Uzbekistan in the third/fourth play-off, while MGD1 and Freedom respectively completed the top six.

In conclusion, playing the World Team Rapid and Blitz was an incredible experience, and I feel very lucky that such a prestigious event was held so locally. I want to thank my captain IM Lawrence Cooper for his work in organising both Wood Green teams, as well as my team-mates for making this event such a positive experience. Credit should also go to the ECF for their work throughout the event, and especially to the huge number of arbiters and other volunteers who made the event possible.

Hammersmith Chess Club Wins the U2200 Category at the FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Teams Championships 2025

by Gaston Franco

As soon as our club's committee read the announcement of the World Championships coming to London we began to daydream about participating. Imagine our reaction later on to hearing it would take place less than ten minutes away from our venue! We simply could not miss this opportunity, quickly signed up, and started assembling our team. Our squad included nine players who regularly represent our club in the local leagues, but as the club with the largest membership base in London we wish we could have included twice as many players!



Back row (left to right): Aryaman Ganguly, Alistair Hill, CM Thomas Villiers, Ashley Stewart

Front row (left to right): Maria-Alexandra Ciocan, Marco Gallana, Gaston Franco, Kai Hanache, Gesneria-Codruta Cepoi

The Rapid event was a 12-round Swiss played over three days (11th-13th June) and, as expected, the first two were tough for us, as we were playing mostly against higher-rated teams from around the world which included some familiar faces too, such as our round 1 match against GM Shreyas Royal's Rookies or our pairing against English Knightmares in round 4, both of which ended in defeat. We did score a couple of upsets, but ended the second day with two losses in a row, which pushed us to the bottom board for round 9 on day 3.

These results were not discouraging at all, and we entered the last day knowing it was our chance to improve our score, as is usual in Swiss tournaments. Two wins in a row put us in front of the competition for the U2200 category prize, and our players were in top form. We managed to overcome a round 11 loss by defeating the higher-rated Oxbridge team in the last match, which was in itself not enough to guarantee us the prize. We finished our day by watching a rook endgame in another match to find out if the result we needed (a draw) would materialise. After the last pawn was traded it was time to celebrate a prize at a World Championship!



Our club has come a long way from the days when we only had 20 members about a decade ago. As the team captain I am immensely proud of my players, all of whom made a critical contribution to our score at one point or another. I would not want to single out anyone in particular at the expense of the rest, but if I had to pick a game it would be from our board 2 CM Tom Villiers, who scored 3/3 on the last day, including our only win against a GM, even if it was not enough to prevent us losing our match against Natasha Regan's Sassy Seniors, who also bested us in the Blitz section.

Villiers, Thomas (2108) – Parker, Jonathan F (2506) [C70]
Round 11: Hammersmith Chess Club – Sassy Seniors

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 g6 5. O-O Bg7 6. c3 Nge7 7. d4 exd4 8. cxd4 b5 9. Bc2 d5 10. exd5 Nb4 11. Bb3 Nbx d5 12. Bg5 f6 13. Bh4 O-O 14. Re1 Kh8 15. Nc3 c6 16. Ne4 Nf5 17. Bg3 Nxd3 18. hxd3 Bg4 19. Qc1 Qb6 20. Nc5 Rae8 21. Qd2 a5 22. Rxe8 Rxe8 23. Re1 Qd8 24. Rxe8+ Qxe8 25. Qxa5 Bxf3 26. gxf3 f5 27. Bxd5 cxd5 28. Qd2 h5 29. b3 Kh7 30. a4 bxa4 31. bxa4 Bh6 32. Qb2 Qe1+ 33. Kg2 f4 34. Qb7+ Kh8 35. Qc8+ Kh7 36. Qd7+ Kh8 37. Ne6 Qb1 38. Qe8+ Kh7 39. Qf7+ Kh8 40. Nxf4 Bxf4 41. Qxf4 Qc2 42. a5 Qc6 43. Qf8+ Kh7 44. Qc5 1-0

The closing ceremony felt surreal, surrounded as we were by famous players and sitting directly next to the lovely

GM David Navara, who congratulated us on our performance. We walked up to the stage to receive our award, and it was not over yet, since one of us even won an individual prize as well: 12 year old Aryaman Ganguly received a bronze medal from the hands of Vishy Anand himself!



Aryaman Ganguly with his bronze medal, Gaston Franco with the team prize

The FIDE presenter at the ceremony, WIM Charlize van Zyl, also made reference to our status as the biggest club in London. She and her media crew had visited our club night on the previous Monday and interviewed a few of our members, as published on [FIDE's YouTube channel](#). We felt their organisation was fantastic – perhaps with some minor delays or logistical challenges, which are to be expected of an event of this magnitude, and which did not take away from our enjoyment. Our thanks go not only to FIDE, but also of course to the ECF, to all the arbiters and supporting staff, and last but not least to all the volunteers at the venue, some of whom are even Hammersmith members. They all contributed to an amazing atmosphere and an unforgettable experience.

Cotswold Chess Congress 2025

by Michael Ashworth

During the May Bank Holiday weekend (24th -26th May) the 55th Cotswold Chess Congress was held at King's School in Gloucester. The school, being in the centre of Gloucester, provides an ideal location, with players able to enjoy the local bars, restaurants and sights of the city in between rounds, making for an enjoyable weekend both on and off the board.



Ben Ogunshola, organiser of the 1st Swindon Chess Congress: <https://swindonchessevents.co.uk/> - picture by Kevin Markey

130 players competed across three well-contested sections (Open, Major and Minor), with all three sections being both FIDE- and ECF-rated. A total of 23 juniors took part in the congress (eight in the Open, six in the Major, and nine in the Minor). As a result of a generous grant from the John Robinson Youth Chess Trust, the congress was able to provide a bursary to the juniors who took part this year. Two of the three sections were won, either outright or jointly, by junior players.



Zack Norris, Open section winner and 2025 Gloucestershire Individual Chess Champion

Here is a round-up of each of the sections.

Open Section

The Open had a total of 43 players taking part, with 17 eligible for the title of Gloucestershire Champion, awarded to the highest-placed Gloucestershire player in the congress. The competition was very tight going into the last round, with Zack Norris picking up first prize and the Gloucestershire Champion title. At the age of 12 Zack is one of the country's strongest junior talents, and his performance in this tournament demonstrated a tremendous amount of chess maturity.

A summary of all the Open prize-winners is as follows:

=1st: Zack Norris (5/6) (Gloucestershire County Individual Champion 2025)

=2nd: Oliver Stubbs and Joe Varley (4½/6)

=4th: David Spence, Ben Ogunshola, Michael Ashworth, Chris Beaumont, Daniel Gomez, Stephen Homer, Bruce Baer and Robert Ashworth (4/6)

Rating prizes:

Under 2050: Robert Ashworth (4/6)

Under 1900: Spencer Lawrence (3½/6)

Other notable mentions:

Top junior score by a non-cash prize-winner: Finn Schell (3½/6)

Top score by a female player: Shambavi Hariharan (3½/6)

Major Section

The Major was the largest of the three sections this year, consisting of 46 players. The winners were Hayden Griffiths and Tommy Wilkins, both of whom represent the University of Bristol. A summary of the prize-winners in the Major section is as follows:

=1st: Hayden Griffiths and Tommy Wilkins (5/6)

=3rd: Alexis Kristoff Malibiran, Laurence Tarbuck and Kevin Winter (4½/6)

Rating prizes:

Under 1721: David Rogers (4/6)

Under 1650: Aarav Swansh Mehta (3½/6)

Other notable mentions:

Top junior score by a non-cash prize-winner: Anay Misra (3½/6)

Top score by a female player: Lynne Fursman (3½/6)

Minor Section

The Minor had 41 competitors taking part. As with the other two sections, the top score was 5/6, shared by three players, two of whom are juniors. The complete list of Minor section prize winners is below:

=1st: Aviraj Bhaduri, Paul Foster and Dexter Wildsmith (5/6)

4th: Tom Cleverley (4½/6)

Rating prizes:

Under 1500: Gary Brown (4/6)

Under 1360: Jenny Gartside (3/6)

Other notable mentions:

Top junior score by a non-cash prize-winner: Noah Taylor (4/6)

Top score by a female player: Christine Constable (4/6)

Christine was also the winner of the book prize given as the top score by a female in any section (other than cash prize winners).

Andrew Farthing ran a charity bookstall, and reported: 'I was absolutely delighted by the outcome. Over the three days I sold 169 books (and a few magazines) for a grand total of £861. This was easily the best result of any of my bookstalls at the Cotswold Congress. Since it was a personal fundraising initiative to help the charity I'll be able to Gift Aid it, so St Richard's Hospice will actually receive nearly £1,100.'



CHARITY CHESS BOOKSTALL

Raising Funds for



St. Richard's Hospice
CARING FOR LIFE

Andrew Farthing and his charity bookstall (top)

St Richard's Hospice logo (bottom)

You can find more photos of the congress here:
<https://brendanogorman.smugmug.com/Chess/2025/Cotswold-Open-2025>

We look forward to hosting an equally successful congress in 2026.

Hampshire Women's Individual Championship 2024/2025

The Hampshire Chess Association held a new competition for 2024/2025. One of our aims is to grow chess in Hampshire, and specifically to increase the number of female players. With this in mind we introduced the HCA Women's Individual Championship.

The format of the competition was a double-round all play all at players' clubs or homes between October 2024 and May 2025. This is along the same lines as the current Southampton Individual Championship.

Five players entered the Championship, with a mixture of youth and experience among the entrants.

Player	Club
Gillian Moore	Southampton Chess Club
Helen Archer-Lock	Southampton University Chess Club
Rose Saunders	Chandler's Ford Chess Club
Megan Birch	Basingstoke Chess Club
Rosamund Hale	Southampton Chess Club

The time control was the same as the current Southampton Chess League matches: 80 minutes + 10 second increments. Rose Saunders withdrew after playing the other players once, and these remaining fixtures were recorded as default wins.

This is not the first time a Hampshire Women's Individual Championship has been held, but the last one was in 1961, and, although started, that Championship was never completed. But there is a link between the two competitions, as a young Gillian Moore played in 1961, and also played in this season's Championship. You can read about the history of the event at the link below:
[Hampshire Individual Chess Championship 1961 – Hampshire Chess History](#)

The players were a mixture of youth and experience, although with the two oldest competitors, Gillian and Rose, their chess experience are at the two ends of the

spectrum. Gillian has been playing for more than 65 years, whilst Rose only started playing in 2017. A brief profile of each of the players is below.

Rose Saunders

Rose Saunders and her husband Steve joined Chandler's Ford chess club in 2017, and have played league and internal tournaments since then. Rose and Steve also play a lot of online chess, especially against each other. I wonder if many others on Lichess have played another opponent more than 5,000 times, which Rose and Steve have done. I put a bit of pressure on Rose to play in the Championship, and it was always going to be a struggle against players rated 400 to 700 points higher than her, but Rose enjoyed the games she played.



Steve and Rose Saunders

Rosamund Hale

Rosamund has only been playing rated chess since 2022. She scored 1½ out of 2 against Megan Birch, finishing with three points. Rosamund is pictured below from the 2023 Hampshire Congress, where she jointly won the Gillian Moore Cup for the best performance in the congress.



Rosamund Hale

Helen Archer-Lock

Helen plays for Southampton University, and has been playing competitive chess since 2011, when she played in several Under 9 championships. She recently jointly won the 2025 Frome Under 1750 congress, and her rating is now close to approaching 1750.

Helen went through the tournament undefeated, with three wins and four draws from her seven games played. An excellent result, but one person had an even better performance, which stopped Helen winning the Championship.



Helen Archer-Lock

Helen also jointly won the Gillian Moore Cup in 2023.

Megan Birch

Megan Birch plays for Basingstoke, and is another fast improving player, with her rating now also approaching 1750. With her rating under 1600 in September 2024, this highlights the progress she has made.

Megan probably underperformed in the Championship, but will certainly be challenging for the title if she enters again.

Picture below from the 2024 Hampshire Chess Congress, where Megan won the Minor with maximum points, and not surprisingly won the Gillian Moore Cup at the same time.



Megan Birch, Hampshire Chess Congress 2024

Gillian Moore

Gillian had an outstanding tournament, winning five games and just drawing her two games against Helen. Gillian has a wealth of chess experience, having played for more than 60 years, and is a previous joint British Ladies Champion (1966) and British Under 18 Girls Champion twice - in 1962 and 1963 (shared). Gillian also won the British Over 60 Women's Championship in 2015, and shared the Over 65 event in 2022.

Gillian also holds the record for most prolific Hampshire county player, representing Hampshire more than 300 times from 1960 to 2025. This is even more remarkable given that she only played seven times from 1968 to 2000.

Do read Gillian's profile on the Hampshire Chess History website, as this has additional information, and includes a published CHESS Magazine article on her.



Gillian Moore aged 22 with Rosebowl trophy

Final Table

The final crosstable and links to the tournament can be found here:

- [Standings](#)
- [ECF Tournament Details](#)

Games from the Tournament

Saunders, Rose (1084) - Birch, Megan (1502)

1.d4 c5 2.d5 e6 3.e4 exd5 4.Qxd5 Nf6 5.Qd3 Nc6 6.a3 Ne5 7.Qe2 Be7 8.Nc3 0-0 9.Bd2 a6 10.0-0-0 b5 11.Kb1 b4



12.Na4 bxa3 13.b3 c4 14.Ka2 Qc7 15.Rb1 Rb8 16.b4 a5 17.c3 axb4 18.cxb4 Nd3 19.Kxa3 Qa7 20.Be3 Qa5 21.Qd2 Bxb4+ 22.Rxb4 Rxb4 23.Qc2 Rb3+ 24.Qxb3 cxb3 25.Kxb3 Ne5 26.Bc5 Nxe4 27.Bb4 Qd5+ 28.Bc4 Qxc4+ 29.Ka3 Nxf2

30.Nb2 Qa6+ 31.Kb3 d6 32.h3 Be6+ 33.Kc2 Rc8+ 34.Bc3 Qc6 35.Ne2 Nxb1 36.Kd2 Nc4+ 37.Kc2 Nxb2 38.Kxb2 Ng3 0-1

Moore, Gillian A (1628) – Archer-Lock, Helen (1682)

1.d4 f5 2.Bg5 g6 3.e3 Bg7 4.c3 Nf6 5.Nd2 d6 6.Bc4 a6 7.a4 e5 8.dxe5 dxe5 9.Qc2 Qe7 10.Ngf3 Nc6 11.0-0 Be6 12.Bxe6 Qxe6 13.Qb3 Qxb3 14.Nxb3 Nd7



15.Bh4 h6 16.Bg3 0-0 17.h4 Rae8 18.Rfe1 Re6 19.Rad1 Rd6 20.Rxd6 cxd6 21.Rd1 Rf6 22.Bh2 Nb6 23.Ra1 Nc4 24.Rb1 Rf8 25.Nbd2 Nxd2 26.Nxd2 d5 27.Nb3 Bf6 28.Bg3 b6 29.f3 Rd8 30.Rd1 d4 31.cxd4 exd4 32.exd4 Nxd4 33.Nxd4 Rxd4 34.Rxd4 Bxd4+ 35.Bf2 ½-½

Birch, Megan (1524) - Moore, Gillian A (1636)

1.d4 d5 2.c4 Nc6 3.Nf3 Bg4 4.e3 e6 5.Nc3 Nf6 6.Be2 Be7 7.0-0 0-0 8.a3 Ne4 9.Nxe4 dxe4 10.Nd2 Bxe2 11.Qxe2 f5 12.b4 Bf6 13.Bb2 Ne7 14.f3 exf3 15.Nxf3 Ng6 16.Rad1 c6 17.a4 Qc7 18.Nd2 Rad8 19.e4 f4 20.Nf3 e5 21.d5 Qb6+ 22.Rf2 Qxb4 23.Qc2 cxd5 24.cxd5 Rc8 25.Qd3 Qc4 26.d6 Qxd3 27.Rxd3 Rfd8 28.Rfd2 Kf7 29.Rc3 Rxc3 30.Bxc3 Ke6 31.Bb4 Nf8 32.Rc2 Rd7 33.Rc7 Ng6 34.Rc4 Nh8 35.Nd2 Nf7 36.Nb3 b6 37.Rc6 Bd8 38.a5 g5 39.axb6 axb6 40.Nd2 Nxd6?



41.Nc4 Bc7 42.Bxd6 Bxd6 43.Nxb6 Rc7 44.Rxc7 Bxc7 45.Nd5 Bb8 46.Kf2 g4 47.h3 h5 48.hxg4 hxg4 49.Ke2 Bd6 50.Kd3 Bb8 51.Ke2 Kf7 52.Kd3 Kg6 53.Ne7+ Kg5 54.Nf5

Ba7 55.Ke2 Bc5 56.g3 f3 57.N3g3 Kf4 58.Nh5+ Kxe4
59.Nf6+ Kf4 60.Nd5+ Kg3 61.Nc3 Kg2 62.Nd5 Kg1 63.Nf6
g3 64.Ne4 Bf2 65.Kf3 0-1

Hale, Rosamund (1499) - Moore, Gillian A (1628)

1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Nxd5 4.Nf3 g6 5.c4 Nb6 6.Nc3
Bg7 7.c5 Nd5 8.Bc4 Nxc3 9.bxc3 0-0 10.0-0 Nc6 11.Bf4
Na5 12.Bd3 b6 13.cxb6 axb6 14.Qc1 Bb7 15.Bh6 Rc8
16.Bxg7 Kxg7 17.Qe3 Bxf3 18.Qxf3 Qd6 19.Rfe1 Rcd8
20.Qe4 e5? 21.Qxe5+ Qxe5 22.Rxe5 c5 23.d5 c4 24.Be4
Kf6 25.f4 Rd6 26.Re1 Nb7 27.Re2 Ra8 28.Bf3 Ra3 29.R5e3
Nc5 30.Rc2 Nd3 31.g3 Nb4 32.Rb2 Nxa2



33.Be2 Nxc3 34.Bxc4 34...Ra1+ 35.Kf2 0-1

Archer-Lock, Helen (1702) - Birch, Megan (1748) [A60]

1.d4 c5 2.d5 e6 3.c4 Nf6 4.Nc3 d6 5.e4 Be7 6.Nf3 a6 7.Be2
exd5 8.cxd5 b5 9.Qc2 b4 10.Nd1 0-0 11.0-0 Bg4 12.Bg5?



12...Nxd5 13.Bxe7 Nxe7 14.Ne3 Bh5 15.Rfd1 Nbc6
16.Nc4 Nc8



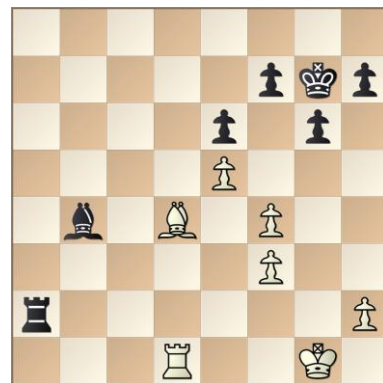
17.Nxd6 Nxd6 18.Qxc5 Bxf3 19.Bxf3 Nb7 20.Qxc6 Qc8
21.e5 Qxc6 22.Bxc6 Rab8 23.Rd5 Nd8 24.Ba4 Ne6 25.Rc1
Rfc8 26.Rxc8+ Rxc8 27.g3 g6 28.Rd6 Nc5 29.Bd1 Ne4
30.Rxa6 Rc1 31.Ra8+ Kg7 32.Rd8 Rb1 33.Rd4 Ng5 34.Kg2
Rxb2 35.Bb3 Re2 36.Rxb4 Ne4 37.Kf3 Nc3 38.Rc4 1-0

Archer-Lock, Helen (1707) - Moore, Gillian A (1645) [D07]

1.d4 d5 2.c4 Nc6 3.Nf3 Bg4 4.cxd5 Bxf3 5.dxc6 Bxc6 6.Nc3
Nf6 7.Qd3 e6 8.a3 a6 9.e4 Be7 10.Be2 0-0 11.0-0 Qd7
12.Be3 b5 13.f4 b4 14.axb4 Bxb4 15.e5 Nd5 16.Nxd5
Bxd5 7.Rxa6 Rxa6 18.Qxa6



18...Ra8 19.Qd3 Ra2 20.Bc1 g6 21.Rd1 Kg7 22.Bf3 Bxf3
23.Qxf3 Qd5 24.Qd3 Ra1 25.b3? Ra2 26.Qg3? c5 27.Be3
Qxb3 28.Qf3 cxd4 29.Bxd4 Qxf3 30.gxf3 ½-½



The Future

The Hampshire Chess Association are hoping that we

have enough interest to hold the Championship in future. We have been helped by a generous donation from Gillian Moore, and the free to enter Championship will have a small financial prize as well as a trophy.

Acknowledgement and Sources

- Britbase for Gillian Moore's British successes
- Hampshire chess archives
- The players for providing their games

South Lakes Congress 2025

by Dave Cole



The South Lakes Congress was held from 13th to 15th June in Barrow-in-Furness. The results are below:

OPEN

20 entries

1st John Potter (Belper) 4½/5

2nd Yaoyao Zhu (3Cs) 4/5

=3rd Nigel Davies (Tiger Chess), Ali Jaunooby (Eccles) 3½/5

Rating prize Alannah Ashton (3Cs)

Cumbria prize David Phillips (Kendal), Barry Hymer (Ulverston)

MAJOR

33 entries

=1st Simon Arnold (Eagle & Child), Raymond Wynczyk (Northumberland), Peter Garrett (Waterloo), Michael Allen (South Shields) 4/5

Rating prizes Paul Jackson (Coulsdon), Adrian Waldock (Ashted)

Cumbria prize Paul Rivers (Carlisle), Steve Bailey (Ulverston)

MINOR

47 entries

1st Paul Ashton (Leyland) 5/5

=2nd Simon Richards (Northwich), Neville Pearce (York), Bernard Cassidy (Glasgow) 4/5

Rating prizes Mohammed Rohman (3Cs), Michael Foss (Woking)

Cumbria prize James Ovens (Carlisle)

Durham Chess Congress 2025

by Mick Riding

163 players competed in this year's DCCA Congress over the beautifully sunny weekend of 9th to 11th May at (of course) the popular Dolphin Centre. For good measure Lola McEvoy, MP for Darlington, popped in, and did a short welcome and presentation on Saturday morning.

Friendly staff, no disputes between players (that I am aware of!), and on a personal note, never have I had so many people make the effort to say thank you before leaving! If you've read this far, please do the same the next time you go to a congress - it means a lot. And on the same note, thank you to Alex McFarlane, Carl Stephens and Tom Krause for their arbiting and general support.

The main prize-winners included:

Open: Shriaansh Ganti, Toby Quaite =1st, 4½/5

Major: Andrew Trevelyan 5/5

Minor: Gautham Sathishkumar, Alan Tunnacliffe =1st, 4½/5

There were a number of rating prizes and trophy awards, including:

Jack Erskine-Pereira, winner of the Fred Stobbs trophy for the best North East adult performance;

Gautham Sathishkumar, winner of the Gary Hewitt trophy for the best North East junior performance;

John Marsh, winner of the Tony Mezzo trophy for the best performance in the Major by a Durham League player.

A game from the winner of the Fred Stobbs trophy and some pictures follow.



Nearly ready to go - a full hall of chess players, a lovely sight!



Lola McEvoy formally presenting trophies to last year's Fred Stobbart and Gary Hewitt trophy winners, Daniel Sewart and Guy Smith

Jeremy Revell - Jack Erskine-Pereira

Durham Chess Congress R2 Open

1.c4 e5 2.g3 Nc6 3.Bg2 f5 4.Nc3 Nf6 5.e3 d5 6.cxd5 Nb4 7.d3 Nfxd5 8.Nxd5 Nxd5 9.a3 Be6 10.Ne2 c6 11.0-0 Bd6 12.d4 e4 13.f3 exf3 14.Bxf3 0-0 15.Nc3 Qd7 16.Nxd5 Bxd5 17.Bxd5+ cxd5 18.Qb3 Be7 19.Bd2 Rac8 20.Rac1 b6 21.Bb4 Rce8 22.Rc3 g5 23.Rfc1 Qe6 24.Rc6 Qe4 25.Bxe7 Rxe7 26.R1c3? f4 27.Rd6 fxe3 28.Rxd5 Qb1+ 29.Kg2 Qf1# 1-0



Yaoyao with Alex - a moment to treasure!

Oh, lest I forget – a big highlight for me was Yaoyao Zhu pulling together examples of regional accents for (I think) a podcast she is running, to enable better grasp of how difficult it is to pick up our native tongue. For Scotland she selected her, and our, favourite arbiter. 😊

Yorkshire County Chess Update by Steve Westmoreland



County chess is a fantastic experience. Away from the Open teams you get the chance of a fairly even game and to play alongside your former league foes. Yorkshire has a thriving Saturday league, and a large number of different areas. County chess puts us on the same team.

The semi-finals had 64 Yorkshire players out in the Open, U2050, U1850 and U1650 teams. Alas, half the teams lost, with the Open team losing 10-6 and the U1650 team 8½-7½ to the respective Surrey teams. However, the U2050 team defeated Middlesex to join the U1850 team on finals day.

This season a number of us in the U1850 team have stayed near the venues to enjoy local hospitality and arrive at games fresh. On Friday 6th June six Yorkshire players from Leeds, Holmfirth and Belgrave met up at the Park Inn Peterborough for drinks, and what was a fantastic Nepalese meal at Momoz, while keeping track of the Norway Chess Open.



Whilst walking back from the meal we came across the Bumble Inn. Pete Mason (who owns the Stumble Inn at Holmfirth) and I (a Holmfirth player), went straight in.



The match was played in Peterborough on 10th June, and our six stay-overs were joined by fellow players from clubs in York, Sheffield, Hull, and the many clubs within West Yorkshire. What was apparent was the camaraderie and excellent team spirit. All members get on very well, which is demonstrated whenever our respective clubs play each other.

Peterborough itself looks nice, with some great architecture, in particular the churches and cathedral. Sadly, the city is in decline, with very visible problems common to many other British cities. Fortunately the venue was out of the city centre, although we did have to eject one lady and bar the door. The lady in question and her friends had apparently already been removed from a number of local premises.



The bridge club, though, was a brilliant venue: spacious, good tables, and a kitchen area. Parking was decent and free. The Suffolk team were very friendly and accommodating; it was a pleasure to meet them. They beat us the last time we played (many years ago), and Granville's opponent recognised him from 50 years previously, although on this occasion Granville won his game. Granville remarked that studying does pay off!



The end result was 9-7. Yorkshire were largely outrated on boards 1 to 5, but three draws and two wins meant that the top order did their job well again. The lower boards had the rating advantage, and took the match away from Suffolk.



As I like my stats, how are we performing? Excluding those who have only played one match, Dave Patrick and Rupert Jones are our top performers on 2/2. Granville, Rob Dean, Rob Browne and I are all on 1½/2.



In the Northern Counties stages we had Granville on 3/3, Robin (Browne) on 2/2, Dave Patrick on 2½/3, and Seth, Charlie and me on 1½/2. We are very hard to beat!

So what next? At the time of writing player bartering has commenced, and we await venue details. Hopefully another overnight stay is on the cards, with good food and company. Back on 5th July!

FEATURES

Endgames All Club Players Should Know by Glenn Flear

Stalemate Ends the Game (Sometimes)



Stalemate is a curious aspect of chess, a supposedly logical game. Why is it that a player who has been convincingly outplayed can still share the spoils?

Normally it's unfavourable to have one's king (and other units) badly tied down, but if there are no legal moves (and it isn't check) then one can claim a draw. Who invented such a rule?

Endgame theory is heavily influenced by this last chance resource for the defender. One typical case is where the bishop doesn't have control of the promotion square of a rook's pawn.

Wrong Rook's Pawn



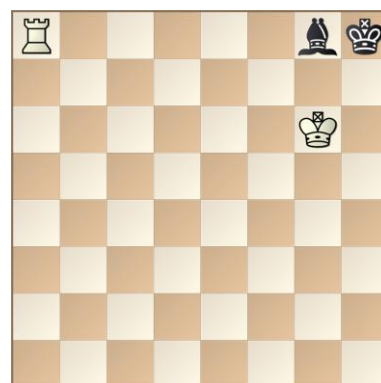
1.g5 Nf7 2.Kg4 Nxc5! 3.Kxc5 Kh8 White can't push the opposing king away from the corner, and attempts to do so typically lead to stalemate.

4.Kg6 Kg8 5.h6 Kh8 6.Bf5 Here are three different stalemates: 6.h7; 6.Kf7; 6.Bd5.

6...Kg8 7.Be6+ Kh8, and again stalemate is close.

In the case of rook versus bishop, again the colour of the corner square decides the result.

Rook vs Bishop



The diagram illustrates the favourable corner for the defender (i.e. not the same colour as the bishop). White has to withdraw one of his pieces, as Black is threatening stalemate.

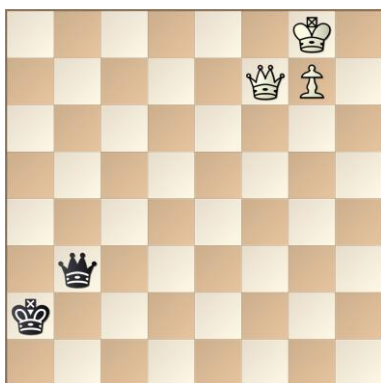
1.Ra4 Bd5 2.Rh4+ Kg8 3.Rd4 Bf7+! 4.Kf6 Bb3 5.Rd8+ Kh7 6.Rd7+ Kh8, and Black can happily hold with his king in the corner.

Having a king in any corner is frequently associated with the possibility of a stalemate in a wide variety of endgames.

In the following more advanced example, the possibility of a cunning trick indicates where the defender should

aim to place his king.

Queen + g-Pawn vs Queen



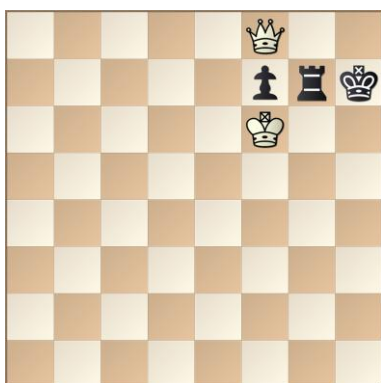
Knowledge about queen endgames with just one knight's pawn (i.e. the b-pawn or g-pawn) is a grey area for even experienced players. Small details can change the assessment from winning to drawing, and in a practical game it's hard to calculate all the possible checks. In many cases the stronger side's king can wriggle out of a series of checks. Even so, the following defensive resource is worth knowing:

1...Ka1! Although White isn't obliged to capture, the position is still a book draw. This resource shows why placing the defending king in this far distant corner yields drawing chances, despite the fact that the g-pawn is so close to the promotion square.

2.Qxb3 After 2.Kf8 Qb8+ 3.Qe8 Qf4+ 4.Kg8 Qc4+ White has no satisfactory way to escape the checks.

In many a limited material endgame, if the attacking queen is exactly a knight's move away from the opposing king (on the edge of the board) there can be stalemate themes.

Lilienthal
1962



Black can hold using a variety of themes, stalemate being one of them.

1...Rg6+! 2.Kf5 Going forward is no better: 2.Kxf7 Rf6+! 3.Kxf6. If 2.Ke7 Rg8!, and the queen is trapped.

2...Rf6+ 3.Kg5 Rg6+ 4.Kh5 Rf6 5.Kg5 Rg6+ 6.Kf5 Rf6+ 7.Ke5 Re6+ 8.Kd4 Rf6 9.Kd5 Rf5+ 10.Kd6 Rf6+ 11.Kd7 Rg6! 12.Kc7 Or 12.Qxf7+ Rg7.

12...Rg8 Black's fortress holds firm.

Avoiding a stalemate resource is a recurring theme in studies.

Saavedra



This fairly well known study features a clever way to avoid stalemate.

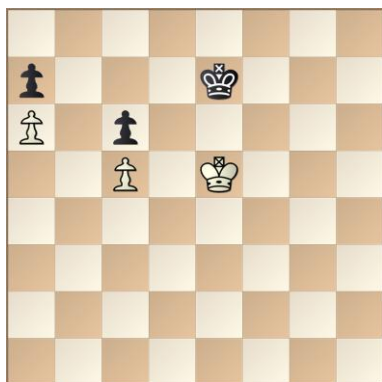
1.c7 Rd6+ 2.Kb5! Otherwise Black can find a way to trade the rook for the pawn, for example 2.Kc5 Rc1.

2...Rd5+ 3.Kb4 Rd4+ 4.Kb3 Rd3+ 5.Kc2 Rd4! 6.c8=R! The routine 6.c8=Q allows 6...Rc4+ 7.Qxc4, with an immediate draw.

6...Ra4 7.Kb3, with two decisive threats.

In practical games pawn endgames often involve the defender angling for stalemate, but it's still necessary to calculate the tempi correctly.

Bologan, V – Dizdarevic, E
Sarajevo 2004



Now Black needs to find the right path for his king.

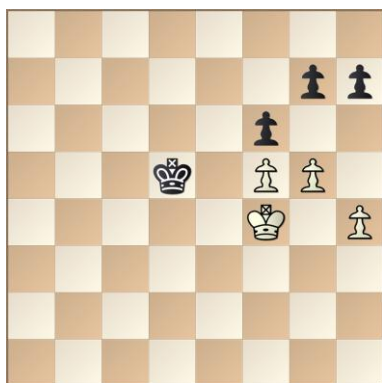
64...Ke8? A sloppy move!

The alternative 64...Kd7! seems to hold: 65.Kf6 Kd8 66.Ke6 Kc7 67.Ke7 Kc8 68.Kd6 Kd8 (Black has the opposition) 69.Kxc6 Kc8 70.Kd6 Kd8 71.c6 Kc8 72.c7 stalemate, with the a6-pawn cramping Black a little too much!

65.Ke6! Black resigned, as he realized that allowing White to seize the opposition in this manner wasn't going to end well: 65...Kd8 66.Kd6 Kc8 67.Kxc6 and Black must allow the enemy king onto the seventh rank: 67...Kb8 (or 67...Kd8 68.Kb7 etc.) 68.Kd7 Ka8 69.c6 with mate in two. **1-0**

Of course it helps to have an idea of what to aim for, as a stalemate net doesn't necessarily readily come to mind. Here, for example, Chigorin failed to find a way to hold a desperate-looking position.

Chigorin, M – Tarrasch, S
Ostend 1905



50.gxf6? A miscalculation, or simply not being aware of the possibility of hiding his king in a burrow? The key idea is that after 50.Kg4 Ke5 51.g6! h6 the white monarch can

tuck himself away with 52.Kh5 (=), as 52...Kxf5 is stalemate. Similarly, 50.Kg3 Ke5 51.Kg4 Ke4 52.g6 h6 53.Kh5 comes to the same thing.

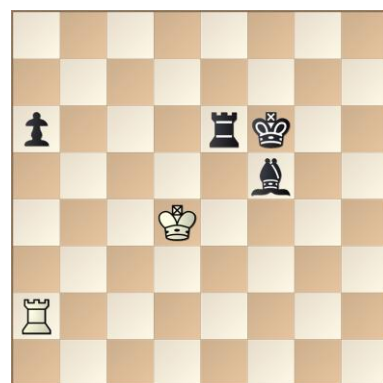
50...gxf6 51.Kg4 Ke4 52.Kh3 A better try is 52.Kh5 Kxf5 53.Kh6 Kg4 54.Kxh7, and now in order to win Black needs to find a neat idea 54...Kh5!.

52...Kf4 0-1

From now on any vigilant reader of this column(!), can bear in mind this type of resource in their own games, whereas Chigorin in 1905 had probably never seen anything like it in chess literature before!

In practical play, if one is not careful the drawing themes can escape one's vigilance.

Cramling, P – Berg, E
Stockholm 2007



65...Bg4 Simpler is 65...Rc6 66.Kd5 Bd7.

66.Rf2+ Ke7 67.Rf4 Threatening the bishop and Re4. You're probably already aware that if the rooks come off then the game will be drawn if White's king can make it to a1 (with a long-term stalemate!).

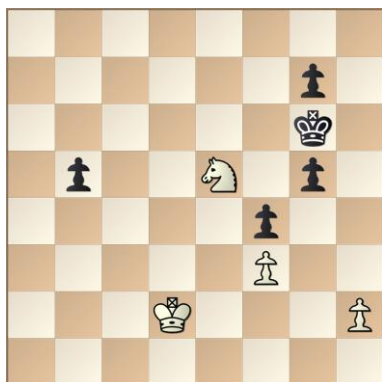
67...Rg6 68.Kc5 Kd7 69.Rf2 Kc7 70.Rg2 The pin is a nuisance, but Black is still able to reorganize.

70...Rc6+ 71.Kb4 Bc8 72.Rg3 Kb6? There are several moves that would have maintained the advantage, but not this one! I quite like 72...Be6, with the idea of 73.Ka5 Rc5+! 74.Kxa6? Bc4+, and mates.

Berg had no doubt seen **73.Rc3!**, but evidently failed to notice that after **73...a5+ 74.Ka4 Rxc3** an unusual stalemate arises. $\frac{1}{2}$ - $\frac{1}{2}$

There sometimes doesn't seem to be any sort of stalemate in view.

Turner, M – Pert, N
Millfield 2000



45...Kh5! White has an extra piece, but Black's king is intriguingly placed.

46.Ng4 Kh4 47.Nf2 b4 48.Kc2 g4! A star move, as both recaptures have their downsides.

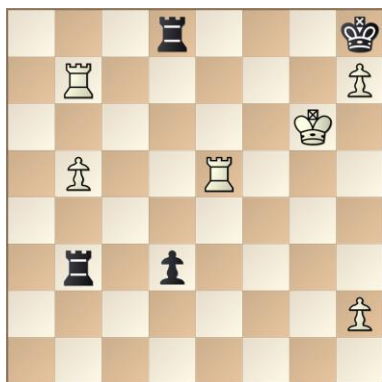
49.Nxg4 After 49.fxg4 b3+ 50.Kxb3 g5= any king move by White produces stalemate (whereas h2–h3 looks suicidal).

49...Kh3 50.Kb3 Kg2 51.Ne5 Kxh2 52.Kxb4 Kg3 53.Kc3 g5 54.Kd2 g4! Even the second time around, this pawn thrust is still elegant!

55.fxg4 f3 ½–½

Mate might seem close, but with careful calculation a defender can sometimes turn this into stalemate!

Kramnik, V – Leko, P
Tilburg 1997



A sharp position has arisen, but White has three pieces in the heat of the action against Black's two.

50...Rxb5! But not 50...d2? 51.Rd5! (on the other hand 51.Rbe7 can be met as follows: 51...Rf3 52.Re8+ Rf8

53.Rxf8+ Rxf8 54.Rd5 Rb8! 55.Rxd2 due to the intermediate check 55...Rb6+!) 51...Re8 52.Rxd2, with a winning advantage.

51.Rbxb5 The same theme (as in the game) works against the other capture: 51.Rexb5 d2 52.Rd5 d1=Q 53.Rxd1 Rd6+!=.

51...d2 It's mate, not stalemate, that ends the game following 51...Rd6+?, in view of 52.Kf7 d2 53.Rb8+ Kxh7 54.Rh5+ Rh6 55.Rh8+.

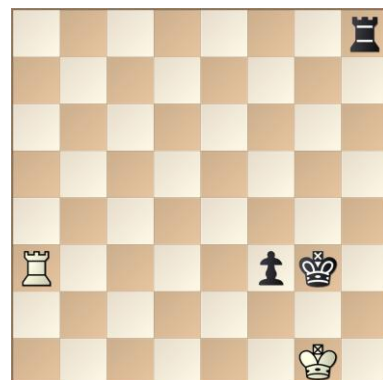
52.Rbd5 d1=Q Rather than 52...Rxd5?!, which allows mate in one with 53.Re8#.

53.Rxd1 Rd6+! The point emerges.

54.Rxd6 54.Kg5 Rxd1 is also drawn, but less elegant. ½–½

In the following example, the only way to rescue the cause is a stalemate resource.

Rook Endgame Stalemate



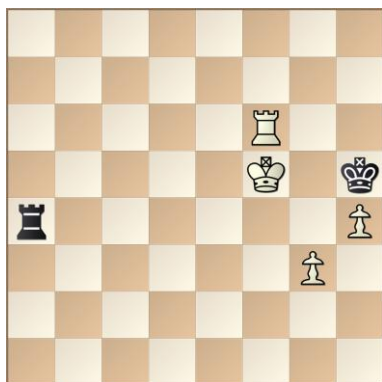
Black is threatening to bring his rook to the queenside, with a book win, but White has time to save himself - but only if he spots the following:

1.Ra2! Rb8 2.Rg2+! Black either accepts a draw by capturing or retreats.

2...Kf4 3.Rg7, and now the danger has passed.

A seemingly lost endgame sometimes can be saved if one can spot a promising pattern. Of course, it helps to remember that when a king is restricted stalemate may be just around the corner!

Solic, K – Pruijssers, R
Sarajevo 2010



1...Ra3! The only way to salvation. Other moves fall short:

1...Rb4 2.Rf8! (now mate is threatened) 2...Rb5+ 3.Kf4 Rb4+ 4.Kf3 Rb3+ 5.Kg2 Rb2+ 6.Kh3 and, with the king sheltered, White has control and should eventually win;

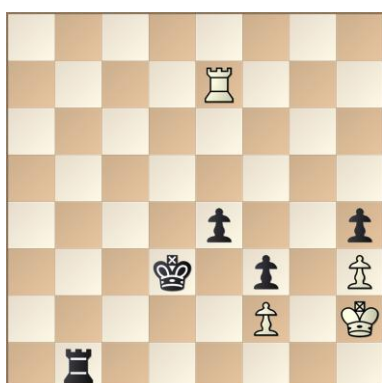
1...Rf4+? (this only works if the opponent is really naïve!) 2.gxf4+—;

1...Ra5+ 2.Ke6! (2.Kf4 Ra4+ (2...Rf5+? loses on the spot to 3.Rxf5+) 3.Kf3? fails to 3...Ra3+! 4.Kf2 Rxf3) 2...Ra6+ 3.Kf7 Ra7+ 4.Kf8 Ra8+ 5.Kg7 Ra7+ 6.Rf7 Ra5 (no better is 6...Ra4 7.Rf5+ Kg4 8.Rg5+ Kf3 9.h5) 7.Rf4 Rb5 8.Re4 Ra5 9.Kf6 Ra6+ 10.Kf5 Ra8 11.Re5 (Black's king will soon be forced away from its tricky defensive square on h5) 11...Rf8+ 12.Ke4+ Kh6 (12...Kg4 13.Rg5+ Kh3 14.h5) 13.g4 etc., and White is on the road to victory.

2.Kf4 Rf3+! 3.Kxf3 If 3.Ke5 then 3...Rxf3 is a trivial draw. ½–½

In the following example Black avoided White's clever stalemate idea with an amazing counter-resource.

Pisa Ferrer, J - Bellon Lopez, J
Barcelona 1984



79...Rf1 For the record, the most efficient way from here is 79...Re1! 80.Rd7+ Ke2 81.Rd2+ Kf1 (no thank you!) etc.

80.Rd7+ Ke2 81.Rd2+ White was perhaps getting all excited at this point, as his crazy rook is about to get going.

81...Ke1 82.Rd1+ Kxf2 83.Re1 However, Bellon found a way to keep his winning advantage alive.

83...Rh1+!! Giving the opposing king some breathing room, and thus avoiding the traps: 83...e3 84.Re2+!=, 83...Rxe1=, and 83...Kxe1=.

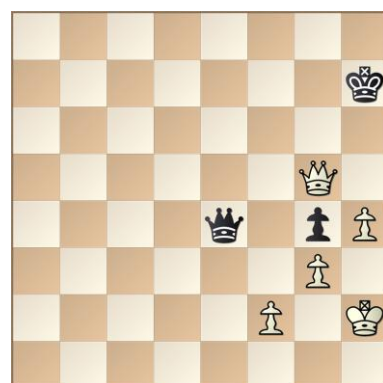
84.Rxh1 e3 The two advanced pawns beat the rook.

85.Ra1 e2 86.Ra3 e1=Q 87.Rxf3+ Another stalemate try!

87...Ke2! 88.Kg2 Qa1 89.Rf4 Qa8+ 90.Kg1 Qa7+ 91.Kg2 Qb7+ 92.Kg1 Qb6+ 93.Kg2 Qc6+ 94.Kg1 Qc1+ 0–1

In endgames with queens on the board, stalemates are probably even more common than those with rooks.

Ribli, Z – Spassky, B
Montpellier 1985



71.h5 Qf3 72.Qg6+ Kh8 73.Qh6+ Kg8 74.Qf4 Qd1 75.Qg5+ Kh7 76.Qf5+ Kg7 77.Qe4 Kh8 78.Kg2 Kg7 79.f4? Ribli aims to break out of the bind, but the resulting queen + g- and h-pawns vs queen endgame (surprisingly!) turns out to be probably drawn after this move. I worked out a way to win (with help from Stockfish) starting with 79.Qe7+!:

1. 79...Kh6 80.Qf7 Qc2 (80...Qe2 81.Qg6#) 81.Qf6+ Kh7 82.h6 Qc7 (82...Qg6 83.Qxg6+ Kxg6 84.Kf1) 83.Qf5+ Kxh6 84.Qxg4 and with the f- and g-pawns the conversion process shouldn't be too difficult.

2. 79...Kg8! (the most resistant) 80.h6 Qd5+ 81.Kg1 Qd4 82.Qe6+ Kh7 83.Qe7+ Kg8 (83...Kxh6 84.Qe3+) 84.Qb7! Kh8 85.Kg2 Kg8 86.Qb1 Qd5+ 87.Kg1 Qg5 88.Qe4 Kh8 89.Qf4 Qg6 90.Kf1 Kh7 91.Ke2 Qa6+ 92.Ke3, and despite

there being a few further checks to navigate White's king will be able to march over towards g4 and thus eliminate the opposing g-pawn.

79...gxf3+ 80.Qxf3 Qc2+ 81.Kh3 Qd2 82.Qg4+ Kh8 83.h6
Playing for tricks!

83...Qb2 Whereas 83...Qxh6+ 84.Qh4! wins for White.

84.Kh4 Qh2+ 85.Kg5 Qxh6+! Flashy!

86.Kxh6 ½–½

Here is an example from one of my games.

Flear, G - De la Riva, O
Chanac 1995



48.Qxa6? After the game my wife pointed out that 48.h4+! wins, as this leads either to mate or a decisive exchange of queens: 48...Kf5 (48...Kxh4 49.Qxf4+ Kh3 50.Qh2#) 49.Qd5+ Kf6 50.Qd4+ Kg6 51.Qxg7+ Kxg7 52.Kg2 etc.

48...Kh4!? The strange position of the king yields some practical counter chances.

49.Qf1 Qb2 50.Kg1 Qg7+ Here 50...Qxa2 allows 51.Qf2+.

51.Kh1 Qb2 52.Qe1+ Instead, White retains excellent winning chances by giving up one of his pawns for time: 52.a4!, e.g. 52...Qxb3 53.a5 Qc3 54.a6 Qa3 55.Kg2+.

52...Kh3 53.Qe6+ Kh4 54.Qe7+ Kh3 55.Qe6+ Kh4 56.a4 Qc1+? Overlooking 56...Qb1+ 57.Kg2 Qg6+! and draws using stalemate.

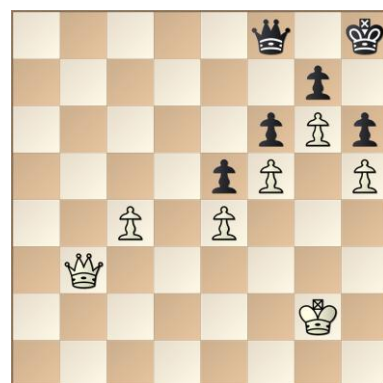
57.Kg2 Qc2+ 58.Kg1 Qc1+ 59.Kf2 Qc2+ 60.Qe2 Qxb3 61.a5 Qa3 62.a6 Qa1 63.Kg2? At this point 63.Qe6! looks promising for White.

63...Qg7+ 64.Kf1 Kh3 65.Qa2 h4! 66.a7 Qg1+! This time my opponent didn't miss the opportunity.

67.Kxg1 ½–½

In the following example the defender needs to anticipate the drawing pattern in advance. But that's not all; he must also determine the right way to set about preparing his intended blow.

Preparing the Ground

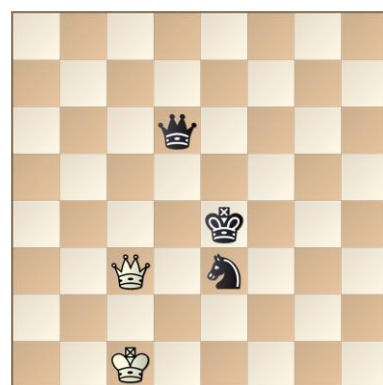


1...Qg8! Instead, 1...Qc8? fails to 2.c5! in view of 2...Qxc5 3.Qb8+.

2.Qb5 Qxc4! 3.Qxc4 and suddenly (as if from nowhere!) it's a draw, noting that 3.Qb8+ Qg8 gets nowhere. ½–½

My attempts at winning in the following example were foiled by my opponent's resource.

Bryson, D – Flear, G
Edinburgh 1985



Just when I thought that I was making good progress (White has no normal checks!), my opponent revealed his main idea.

68.Qb4+! If Black captures it's stalemate. Where did that come from!? ½–½

Maybe the most amusing cases are swindles. Here's one that is memorable.

Chernin, A – Dunnington, A
Cappelle-la-Grande 1994



Black is in dire straits, but for some folk desperation brings on inspiration.

41...bxc4 42.Qf6? An error, but the reason why isn't immediately apparent.

Instead, the powerful **42.Qe5!** avoids what now happens.

42...h4+! 43.Kxh4 Rb8! 44.Rxb8 Qxh3+! 45.Kxh3 with a draw by stalemate. Highly creative! $\frac{1}{2}$ - $\frac{1}{2}$

The next case was memorable, as I somehow saved a rotten position.

Flear, G – Hebden, M
Hastings 1978



The game was about to be adjourned, with yours truly in a seemingly hopeless position. What adds to the drama is that it's New Year's Eve and I'm sharing a room with my opponent, who suggested that I resign so we could go out and enjoy the fun. Tempting though that option was, I decided to play on as I had a strange resource in mind.

47...f5 48.h5 fxe4 49.fxe4 gxh5 50.Bc2+! Saving the e-pawn, as capturing on c2 is an immediate draw.

50...Kd2 51.Bd1! Cheeky, but best.

51...h4 52.Bg4 Bc5 53.Bf5 Kd3 54.Bg6 Ke2 55.Bf5 Bd4 56.Bg6 h3 57.Bf5 Other moves allow a quick mate.

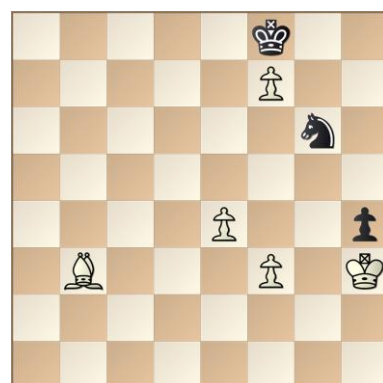
57...Ke3 58.Kg1! Otherwise White is in a nasty Zugzwang.

58...Ke2+ 59.Kh1 Ke3 60.Kg1 Kf4+ 61.Kh1 Bc5 62.Bg6 Bf2 63.Bh7 Be3 64.Bg6 Bc5 65.Bf5 Ba3 66.Bg6 Ke3 67.Bf5 Bc5 68.Kg1 Bd4 69.Kh1 Bc3 70.Kg1 The engine claims that it's still winning for Black, but Mark couldn't find an evident way and nor can I, even now.

Purists might be interested in trying to find a way. Good luck! $\frac{1}{2}$ - $\frac{1}{2}$

The next one, alas, was highly painful, as I was on the receiving end!

Flear, G – Razafindratsima, T
Marseille 2021



69.f4 This seems to be necessary in order to make progress.

69...Nxf4+ 70.Kxh4 Ng6+ 71.Kg5 Ne5 72.Kf6? Here's how White should continue: **72.Bd5 Ke7 73.Kf4 Ng6+** (or **73...Nxf7 74.Bxf7 Kxf7 75.Kf5** with a decisive opposition) **74.Kf5 Nf8 75.e5 Nd7 76.e6 Nf8 77.Kg5 Nh7+ 78.Kg6 Nf8+ 79.Kg7**, and the knight has been run out of squares.

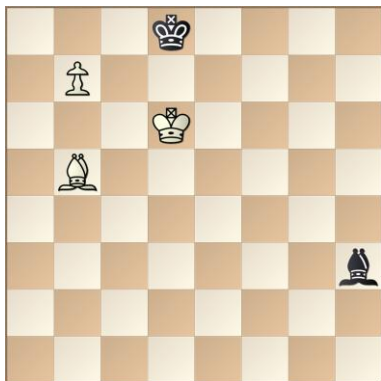
72...Nxf7! Ouch! I must admit, the idea never occurred to me!

73.Bc2 73.Bxf7=.

73...Nd8 74.e5 Nc6 75.e6 Ne7 76.Be4 Ng8+ 77.Ke5 Ke7 78.Ba8 $\frac{1}{2}$ - $\frac{1}{2}$

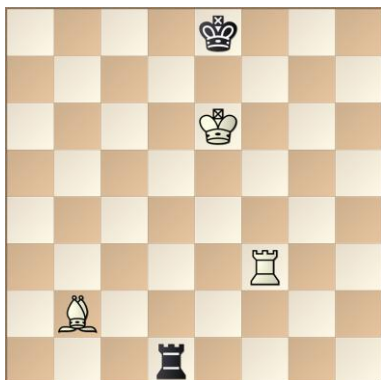
Here are a couple of exercises where stalemate comes in somewhere.

Exercise 1



Just when it looks all over, Black to play has a cunning defensive resource. Can you find it, and is it good enough to draw?

Exercise 2



It's looking grim for Black, but there is a way to keep the opponent at bay. Can you find it?

Exercise 1 Answer

(analysis from **Vukic, M – Flear, G** Hem 1984)

1...Bc8!? The only chance to make a fight of it. But there is a nevertheless a win:

2.b8=B!! Promoting to a major piece is immediately stalemate, whereas under-promotion to a knight gets close, but is insufficient to win: 2.b8=N? Bh3!! 3.Nc6+ Ke8 and Black slips out of the net. For the curious, it's worth noting that 2...Bh3 is indeed the only move, as other moves fall short:

2...Bb7 3.Bd7! Bg2 4.Na6 4...Bd5 5.Nc5, and Black is in a mating net;

2...Bg4 3.Nc6+ Ke8 4.Ne5+;

2...Bf5 3.Nc6+ Ke8 4.Nd4+.

2...Bh3 Mate also occurs after 2...Bb7 i.e. 3.Bc7+ Kc8 4.Bd7#.

3.Bc7+ Kc8 4.Ba6# So Black's cunning idea doesn't quite save the game, but an opponent would still need to be inspired to find the win!

Exercise 2 Answer

When in trouble, have a look round for a stalemate pattern!

1...Rd7!! 2.Ba3 Re7+! This stalemate resource is an important one to be aware of when defending with rook against rook and bishop (see the December 2024 column for more examples).

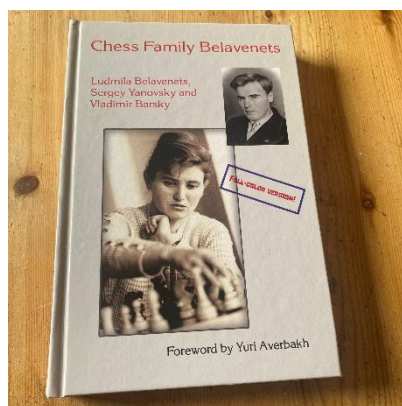
Book of the Month by Ben Graff



The best new writing and the greatest classics under one roof... in association with Forward Chess

Chess Family Belavenets by Ludmila Belavenets, Sergey Yanovsky and Vladimir Barsky (Elk and Ruby)

'Do whatever it takes, nothing else is particularly important, but you must save the children!'
(Extract from one of Sergei Belavenets' final letters)



Sometimes what one generation gets to hand on to the next is very limited, and is all the more precious for that. Ludmila Belavenets writes that ‘For the majority of my generation, war children, the father was above all a portrait on the wall. My father’s framed photo hung over the sofa. I constantly felt like he was watching me, smiling a bit.’

A tiny child when Sergei Belavenets died, apart from the photograph the worldly goods Ludmila inherited were very limited. They included: a ‘really heavy’ inkstand made of marble, engraved with the words ‘For a successful tournament performance’; a travel chess set ‘with pieces on pins inserted into the holes on the squares,’ two of the chessmen long since lost; a handful of his chess books; a pocket watch; an unfinished manuscript. As Ludmila put it, ‘He couldn’t do anything for me, since he died so soon... As a parting gift, he left me a huge (chess) world populated with diverse people, and I’m sure most of them are good!’ So while the physical goods Sergei could bequeath did not amount to much, his connection with the chess community and a shared talent for the game were his true gift, and these would take Ludmila a very long way.

I must confess that before I read this book Sergei Belavenets was not well known to me. Yet in the 1930s and early 1940s he was one of the strongest players of his generation. Sergei finished third in the 1939 Soviet Championships (behind Botvinnik and Kotov), and won the Moscow championship twice. Who knows how much more he might have achieved, had he not been one of the many whose career, and life, were tragically cut short by World War Two. Sergei apparently thought he was going to be working in a tank repair school which ‘ultimately did not happen’, and was just 31 when in 1942 he was killed while fighting on the front line in Leningrad against the Nazis. Undoubtedly books like *Chess Family Belavenets* are vital in helping us to remember those who were lost to the chess community much too soon.

The world his daughter was born into was not an easy one. She recalls living in a cottage that was so cold that ‘I

never left the bed for the entire winter. In the spring, I was put on the floor, and it turned out I had forgotten how to walk.’ Ludmila lived between 1940 and 2021. She writes about the cult-like grip that Stalin had on the country (including on her), and a society that changed beyond all recognition during her lifetime. A true witness to history, Ludmila played an important part, both in chronicling her father’s story and in shaping her own.

At the chessboard Ludmila mirrored Sergei’s achievements by winning the women’s equivalents of the Soviet and Moscow titles. She also triumphed in the Women’s World Correspondence Championship in 1992. Ludmila seconded Alla Kushnir at three world championship matches against Nona Gaprindashvili, and coached many now famous players including Sokolov and Morozevich.

The difference in approach between Alla, who gave the game up, and Ludmila says a lot. ‘Maybe I loved it more. My gift was less but I loved chess more... Chess pervades you, you can’t just throw it away – you can’t throw part of your soul away, right?’ She also writes elsewhere in the book that ‘I was never greatly ambitious in the vein of “either I get to the very top or I quit chess altogether.” I liked playing chess, and I wanted it always to be a part of my life.’

In the first part of the book Ludmila tells the story of her own life in chess, a world in which her father was well known. It did amuse me to read how Sergei’s wife had previously assessed his games. ‘My mother never looked at the board, but evaluated the position based on the way my father smoked cigarettes: if he did it calmly, without hurry, than all was well, but if he smoked quickly and nervously, then something was wrong.’

Grigory Levenfish was an early coach for Ludmila, and a wonderful role model. ‘Levenfish was actually treating us like grown-ups. He didn’t drop to our level – he tried to lift us to his level.’ Even a suitably brusque Korchnoi assisted by offering up thoughts on some of Ludmila’s games. In that world, at that time, Ludmila knew many world champions. It would be Tal who made the greatest impression. ‘He was incredibly charismatic! Always funny, friendly and witty, he had a truly magnetic personality, and you couldn’t help but admire his colossal chess talent.’

Inevitably Ludmila was something of a trail-blazer, helping to pave the way for future generations of female players. ‘The situation has now changed, but back then the attitude towards chess-playing women was mostly ironic and condescending.’

In the age of the computer it is easy to forget how much more prominent correspondence chess once was. Ludmila observes that 'Chess players are slightly crazy in general, but I think that the correspondence players are a bit crazier.' Yet for Ludmila it was central to her journey. 'Correspondence chess is pure creativity... correspondence chess gave me the inspiration, the pure, true joy I never felt at the board.'

Ultimately it would fall to Ludmila, in conjunction with Yanovsky and Barsky, to finish the book her father had started. Just as with his career more generally, the portion of *Chess Family Belavenets* dedicated to Sergei's writing gives us a tantalizing glimpse as to what might have been. 'Sadly, most of [his material was] lost during the war and in the early post-war years.' What survived was 'only a fraction.' Various middle- and endgame themes are explored, and I was struck by the clarity of Sergei's prose and the freshness of his ideas. It is beyond the scope of this review to provide a full analysis here, but it is clear that this is exceptional work.

Ludmila also added 31 of Sergei's games and 22 of her own, which are all nicely annotated, and very pleasing to read through. There are reflections on Sergei from various other players, which speak to an excellent player, a fine writer and a worthy man. Alexander Iglitsky noted that 'Belavenets' passionate love for chess and loyalty to chess art combined with intolerance towards everything superficial, ostentatious, and short term. That's where his constant striving for clarity, his scientific approach to playing comes from... [He] made a great contribution to the Soviet chess school, the strongest in the world.' As Serezha Belavenets put it, 'Even when [he] became one of the country's most prominent masters, he still remained a humble, hard-working, kind-hearted man, always ready to help his friends, both near and far.'

Perhaps the most haunting line comes from Averbakh (whose own life was now nearing its end). He observed that 'Stanishnev... went to the front and never returned. Sergei Belavenets didn't return either. As it turned out, he played his last ever tournament game against me...' It is also sad to note that Ludmila, who had been alive at the start of the project to produce this book (which builds on a smaller 1963 Soviet edition called *Master Sergei Belavenets*), died of Covid before *Chess Family Belavenets* could go to print.

A father and daughter - one whose life was short, the other whose life was long; people who spent their days in times of tremendous change. Both were to leave a wonderful impression on the chess world. I have no doubt that *Chess Family Belavenets* will be enjoyed by all who read it. This is a compelling, eclectic and unusual offering,

which stands as a fitting tribute to both Sergei and Ludmila.

The Chess Trust



The Chess Trust was established in 2015, initially supported by a significant bequest from the estate of Kent junior organiser Richard Haddrell, and this bequest formed the basis for building plans to support chess.

The Trust has two objectives:

- 1) The advancement of amateur sport by promoting the study and practice of chess in all its forms, principally, but not exclusively, for the benefit of residents of England; and
- 2) The advancement of education by promoting the development of young people through the teaching and practice of chess.

Since the Trust's inception additional funds have been received through donations and bequests, and we intend to use any funds received to meet these objectives in the immediate future and for the long term. These objectives are broad! Apart from directly supporting professional players, there are not many things that we can't do, although we do work closely with our colleagues at CSC, the John Robinson Youth Trust and the ECF Grass Roots Initiative so that we don't step on each other's toes.

Our financial year runs to August, and so far this year we have spent about £70,000. The majority of our expenditure funds the Accelerator programme, a supported chess development programme available only to a handful of our top junior (U18) talents on a selection-only basis. You will have read in these pages about the achievements of Shreyas Royal, Bodhana Sivanandan, and others, but you may not be aware that two of the students, Stanley Badacsonyi and Supratit Banerjee, recently finished first and second respectively at the annual Kings Head 'In Memoriam' blitz tournament arranged by David Norwood and Ali Mortazavi, ahead of several GMs.

We have also made grants to just about every tournament in England which has offered norm

opportunities as well as the British Championships and the Glorney Cup, and we sponsor the ECF's awards scheme. In the past we have made grants to enable teams to participate in the World and European Senior Championships, both the Open and Women's European Club Cups and the NATO Armed Forces Championship, we have provided seed funding for a chess club for blind players, we have made a grant to enable a team of deaf players to participate in the 4NCL, and we have supported ad hoc projects in Yorkshire and Essex.

We welcome requests for grants for many other events and activities. Our next meeting is on 27th August. If you have an idea and would like to apply for a grant, please visit the Chess Trust website:

<https://chesstrust.org.uk/>.

While we would like to support almost every request we receive, that just isn't possible. We currently have assets of about £750,000 which are prudently invested, but these funds will not last for ever. We would be delighted to accept donations to the Trust, and any donation can be used, within reason, however the donor instructs. Donations will of course be accepted anonymously unless requested otherwise. The Trust is a registered charity, so donations made by a UK taxpayer will enable us to reclaim basic rate tax on its value through the Gift Aid scheme. So a donation of £100 will enable the Trust to reclaim £25, making the total donation worth £125 to the Trust. Higher rate taxpayers should be able to reclaim the difference between the basic and higher rates through their tax return.

There are many charities which rely on the generosity of individuals (not to mention the benefits of reducing any potential inheritance tax liability) to receive legacies and bequests. While the Trust cannot claim to be able to save children's lives, find a cure for a disease, or even look after tomorrow's abandoned cats and dogs, over £2 billion is left to charity each year in the UK alone, and the Trustees would be honoured to accept any part of that as a bequest to the Trust to help us continue not only to encourage and nurture the Shreyas's and the Bodhanas of future generations, but also to make the game we love more accessible to everyone. If you would like to discuss a bequest to the Chess Trust in your will, please get in touch with me here: https://chesstrust.org.uk/?page_id=36, or by email: contact@chesstrust.org.uk.

Simon Brown, Chair of Trustees

From the Archives by Dr Natalie Hayton, DMU

Chessboard Curiosities: Four Highlights from the English Chess Federation Library

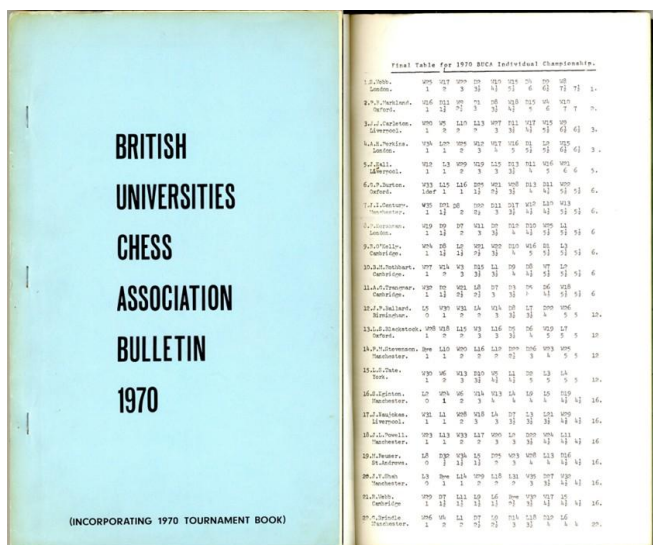
Work on the English Chess Federation Library in Special Collections continues apace as we catalogue extensive runs of books, periodicals, and international newsletters, as well as preserve significant archival material, while ensuring everything is discoverable through our catalogues. This remarkable collection offers a wealth of historical insight, and we remain committed to making its stories accessible to researchers, enthusiasts and the wider public.

For this month's feature we're taking a short detour from our usual focused explorations of individual items to reflect on recent highlights from our social media activity. Each week, under our homegrown hashtag #ChessTuesday, we spotlight a noteworthy item from the collection. Fleeting by nature, these posts offer valuable glimpses into the breadth of the library, as well as the curatorial work and expertise behind the scenes. Here we revisit four of our most popular posts from the past six months, each one deserving of a closer look.

British Universities Chess Association (BUCA) Bulletin (1970)

As custodians of De Montfort University's institutional history, Special Collections often uncovers materials that resonate with our academic community. The 1970 BUCA bulletin, a record of that year's university-level chess competition, was a natural candidate for online engagement, particularly given DMU's strong local ties and the proximity of the University of Leicester (we are a two-university city after all).

Our online audience, comprising a lively mix of alumni, students, and chess players, responded warmly. Many shared memories of their own university chess clubs, while others took pleasure in recognising familiar names listed in the final results table. It was a rewarding reminder of how archival materials can spark personal and collective reflection. Those who placed in the top five are listed here in case the image proves too difficult: 1. Simon Webb of London; 2. Peter Markland of Oxford; 3. John Carleton of Liverpool; 4. Alan Perkins of London; 5. John Hall of Liverpool.



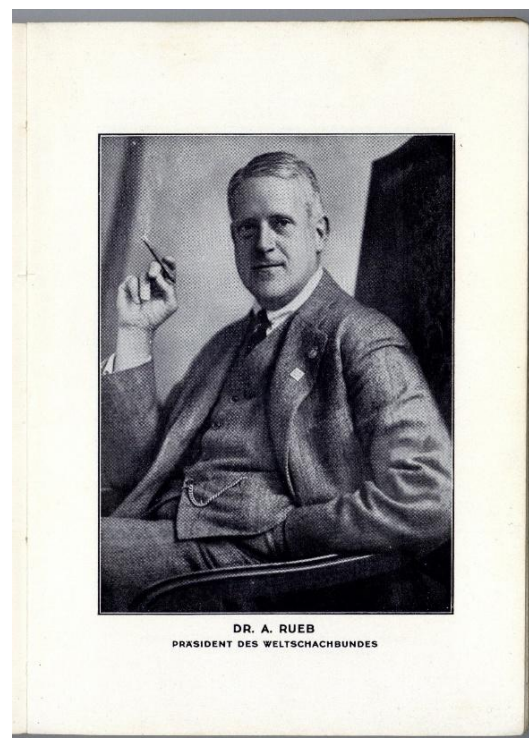
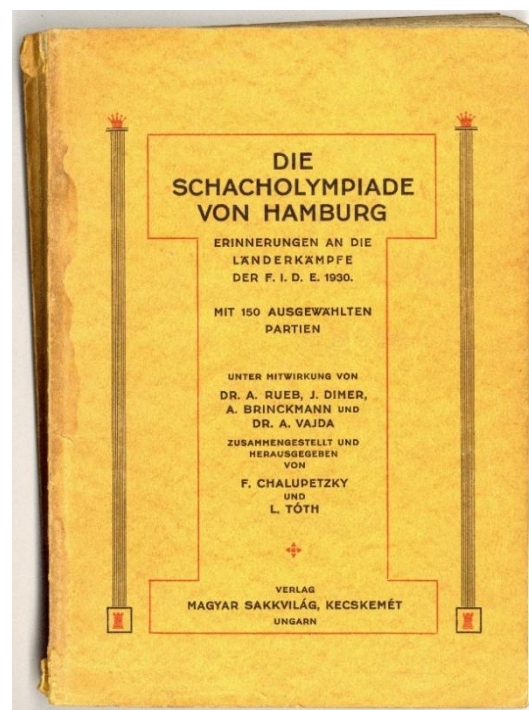
Cover of the BUCA bulletin for 1970, and the final table for the BUCA Individual Championship, held the same year

Die Schacholympiade von Hamburg (1930 Programme)

Although Special Collections at DMU is home to an increasing number of prestigious sporting history archives, our team is not composed of sports historians — at least, not formally. However, our continuing work with these collections steadily deepens our subject knowledge. Regardless of discipline, we believe it is essential to take the time to understand each collection's distinctive context and significance.

Many of our posts relating to the ECF Library have focused on the wonderfully niche, such as club and regional newsletters, but it is equally important to explore the broader structures that shape the sport, including the formation and evolution of governing bodies and their activities.

One recurring point of fascination has been the history of the Chess Olympiads, including both the International Chess Federation (FIDE) Olympiad and the Women's Olympiad. You can imagine our excitement when we discovered this original programme from the 3rd FIDE Chess Olympiad, held in Hamburg in 1930. Written entirely in German, the booklet features a photographic portrait of Dr Alexander Rueb — one of FIDE's founders, and its first president. A remarkable piece of international chess history!



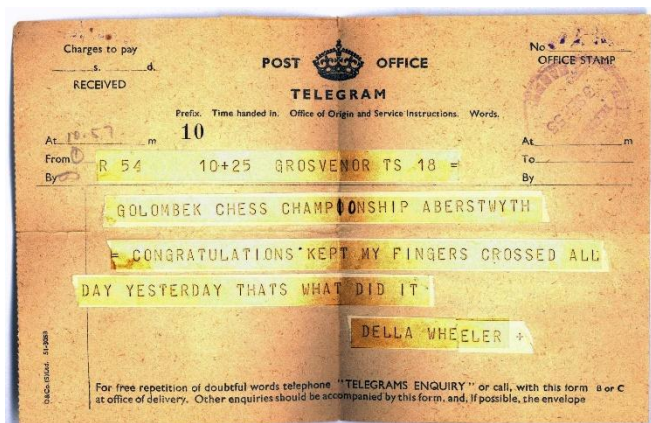
Cover of the Die Schacholympiade Von Hamburg 1930 programme, with a photograph of Dr. Rueb

Telegram to Harry Golombek (1955)

Among the more unusual treasures in the archival holdings is a charming telegram nestled within the archival papers of chess doyen Harry Golombek. By their nature telegrams are typically brief and ephemeral, often discarded unless tied to a notable individual or occasion. As such, they are rare across all the collections in our care, making this example all the more compelling.

Sent by Della Wheeler, whose identity remains something of a mystery, the message marks Golombek's third victory as British Champion at Aberystwyth. We have yet to determine whether Wheeler was a known figure in the chess world, a personal acquaintance, or perhaps both. Despite inviting input from our online audience, no definitive identification has emerged. Perhaps one of our readers here can assist?

What truly stands out, however, is the message's warmth and wit. Its playful tone offers a glimpse not only into Golombek's achievement, but also into a moment of personal celebration. It is easy to imagine the smile it may have brought to his face, a brief but revealing fragment of a champion's life.



Telegram to Harry Golombek from Della Wheeler - from the Papers of Harry Golombek in S/012 (Papers of the English Chess Federation Library)

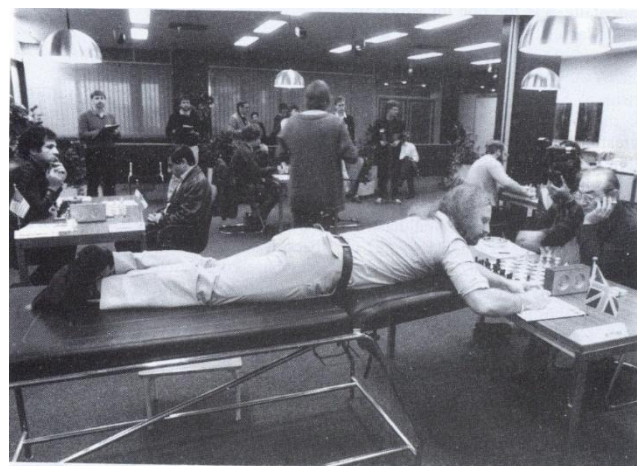
Grandmaster Anthony Miles (1985)

Our final highlight in this social media round-up explores one of those memorable moments when the chess world is abuzz, often for reasons that are in equal parts controversial and entertaining. Late in 2024 'Jeansgate' captured global attention when Grandmaster Magnus Carlsen temporarily withdrew from a New York tournament after being fined for violating the dress code. With that still fresh in mind, we found ourselves particularly attuned to historical instances of unconventional tournament behaviour.

Enter Anthony Miles, the first Englishman to become an over the board grandmaster. In a now-iconic photograph from the 1985 Tilburg tournament, Miles is shown playing while lying down following doctor's orders due to back pain. While some of his opponents objected, citing distraction, the tournament officials upheld the results, and Miles famously shared first place with Robert Hübner of Germany and Victor Korchnoi of Switzerland.

Our post featuring this image sparked lively engagement. Comments ranged from affectionate tributes ('Tony was a top guy!' and 'knew how to create publicity') to helpful

corrections, including one noting that we had mistakenly identified one of the players as Polugaevsky rather than Korchnoi. A timely reminder for us all: accuracy is everything, even in the midst of a good story!



Anthony Miles plays Victor Korchnoi - photo from British Chess Magazine, 1985

These four highlights represent just a small fraction of the stories we've shared, and those waiting to be uncovered and remembered in the ECF Library. From rare publications and playful personal moments to international tournaments, the collection continues to reveal the rich and varied culture surrounding the game. Through this feature we also hope to share something of our approach to the collection, one grounded in careful preservation, thoughtful interpretation, and a commitment to making these materials accessible and engaging for a wide audience. We're always delighted to share these glimpses with our online community, our readers and our visitors, and we look forward to bringing more discoveries to light, whether through focused features, future #ChessTuesday posts, or new additions to the catalogue.

It's a Puzzlement!



Welcome to our puzzles section! Here are this month's puzzles - all hand-picked by ChessPuzzle.net. We provide a link to the relevant ChessPuzzle.net page and a QR code, so you can try the puzzles interactively and get hints if needed - or even the solutions!

When you click on the links below you need to play a move to see the hint and/or solution.

Puzzle 1 – FM Pozzari, Simone – Majeed, Haroon
3rd Cambridge Int. Open, Cambridge ENG



Black to win - [Puzzle One](#)

Puzzle 2 – Pride, Stephen C. – Jones, Graeme
3rd Cambridge Int. Open, Cambridge ENG



Black to win - [Puzzle Two](#)

Puzzle 3 – Dehankar, Mrudul – Southcott-Moyers, Indy
Freestyle Friday, Chess.com



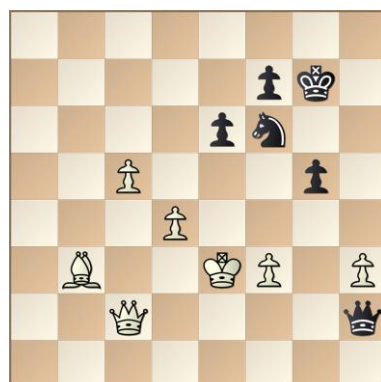
Black to win - [Puzzle Three](#)

Puzzle 4 – Sandhu, Manvith – FM Rappazzo, Johannes
Wightlink Int. Masters, Ryde ENG



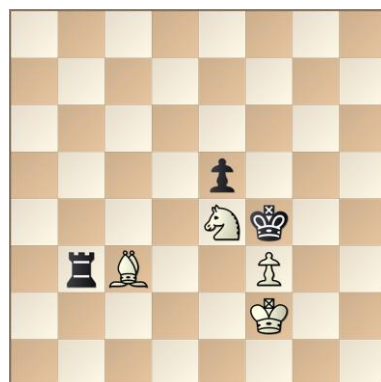
White to win - [Puzzle Four](#)

Puzzle 5 – WFM Kueh, Audrey – IM Haubro, Martin
3rd Cambridge Int. Open, Cambridge ENG



Black to win - [Puzzle Five](#)

Puzzle 6 – Mittal, Aditya – Verbytski, Oleg
3rd Cambridge Int. Open – Cambridge, ENG



White to win - [Puzzle Six](#)

Puzzle 7 – Hedger, Alec – Hanache, Kai
3rd Cambridge Int. Open, Cambridge ENG



Black to win - [Puzzle Seven](#)

Puzzle 8 – Jacobs, Simon – Pack, James
3rd Cambridge Int. Open, Cambridge ENG



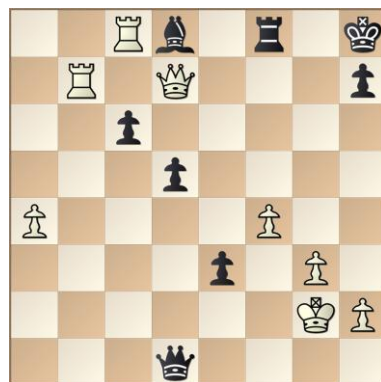
Black to win - [Puzzle Eight](#)

Puzzle 9 – Vaidyanathan, Adithya – GM Wells, Peter K
3rd Cambridge Int. Open, Cambridge ENG



White to win - [Puzzle Nine](#)

Puzzle 10 – Shivakumar, Akshath – Bottekot, Michael T
3rd Cambridge Int. Open, Cambridge ENG



Black to win - [Puzzle Ten](#)

Puzzle 11 – Saidov, B – Southcott-Moyers, I
Freestyle Friday, Chess.com



Black to win - [Puzzle Eleven](#)

Puzzle 12 – FM Fava, Lorenzo – IM Haubro, Martin
3rd Cambridge Int. Open, Cambridge ENG



Black to win - [Puzzle Twelve](#)

All in One

For all the puzzles on one page just visit:

https://chesspuzzlebeta.azurewebsites.net/List/11404?utm_source=ecf&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=junenews

... by clicking the link above, or via the QR code.



Twenty Years After

Some fascinating articles this month – the first describing the decisive first steps in the transition from the old British Chess Federation to the English Chess Federation, and the second two providing an interesting insight into how junior international selection tournaments were organised back in the day.

(Ed: I know I shouldn't tamper with the historical record, but describing a well-known but somewhat speculative opening as 'the Black Mardeimer Gambit' was too much for your editor to bear.)

Historic Council Meeting

At a historic Council meeting in Sheffield on 23rd April the British Chess Federation decided to engage in a major restructuring exercise. The principal change is that it will become a company limited by guarantee, and will simultaneously adopt the name English Chess Federation – a name which reflects more accurately the geographical area of its activities. These changes are scheduled to become effective on 22nd October 2005.

One of the principal reasons for the change to a company limited by guarantee is to mitigate the risk that officers may be held personally liable for the debts of the organisation in excess of any assets. Indeed, the fact that the BCF is currently an unincorporated body has been a factor in reducing the number of people willing to apply formally for directorships.

At the same time as becoming a company limited by guarantee, there will be a number of other modifications

to the structure of the organisation – one of which is an appreciable reduction in the size of the Board.

Junior News - Inaugural Training/Selection Tournament



On 26th and 27th March 2005 the inaugural training/England junior selection tournament was held at Foremarke Hall School, Derby. The youngest competitor was 6, and the oldest was 17.

The age groups were arranged according to the planned selection tournaments that will be held at U20, U18, U16 and U14 levels, due to be organised to select the young players to represent England in the World and European tournaments in 2006.

Entry to this event was by recommendation only, and provided some very interesting observations, mainly from Northern chess officials who verbally clearly demonstrated preference for tournament selection procedures over the paper sift system.

Ironically, I have to report I did not receive one player recommendation from a Northern chess official!

During the tournament IM Lawrence Cooper played rapidplay games against leading contenders in each section, starting with the U7 and finishing with the U17. Please see the report by Lawrence below.

Players drawn against Lawrence Cooper received a 1 point bye.

There were no prizes at this tournament. Entry fees were partly used to provide tuition. Other finance raised will be used to sponsor a grandmaster(s) to accompany young players to the World and European Championships. The objective of this tournament was not only to provide a winner but, by using a flexible approach to the Swiss pairing system, to allow not so strong older players to play against stronger younger players, providing for more competitive chess.

Feedback from parents has been very encouraging.

Future training/selection events will be aimed at end- and middlegame techniques. It was commented that quite a few parents who had travelled from the north of the country (these had been recommended by southern officials!!) would not be prepared to travel south of London because of cost. Therefore parents have been invited to suggest venues which will hopefully incorporate the whole of England and enable more recommended juniors to take part.

Coaches and professional players are invited to approach me stating their interest and terms. I am pleased to report that at the tournament two professional coaches approached me.

In preparation for the July 2006 World Championship the selection procedure is required to be concluded by early April 2006. In view of this, the selection tournaments will be held in age-descending order, commencing with the U20s at a London-based venue (to be confirmed) in early December 2005.

The other tournaments will be held in tandem with other events. I invite organisers of suitable tournaments to approach me.

Following advice from the Management Board, very strong junior players will be allowed to apply to the selection board for pre-selection for an England place.

Alan Ruffle

Report from Lawrence Cooper

Alan Ruffle first contacted me on 5th March. He was organising a BCF Junior selection tournament, and was looking for a titled player to play five rapidplay games against the most promising juniors, and also to help with coaching throughout the weekend. We quickly agreed terms, and the event took place over the Easter weekend of 26th and 27th March at Foremarke Hall School near Milton, Derby. The ages involved ranged from 7 to under 18, so an interesting weekend was guaranteed.

I approached the weekend with a certain amount of apprehension. I've only played around 15 graded games this season, and the idea of facing five juniors who had nothing to lose was a bit unnerving. On the other hand, it was an exciting new venture, and a chance for me to work with some of the most promising juniors in the country. After taking a somewhat scenic route I arrived at the school, and proceedings soon got underway at around 10 o'clock. To my surprise I discovered I was to have five

Blacks, but given my inability to get an advantage with White this wasn't such a handicap!

The first round saw the same time limit for everyone, 30 minutes per player per game. Despite facing an ungraded seven year old, James Bowler, I was sufficiently wary to use the majority of my 30 minutes, and ensure a fairly comfortable victory after a winning a pawn in the early middlegame and mopping up in the endgame. Because the rest of the players played the same time limit I had little chance to observe the other games until I had finished. What already impressed me though was that, on the whole, the players were using their time wisely, and few games finished in five or ten minutes, as one might expect with the age groups involved.

One innovation of Alan's was that after finishing my games I would have a post mortem, and Alan would subsequently frame and present a copy of the game, signed by me with my comments, to my opponents at the start of the next round.

In the second round I again played with 30 minutes each, while the main tournament played with an hour each. After carefully defusing my opponent's piece sacrifice in the Blackmar-Diemer Gambit I was able to simplify to a winning ending. My opponent was J. Thurgood, graded 93 and aged ten. The combination of his age and grade made the game again more uncomfortable than one might expect. Having finished in around 40-45 minutes, I was at last able to observe the other games while finding time to grab a spot of lunch and looking through as many juniors' games as time would allow.

The third round proved to be my most difficult game against Dominic Foord, who like myself is part of the ever-expanding Hilsmark Kingfisher set-up. Despite his grading of 111 I was expecting a tough game. After equalising against my opponent's Bird's Opening, I took advantage of my opponent's dubious pawn sacrifice and liquidated to what I expected to be a fairly comfortable bishop ending, where I had an extra pawn. However, due to my opponent's stubborn defence and my frustration as I entered my last five minutes, I blundered the pawn back. Fortunately I was able to compose myself sufficiently to win the ending, although I imagine he could have drawn had he not been so short of time. I had been impressed by his play in the endgame, and was relieved to have secured the whole point in a game that went to the last seconds of the blitz finish. The juniors were now playing three-hour games, 30 moves in 75 minutes followed by a 15-minute blitz finish. After this I was again able to go through several games while the other juniors were still

playing. My busy day finally drew to an end at around 5 o'clock.

Sunday got underway at 10 o'clock, and I found myself facing Jia Shen Lee graded 129. I emerged from a Nimzo-Indian with a slight advantage, and set about trying to exploit his doubled c-pawns. As so often happens, while winning a pawn I allowed him to gain counterplay on the kingside, and he had a couple of improvements that gave him plenty of compensation for the pawn. In the game itself I was able to stop any attack developing, and swap down to an ending with an extra pawn which was to prove decisive in the blitz finish. Despite my opponent getting a difficult position from the opening, I was impressed that he'd shown the imagination to sacrifice a pawn and drum up counterplay while he had the chance. After the game I was again able to look around the other games before the inevitable deluge of requests to analyse games as the juniors finished their morning round.

The afternoon round saw my toughest pairing, Black against Peter Roberson, aged 15 and graded 179. Surprisingly he lost a pawn to a book trap in the early stages of a Ruy Lopez Exchange. Although the position was by no means lost, the shock to the system meant that he never recovered, and from his point of view the game became a nightmare. After the game I inadvertently raised his spirits by losing a couple of blitz games, although I managed to just about break even. I'm sure he has a bright future, and this game will merely be a blip in his progress. After the game I was able to find time to play some blitz with other juniors and look through some more games, before time ran out and parents with long journeys ahead started to whisk the children away.

On a personal level I enjoyed the weekend, although I found the combination of playing and coaching quite tiring. Everyone seemed to enjoy the weekend, and the experiment of my playing the rapidplay games and then coaching afterwards seemed to be a success. I would like to say a special thank you to Alan Ruffle for organising, and to his wife for organising the refreshments. They were assisted by Paul Hardstaff and Paul Martin, a teacher from the school. David Rumens was also a big help, assisting with the coaching.

NEWS and VIEWS

ChessMood – Free Access for Ten Days from 20th July

We wanted to share a great opportunity with you from our friends at ChessMood, a popular platform designed to help players improve their chess through structured video courses created by grandmasters.

From 20th to 30th July ChessMood is unlocking access to all its courses, completely free. Whether you're looking to sharpen your openings, master middlegame strategy, or get confident in tricky endgames, this is a chance to explore hundreds of hours of material with no commitment.

We've partnered with ChessMood to bring ECF members a 20% discount if you decide to subscribe after the free period. And when you use our affiliate link below, a portion of the fee comes back to the ECF, supporting our work to grow English chess:

<https://chessmood.com/?r=england>

Whether you're just curious, or seriously looking to improve your game, we think it's worth taking a look.

ECF Level One Arbiter Course (Online)

Course dates/schedule: five Monday evenings from 7.00pm to 9.00pm – 1st September 2025; 8th September; 15th September; 22nd September; 29th September.
Course fee: £40.

Please note: participants must be at least Bronze members of the ECF on the date of the examination (29th September).

Course lecturer : Matthew Carr; Assistant lecturer : TBD.
The course will be delivered via Zoom.

Enter online here:

<https://britchess.wufoo.com/forms/ecf-level-1-arbiter-course-online/>

ECF Awards 2025



The closing date for the ECF annual awards for 2025 is 30th June 2025. The awards celebrate both individual and collective achievements. They are a way for the ECF to recognise the work that volunteers undertake to promote and develop chess throughout the country and beyond.

There are nine categories:

1. President's Award for Services to Chess
2. Contribution to Junior Chess
3. Contribution to Women's Chess
4. Contribution to Chess in the Community
5. Contribution to Accessible Chess
6. Online Chess Contribution of the Year
7. Club of the Year
8. Small Club of the Year
9. Congress of the Year

Winners receive a glass trophy, and winning citations will be publicised by the ECF. With the exception of the President's Awards for Services to Chess, each award has a prize of £250, courtesy of the Chess Trust. You can find full details, including how to make nominations and assessment criteria for awards, here:

[ECF Awards Launch 2025](#). Any enquiries should be made to the Awards Committee Chairman Keith Gregory: keith.gregory@englishchess.org.uk

Membership Fees 2025/2026

Last April's Finance Council meeting approved the following new membership rates, effective from 1st July.

	Current price	Rates for 2025/2026
	£	£
Junior Bronze	6.00	7.50
Junior Gold	12.00	14.00
Junior Platinum	77.00	80.00
Bronze	20.00	21.00
Gold	35.00	37.00
Platinum	77.00	80.00
Supporter	12.00	13.00
Congress pay to play	15.00	16.00

Junior congress pay to play fee (mixed events)	6.00	6.50
Junior pay to play fee (junior only events)	3.00	3.00
FIDE admin fee (non-ENG)	1.50 (waived)	1.50 (waived)
Non-members game fee	20.00	21.00
Non-members game fee (junior)	6.00	7.50

ECF's President's Award for Services to Chess – Roger Lancaster



Many congratulations to Roger Lancaster, who recently received the ECF's President's Award for Services to Chess. Roger is a highly respected junior coach and organiser at Watford Chess Club, and was nominated by Watford Chess Club for his long and valued service to the chess community over many years. A link to Roger's award citation can be found here:

<https://www.ecfresource.co.uk/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/Roger-Lancaster-ECF-award-citation.docx>

4NCL 2025-2026 Dates

The placeholder dates for the 2025/2026 4NCL season have been announced:

Weekend 1: Rounds 1-2	Weekend 2: Rounds 3-4
18 th -19 th October 2025	10 th -11 th January 2026
1 st -2 nd November 2025	17 th -18 th January 2026
Weekend 3: Rounds 5-6	Weekend 4: Rounds 7-8
7 th -8 th February 2026	21 st -22 nd March 2026
7 th -8 th February 2026	21 st -22 nd March 2026
Weekend 5: Rounds 9-11	
2 nd -4 th May 2026	
2 nd -4 th May 2026	

Venue and accommodation booking details should follow soon once contracts have been signed.

Seniors Events and Dates for 2025

Here are the latest details and dates for the main seniors events in 2025. Please note that most seniors events state stipulate that you must reach the age requirement within the calendar year of the event: so to play in a 50+ event you must be aged 50 at the end of that calendar year, and likewise for the 65+ age group. In date order, the main seniors events are as follows:

British Seniors Chess Championships

The British Senior Championships will take place on 4th to 10th August in Liverpool, with two separate seven-round seniors events (50+ and 65+) . Further details can be found here:

<https://www.britishchesschampionships.co.uk/>

European Senior Chess Championships (ESCC)

The 2025 European Senior Chess Championships will be held in Rabac, Croatia, from 26th September to 6th October. Further details can be found here:

<https://www.europechess.org/european-individual-senior-chess-championship-2025-regulations/>

Please note that the closing deadline is Friday 29th August.

World Senior Chess Championships (WSSC)

FIDE has announced that this will take place in Gallipoli, Italy, from 20th October to 2nd November. Details can be found in the invitation document:

<https://www.worldseniorchampionship2025.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/02/FIDE-World-Senior-Individual-Chess-Championships-2025-ENG.pdf>

and also on the official website:

<https://www.worldseniorchampionship2025.com/>

For the first time there will be special prizes for the best performers over the age of 75, although FIDE have not yet provided a separate 75+ section.

New ECF Directors

Rob King – Operations and Administration Director



I was introduced to chess by my dad, Geoff, and eventually captained my school team before going on to compete in, and win, the Ramsay Cup, an established county-level tournament. But what has stayed with me throughout isn't the competition itself; it's the joy of thinking deeply, solving problems, and connecting with others.

When I travelled the world as a younger man I played chess in cafés and parks across different countries. Even with complete language barriers the game allowed me to connect with people, and build memories that have lasted a lifetime.

While I no longer play in formal tournaments, I remain an active and curious player, mainly through online rapid games (currently rated in the 1800s). More than ratings or openings, what keeps me coming back is the community, the quiet camaraderie, clubs that welcome

all levels, and simply getting around a board to share ideas.

As Operations Director at the ECF, I focus on building the behind the scenes systems that help that community flourish. My background in organising and optimising complex processes allows me to streamline operations, enhance tooling, and lead digital transformation, so that clubs, organisers, and players can focus on what matters most: playing, growing, and enjoying the game.

To me, chess has always been about more than tactics. It's about creating spaces, both digital and physical, where people of all backgrounds can belong, improve, and contribute. I'm proud to help shape that future at a national level, committed to ensuring our infrastructure is as thoughtful, inclusive, and resilient as the players and communities it supports.

Yury Krylov – Home Chess Development Director



I began my chess journey at the age of four, taught by my grandfather. While my love for the game has never faded, it's not elite competition that inspires me most - it's the world around chess. From helping prisoners reintegrate into society, and supporting child development in primary schools, to simply creating social connections in parks and cafés, chess has a unique power to bring people together and offer purpose and belonging. That's what I want to celebrate and support. I'll be honest - it's not the subtleties of the countless Sicilian Defence variations that get me up in the morning, but the human side of chess: the stories, the community, and the opportunities it creates.

My ECF rating sits at a modest 1695; my passion for chess has found its home at Maidenhead Chess Club, where I've seen both the beauty and the challenges of grassroots chess. The club's 120 year history is something truly special - and it's been a privilege to be part of it. But I've also noticed how some clubs across the country, steeped in rich tradition, can end up relying too much on the way things have always been done. In a fast-changing world, that can become a barrier - not just administratively, but in terms of attracting new players.

As Home Chess Development Director I want to help clubs to modernise where needed - not by imposing top-down change, but by offering practical support: for example, helping with safeguarding compliance, documentation, and league alignment, so clubs can spend less time navigating bureaucracy and more time doing what they love - running events, building communities, and growing the game.

One of my strongest personal commitments is to support lower-rated and beginner players, especially those under 1000 ECF. Too often league chess unintentionally caters for players rated 1500+, leaving newer or developing players on the margins. This is something we've wrestled with at Maidenhead, and I believe we need to focus more on creating space, formats, and support for those just starting out - because that's where growth really begins.

I'm excited about working with leagues, organisers, and players across the country to ensure chess in England is not only thriving at the top, but inclusive, welcoming and sustainable at every level.

Tim Wall - Junior Development Director



I'm delighted to be taking on the role of ECF Director for Junior Development, because the fact that we've created this role indicates that we are serious about developing English junior chess at all levels, all the way from beginners to the very top players.

My background and interest in this field is, I hope, easy to understand. For a total of 18 years – before my 'proper career' as a media editor and journalist in London, Russia and Azerbaijan, and afterwards – I have worked as a chess coach and teacher in Newcastle upon Tyne.

That's coaching improving junior (and adult) players, and teaching schoolchildren, mostly in after-school clubs. I've also done my stint as an up-and-coming junior (not quite at the elite level) and parent to a promising junior (although my son, John, quite sensibly decided that it was better to apply his chess thinking skills to computer programming and now has good prospects at a London-based financial company).

So what's the current situation for English junior chess, and how can we make things better?

Well, we have a few fantastic talents, a growing number of promising players, and an unprecedented number of children coming into the game. We have a growing network of junior chess clubs, and juniors are playing a bigger role in 'adult' clubs, congresses and other tournaments.

We are not yet back to the level of the 'English Chess Explosion' of the 1970s-1990s, where England was challenging the very top nations in global competitions. But we are well above the middle, and with a coordinated approach (and more financial support) we could become a powerhouse again.

My main priorities are to strengthen junior chess so that we achieve even more successes at the international level, and to create more opportunities for juniors through the Development Pathway so that juniors progress from junior chess clubs to regional and national success.

I will be working closely with independent organisations such as the UK Chess Challenge (UKCC), English Primary Schools Chess Association (EPSCA) and the English Junior Coaches and Organisers Association (EJCOA) to harness all our efforts in a coordinated approach that yields results.

What are the next steps? Firstly, I am looking to recruit volunteers to be regional junior coordinators, so that we can spot and feed through talented juniors to the national level. I am also beginning a consultation with everyone

involved in junior chess – parents and juniors, clubs, coaches and organisers. While I have my own ideas to develop junior chess, I'm sure you do too, and I'd like to hear them.

The first step in this consultation will be a question-and-answer session on junior development on the sidelines of the British Championships in Liverpool. (More on this soon, so watch this space.)

I look forward to seeing many of you there.

ChessFest Returns - 13th July



There are fewer than eight weeks to go until ChessFest 2025, our annual chess extravaganza in Trafalgar Square, London. On Sunday 13th July 2025, 11am-6pm, we're taking over the whole square for a day of free, family-friendly chess activities, including:

- Free chess lessons from a CSC tutor;
- Simultaneous displays by the top grandmasters in the country;
- Giant chess sets;
- Speed chess galore in the Challenge the Chess Master tent;
- Living chess with actors, replaying famous games of chess on our giant board;
- Puzzle-Rush: pit your wits against fiendish chess puzzles on ChessKid;
- Watch chess masters battle it out in games of giant blitz, a test of skill and stamina.

This year's ChessFest theme is The Wizard of Oz. Will Dorothy triumph over the Wicked Witch of the West? Will the lion hold his nerve on the same chessboard as the Wizard himself? Come along to find out.



Now It's Your Move!

Over 23,000 people attended ChessFest in Trafalgar Square last year. We want ChessFest 2025 to be even bigger! Please invite chess lovers everywhere to join us on Sunday 13th July:

- Schools - please include this flyer in your school newsletters;
- Chess clubs - please circulate details of ChessFest to your club members;
- Everyone - please forward this email to friends and family, and spread the word on social media.

Chess enthusiasts of all abilities are welcome, from novices to experts. Never played chess before? Not a problem - CSC tutors will be running free classes throughout the day for complete beginners.



We will be joined by many master players, including England internationals Mickey Adams, Gawain Jones, Nikita Vitiugov and Harriet Hunt. Come and test your

chess skills against them in either a simultaneous game or over a blitz game in our Challenge the Chess Master tent.

We'll be hosting challenge matches between the ChessFest in Trafalgar Square and other events around the country, with all the action broadcast on a giant screen at the foot of Nelson's Column. For a flavour of what to expect, please see this [video of our 2024 event](#).

No need to book - just turn up on Sunday 13th July for a full day of chess fun!

If you can't make it to Trafalgar Square, there are other ChessFest events being held around the country. Already confirmed are Liverpool (20th July) and Hull (13th July), but we expect more to be announced soon. Keep an eye on the ChessFest website for more details, or follow us on social media for the latest news.

Volunteer at ChessFest

We are looking for volunteers to help us deliver ChessFest 2025 in Trafalgar Square. Roles include:

- Encouraging members of the public to join in the activities;
- Providing information to visitors on the programme of events;
- Supervising the use of giant sets;
- Helping set up and break down the event;
- Assisting in the running of simultaneous displays.

All volunteers receive a ChessFest t-shirt, refreshments throughout the day, and reasonable travel expenses. Sign up via www.chess-fest.com

Trafalgar Square - How to Get to ChessFest

Public transport is your best bet. The closest Tube station is Charing Cross, which goes right to Trafalgar Square. Additional nearby stations include Leicester Square and Piccadilly Circus. If you're traveling by mainline train, the Charing Cross station is a three-minute walk away. Many buses will take you there as well. Click [here](#) for a map.



2025 Northumbria Masters and First Darlington ChessFest

Entries are now open for the 2025 Northumbria Masters (20th – 25th August at Darlington's Dolphin Centre), a six-day, nine-round FIDE-rated congress. Details here:

<https://northumbriamasters.com>

Tournaments include the Open Super-Swiss (eligible for title norms), the Challengers (U2000 FIDE), the Major (U1700 FIDE), and the IM Invitational Round Robin.

PLUS: the First Darlington ChessFest, Horsemarket Square, Sunday 24th August (3 pm – 7 pm). Live chess games, Challenge the Master, simultaneous displays, chess lessons, friendly games. Free entry, all welcome!

Many thanks to our sponsors: the John Robinson Youth Chess Trust, the Chess Trust, the English Chess Federation Grassroots Initiative, Chess in Schools and Communities, The Friends of Chess, Northumberland Chess Association, Durham County Chess Association, Northumbria Junior Chess Association.

So You Want to Be a Master? by Charles Higgle

I learnt the moves of chess at the age of six or seven, and as a teenager studied the game seriously. My two favourite books at the time were *Think like a Grandmaster* by A Kotov and *The Road to Chess Mastery* by M Euwe. Ever since, I have always thought how nice it would be to be a master, or at least some recognition that I was a fairly strong club player, but equally realising that I wasn't strong enough to become one, not even a candidate master. My ECF rating for most of my adult life was round the 160 mark, and then, when ECF adopted four-figure ratings, about the 1990 mark. My current ECF ratings are 1830 rapidplay, 1929 standardplay and 2084 online, and I have a FIDE over the board rating of 2001.

Then suddenly this year I managed to become both an ECF- and a FIDE-recognised master! Firstly, I found out about the ECF having a number of national titles. The full details are on this link:

<https://www.englishchess.org.uk/master-points-system/>

The title I qualified for was 'English Club Master (Class A) – minimum rating 1800 ECF standardplay'. The player must maintain an average listed rating at, or above, the minimum rating for a period of 12 months, with a total game count of 30 games or more in the 12-month qualifying period. Since Covid I have played fewer than 30 over the board games in most seasons; I have also been playing in and organising teams in 4NCL Online and

playing other online chess, so have had less time for over the board chess, but I qualified for this in the season immediately before Covid. So I applied, paid my £5 registration fee, and duly became a club master on 6th May 2025, with my name on the ECF roll of honour lists on the ECF website.

As regards my FIDE title, I knew that a chess playing friend of mine, Rudy Van Kemenade, was a FIDE Arena grandmaster. I decided to find out more about this. The full details are on this link:

<https://handbook.fide.com/.../B11FOATitlesForLowerRatingBand>

To qualify for the FIDE Arena titles you have to play online on the FIDE site: <https://chessarena.com/>

You can play rapidplay, blitz or bullet, with or without an increment. I personally find blitz and bullet a bit too fast, and I prefer an increment. So I play rapidplay – in my case 10 minutes each plus an increment of 10 seconds a move. While you can play on Arena free as a guest, to qualify for titles you do have to pay to join, which I did. I found that most of the players I ran into were far better than their ratings, which seem to be far lower than on other platforms. While initially I hoped that I would be able to get above 2000, and maintain it to become an Arena grandmaster, I found that my rating hovered around the 1600 mark. Nevertheless, this meant that in due course I became an Arena FIDE master shortly after becoming an English club master.

So there you go – you too may be able to become a master. It's within the reach of keen club players!

2025 King's New Year's Honours: Stephen Rigby, British Empire Medal – New Photo



Steve Rigby has now been presented with his British Empire Medal by the Lord-Lieutenant of Powys (where Steve now lives), Mrs Tia Catherine Jones, in her role as the King's representative. For more details please see our previous story here:

<https://www.englishchess.org.uk/2025-kings-new-years-honours-stephen-rigby-british-empire-medal/>

Gosforth Chess Club – Chess in the Park 25 and Stuff by Mick Riding

31st May saw the first of our six outdoor events this summer on a breezy but warm afternoon. Gosforth Central Park was quietish, but nonetheless enjoyable, with passing interest throughout the afternoon. We kicked off at 1 pm after the juniors session, and a big thank you to the parents, who helped with lifting and shifting, particularly Olga and Stevin. Our next is 5th July, when we are planning an outdoor blitz Swiss. 😊

Meanwhile the juniors session continues to be well attended, now with anywhere between 25 and 35 turning up, with a new hero starting to achieve cult status among the team. Chris Izod held 20 of our juniors captivated for 40 minutes while walking through two of Chernev's *Logical Chess: Move by Move* games. You could hear a pin drop: hands always in the air for questions, nobody interrupting each other – really, really good, so much so that three parents pulled up chairs, maybe mystified as to how the kids were being so good!

This has contributed in no small way to our very own Gautham Sathishkumar (13) scoring 4½ (out of 5) and equal first in the Durham Congress Minor section. There were 72 entries in this one, and for sure 'the boy done well'. Gautham's performance has catapulted his rating to over 1600, and he joins Joey, Lev and Max, with Ethan close to breaking that barrier too. Not too dusty; we are very proud of this, but there's no resting on laurels. 1700 is next on the menu!

If you're thinking of starting a junior club or kicking off outdoor events, just do it. It's simply a massively rewarding experience, and you'll never be sorry. And if support is needed, please get in touch.

Best wishes!

Mick



Delight for Durham University Alumni in World Chess League 2025 Season by Peter Hornsby

Congratulations to the Durham University Alumni chess team for qualifying for the quarter-finals of the 2025 World Chess League (WCL) by finishing in the top six out of almost 100 teams from all around the world!

Their key encounter came in round 6 against their bitter rivals Cambridge University in which they managed to prevail in a thrilling 4½-3½ victory which put them on the

path to the play-offs, and they continued their fine form from there.

The team was founded after a group of friends graduated from Durham University and stayed in touch, meeting for chess events and playing as a team online in the WCL.

The upcoming quarter-final match will be extremely tough - they face Team Iran Pro, which contains several titled and international players including GM Amir Reza Pourramezanali, GM Khalil Mousavi and GM Mahdi Gholami Orimi; however, they will fancy their chances of trying to cause a famous upset!

You can watch the match at **8 pm on Sunday 6th July** on Chess.com through this link:
<https://www.chess.com/play/match/2915351>

We wish them the very best of luck!



Phil Purcell, Kamran Rachlin, NM Sam Walker, Will Taylor

Kazakh Chess Players Play Historic Match in the British Parliament

Article from DKN news with additional input from Peter Horsnby, Captain of the Parliamentary Chess Club.



A unique chess match took place in the British Parliament when a team from Kazakhstan faced representatives of

the House of Lords and Westminster staff. According to the press service of the Kazakhstan Chess Federation (KazChess), this was the first game in history played at such a high political level with participation from international chess players, DKnews.kz reports.



The match was organised at the initiative of the Embassy of Kazakhstan in the United Kingdom, with the support of KazChess.

The Kazakh delegation included the country's leading grandmasters:

Kazybek Nogerbek
Alisher Suleymenov
Kseniya Balabayeva
Gulmira Dauletova
Darmen Sadvakasov

The UK Parliamentary Chess Club team included:

Jamie Njoku-Goodwin
Lord Harold Carter
Lord Patrick Lawrence
Lord Dafydd Wigley
Chris Fegan

Lord Harry Carter did extremely well to get a draw against GM Darmen Sadvakasov in his second game, and KazChess particularly commended Chris Fegan for his

performance against GM Alisher Suleymenov, who famously defeated GM Magnus Carlsen in 2023.

KazChess	Final score: 9.5-0.5	UK Parliamentary Chess Club
GM Kazybek Nogerbek	2-0	Jamie Njoku- Goodwin (Former Director of Strategy at 10 Downing Street)
GM Alisher Suleymenov	2-0	Chris Fegan (APPG for Chess)
GM Darmen Sadvakasov	1.5-0.5	Lord Harry Carter
WGM Xeniya Balabayeva	2-0	Lord Patrick Lawrence
WGM Gulmira Dauletova	2-0	Lord Dafydd Wigley

The evening's proceedings were featured on Kazakhstan TV. First Secretary at Ministry of Foreign Affairs at the Kazakhstan Embassy, Mr Yerlan Zeineshev. commented: 'Thank you to the UK Parliamentary Chess Club for hosting us; we really appreciated the experience and credit to our team, we all thoroughly enjoyed it.'

Lord Carter commented: 'I regarded it as a great privilege and honour to have the opportunity to play such an illustrious national chess team as that of Kazakhstan. Quite apart from the chess, which was great fun, they were all the friendliest people one could possibly meet. This is what really matters to me when playing such a competitive game as chess. It makes playing the game much more appealing if the opponent is warm and engaging, as all the Kazakhstan team were in abundance.'

After the match the Kazakh delegation was invited on a guided tour of Westminster. The chess players attended a session of a working group on labour market issues — a topic of global concern amid the rapid development of artificial intelligence.

The visit to Parliament was not the only goal of the Kazakh delegation's trip. The players were in London to participate in the 2025 FIDE World Rapid and Blitz Team Championships, taking place from 11th to 16th June. Five Kazakh players competed as part of Team KazChess, with others representing two other teams, Barys and Rookies.

Team KazChess comprised:

Aldiyar Ansat (2489)
Meruert Kamalidenova (2330)
Elnaz Kaliahmet (2218)
Darmen Dauren (1932)
Darmen Sadvakasov (2587, rapid)
Richard Rapport (2714, #27)
Parham Maghsoodloo (2691, #38)
Andrey Esipenko (2689, #39)
Alexander Grischuk (2667, #57)

The team was captained by KazChess Executive Director Gulmira Dauletova.

JUNIOR MOVES Littlewood's Choice



One of our greatest and earliest world champions was Emanuel Lasker, who held the title for an amazing 27 years. His view on chess was that it was a fight, with the outcome of the game uncertain until the strongest player eventually prevailed. Many games are like this, with mistakes being made by both players, but those are frequently the most instructive.

Consider the following which was sent in to me by the winner.

Roman Zadvorny - Ethan Pang

Dulwich College vs Westminster Under School – Board 2
ESCC Repechage Rapid, 29.04.2025

1.c4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3.g3 g6 4.Bg2 Bg7 5.e3 e6 6.Nge2 Nge7 7.0-0 d5 8.cxd5 exd5 9.d4 cxd4 10.exd4 0-0 The Symmetrical English can lead to quite dull positions, but as White still has the advantage of the first move he can choose to vary things first, and this is now what happens.

11.h3 Be6 12. Be3 Nf5 13. Rc1 Re8 14.Qd2 Qd7?! Perhaps better was 14...h5 to cement the position of the black knight on f5. White could now play 15.g4, but then 15.....Nh4 16.Bh1 Bxg4 17.hxg4 Qxg4+ 18.Kh2 Qh5 19.Kg1

Qg4+ 20.Kh2 Qh5 leads to a draw. If White tries to vary by 21.Kg3, then 21...Ne7 leads to a winning attack for Black. However, Roman is not happy with a draw, so maintains the tension.

15.Kh2 h5 16.Nf4 Ncxd4 17.Ncxd5 Nxe3? Ethan makes a mistake, leaving White with a much better position. Instead 17...Rad8 maintained the balance.



18.fxe3 Nc6 19.Nxe6 Qxe6 20.Nc7 Qe5 21.Nxe8?! This is OK, but I would have preferred 21.Nxa8 Rxa8 22.Qd7 Rf8 23.Qxb7, with a winning advantage. Perhaps Roman was afraid of 21...h4, but then 22.Qd7 is easily winning.

21....Rxe8 22.Qd5 Qe7 23.b3?! Better was 23.Qb3, with a clear advantage.

23....h4? Instead 23...Be5 gives Black some counter-chances. White has to be careful because of his weak black squares. A possible continuation is 24.Qc4 Nd8 25.h4 Qd6 26.Rcd1! Bxg3+ 27.Kh3 Qc7 28.Qxc7 Bxc7 29.Rd7 Rxe3+ 30.Rf3 Rxf3+ 31.Bxf3 Bb6 32.Bxb7, when White still maintains his advantage, but note how his kingside has been put under tremendous pressure.



24.gxh4! Rd8 25.Qe4 Qc7+ 26.Kh1 Rd2 27.Rc2 Even stronger was 27.Rcd1, because if 27...Rxa2? then 28.Qe8+ Kh7 29.Rxf7+ Qg3 30.Rxg7+ Kxg7 31.Rd7+ Kf6 32.Rf7#.

27....Rd8 28.Qg4 Qe7 29.Bxc6 bxc6 30. Rcf2 Rf8 31.h5 g5 32.h4 Qxe3 33.Qxg5?! When you are winning it is

important not to give your opponent any counter-chances. Here 33.hxg5 is clearly winning, and leaves no swindling possibilities for Black along the g-file.

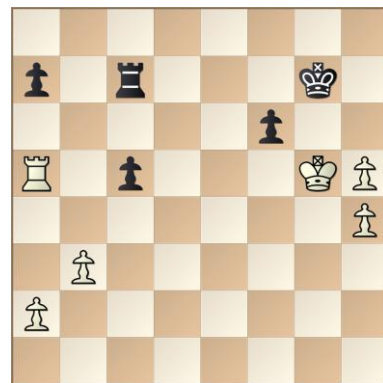
33.....Qh3+ 34.Kg1 Kh8 35.Qf4 Not yet a mistake, but 35.Rd1 Rg8 36.Rd8 Bf8 37.Rxf8! Rxf8 38.Qh6+ Kg8 39.Rg2+ is an easy win. At this stage I suspect time shortage was beginning to be a factor.

35....Rg8 36.Rh2? A bad error. Instead 36.Rg2 was essential, and after 36...c5 then 37.Rf3 Qe6 38.Kh1, and White is safe. Note that 37...Bd4+ fails to 38.Qxd4+ cxd4 39.Rxh3.



36....Be5+ 37.Kh1 Qxh2+ 38.Kxh2 Bxf4+ 39.Rxf4 Re8 40.Ra4 Re7 So the smoke has cleared, and White has to win the game all over again. It is very important here for White maintain his focus after the disappointment of the last few moves, and it is good to see that Roman manages to retain his composure.

41.Kg3 Kg7 42.Kg4 c5 43.Ra5 Rc7 44.Kg5 f6+?! This weakens Black's position, and makes things easier for White. However, even after the better 44...c4 45.bxc4 Rxc4 46.h6+ Kg8 47.Rxa7 Rc5+ 48.Kg4 Rc4+ 49.Kf5 Rxh4 50.Ra6 White maintains a winning advantage. I now give the rest of the game with no further comment, as Roman efficiently winds things up.



45.Kf5 c4 46.bxc4 Rxc4 47.Rxa7+Kh6 48.Kxf6 Rxh4 49.Ra8 Kh7 50.Kg5 Rh1 51.Ra7+ Kg8 52.a4 Rh2 53.a5 Rh1

54.a6 Ra1 55.Kg6 Kf8 56.Ra8+ Ke7 57.a7 Rg1+ 58.Kh7 Ra1 59.Rg8 1-0

A fascinating game which was a real battle, and illustrates Lasker's belief extremely well.

This victory helped Dulwich College to qualify for the final of the National Schools Chess Championships, and I wish them every success.

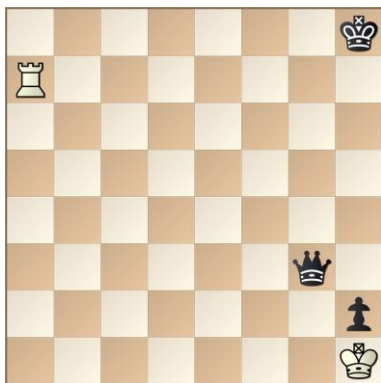
If you have played any exciting games as a youngster that you would like to have published in my column please send them to me at plittl@hotmail.com. I cannot promise that they will appear, but I will give them every consideration.

IMPROVERS

Paul Littlewood on Tactics

It is very important to recognize patterns in chess, as they can turn up in the most unexpected places. One of the unusual motifs that I came across when I was a youngster was the 'mad rook'.

Here is a simple example to illustrate what I mean.



It is White to move, and he is hopelessly behind on material; however, the white king is stalemated. Therefore if he can find a way to sacrifice his rook without breaking the stalemate it is a draw. It looks easy at first, because White can play 1.Rh7+ Kg8 2.Rg7+, and if Black captures with the king it is stalemate. However, Black can play 2...Qxg7, which breaks the stalemate and is then winning for him.

Therefore the drawing manoeuvre is **1.Ra8+ Kh7 2.Rh8+ Kg7 3.Rg8+**, and now **3...Kxg8** is forced, with a draw by stalemate.

There are different examples where the 'mad rook' goes on a suicide mission across the whole board, leading to perpetual check or a stalemate draw.

Consider the following example which came up recently in the Sharjah Masters.

Jorge Ferreira - Pouya Idani
Sharjah Masters 18.05.2025

White to move



Black is intending to simply gobble up the white f-pawns with his king, leading to a simple win; so in this position White resigned. However, he missed a clever 'mad rook' trick!

He should have played **1.Kxh3 Rh1+ 2.Kg2 a1=Q**, and now not 3.Rxa1 Rxa1 with an easy win for Black, but instead **3.Rd8+**, starting a 'mad rook' sequence because the white king is stalemated. The game could continue **3...Kc4 4.Rc8+ Kd5 5.Rd8+ Kc6 6.Rc8+ Kd7 7.Rd8+ Ke7 8.Rd7+ Kf8 9.Rd8+ Kg7 10.Rd7+ Kg6 11.Rd6+ Kg5 12.Rd5+** and the black king cannot escape the checks, or if Black plays **12...Kh4** at the end then **13.Rh5+ Kxh5** is stalemate.

Note, however, that White must be careful not to allow Black to break the stalemate position. For example, had he played 8.Re8+? then Black would have won by 8...Kf6 9.Rf8+ Kg6 10.Rg8+ Kh7, and the black queen is able to capture the white rook on g7 or h8, when the checks run out.

This is a very important point to remember. The 'mad rook' is not always successful!

Here are two positions for you to solve, with the solutions given at the end of the article.

Larry Evans - Samuel Reshevsky

US Championship 1963/64

White to move

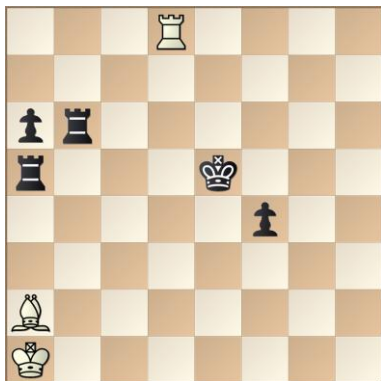


White's position looks desperate, but how did he manage to draw?

Ivan Myall - Ian Snape

English 65+ Seniors round 6 27.04.2025

Black to move



In this position Black failed to notice the danger signals. The white king and bishop are stalemated, and so there is a possibility that a 'mad rook' scenario could develop. Any move that breaks the stalemate, such as 1...Rg6, wins easily, but in the game Black played **1...Rb4**. White now played **2.Re8+**, with the intention of trying to sacrifice this rook and obtain a stalemate draw. Can Black now escape the checks, or is it a draw?

Answers

Evans - Reshevsky

White draws by **1.Qg8+! Kxg8 2.Rxg7+**, and if the rook is captured by either the king or queen it is stalemate. If 2...Kf8 then 3.Rf7+, and there is perpetual check along the seventh rank unless the rook is captured, when again stalemate ensues.

Myall - Snape

The game went **2.Re8+ Kd4 3.Re4+ Kc5 4.Re5+ Kb6 5.Re6+ Kb5 7.Re5+ Kb6 8.Re6+ Kc7 9.Rc6+ Kb7 10.Rb6+ Kc7**, and a draw was agreed, because White can perpetually check along the sixth rank given that a rook capture is stalemate.

However, there are two ways to thwart the 'mad rook'. After **2.Re8+ 2...Kf5 3.Rf8+ Kg4 4.Rg8+ Kf3** (or **4...Rg5 5.Rg3+ Ke4 6.Re3+ Kf5**, and now there are no more sensible checks; if **7.Re5+** then **7...Rxe5** breaks the stalemate. Moreover, instead of **7...Kb6** in the game Black could have played **7...Ka4**, and now the white bishop is unpinned and the stalemate is broken. An extraordinary miss by Black!

Gormally's Coaching Corner



Pessimism Unbound in Almeria

To play chess well you need passion and fascination - the passion and motivation to really be interested and fascinated in chess, and to want to investigate the position and find resources and ideas. When American super grandmaster Hikaru Nakamura plays Titled Tuesday or some other event that he is streaming, often he'll get excited when he sees a possibility or variation appear in his mind during a game. All these ideas are whirring. I want to show you a game where exactly the opposite happened, and where pessimism, and my general sense of despondency and negativity that I carry with myself all the time, seeped into the game itself and gripped my outlook.

This led to a negative flow of ideas, and consequently I lost the game. I was lucky enough to be invited to the Killer Chess training tournament which took place in Roquetas de Mar, a town on the southern Spanish coast in the Almeria region in Andalusia. This area is about 200 kilometres to the east of Malaga, and about 300 kilometres to the west of Alicante. To get to Almeria

airport I got a train down to Stansted airport, and stayed in a hotel before flying out at 7 am in the morning.

The hotel I stayed in, the DeSalis, had mixed reviews when I looked it up on Tripadvisor. I tend to look up the reviews after I've stayed in a hotel, rather than before. I had the feeling that some of the reviews stating that it was loosely run (there seemed to be only one person running both the reception and the bar) were correct, but it was functional enough. There was also a friendly cat that prowled in and out of the lobby area.

On the flight over as we approached the coast I was surprised to see a snow-bound mountain so close to the sea. Apparently this was called Mulhacén, at over 11,000 feet the highest peak in continental Spain. Could I climb my own personal mountain, and finally win a tournament abroad, I wondered? But that still wasn't the end of my journey, as I now had to get to the hotel, and the idea of paying a taxi over 50 euros for a 16 kilometre trip did not appeal - so I decided to get the bus. I got the airport bus into Almeria itself, but then I had to locate the bus terminus to get the connection to Roquetas de Mar. Cue an overweight, exasperated chess grandmaster huffing and puffing in the heat of Spain, trawling around town asking bewildered locals where the bus station was. I found the bus, and it deposited me in Roquetas. But even this wasn't the end of my troubles, as I couldn't get internet reception on my phone and had no idea where the hotel was. So I asked a local who was loitering near the bus stop if he had any idea, and after he put it in his phone, he suggested that we go and find his cousin (who he claimed was a taxi-driver) and he could drive me to the hotel. Alarm bells started ringing in my head. I had never met these people before, and had no idea who they were. What if they tried to rob me? I thanked them for their help, but said I would be better off finding an official taxi. It was eight euros to the hotel, so I did in the end make a saving, but it hardly seemed worth it for all the trouble I went through.

It was round 5 of the tournament that effectively decided the event for me.

Castellanos Rodriguez, Renier (2474) - Gormally, Daniel W (2443)

Round 5: Castellanos Rodriguez, Renier - (5.1), 07.05.2025

1.c4 c6 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e3 d5 4.Qc2 g6 5.b3 Bg7 6.Bb2 0-0 7.Be2



7...Bg4 After the game my opponent mentioned 7...Bf5 8.d3 Na6 as a possible improvement, when Black is creating indirect pressure against d3.

8.h3 Bxf3 9.Bxf3 Nbd7 10.d4 Re8 11.Nd2 e5 12.0-0



12...e4 A committal decision. Black is handing White a free hand on the queenside, but at the same time I hoped that I might be able to create some chances on the other wing. 12...exd4 13.Bxd4 Ne5.

13.Be2 Nf8 14.b4 Ne6 15.Rfc1 h5 16.a4 Nh7 17.a5 a6 18.cxd5 cxd5 19.Qb3 f5 20.b5 f4 21.bxa6 bxa6 22.Rc6



The critical moment of the game has been reached.

22...Nh7? This has been happening in my games recently when under pressure. I feel uncomfortable in these situations; somehow my ego takes over, and I rush

through the moment and don't take my chances. When I checked the game afterwards I was surprised to see that Black was perfectly fine here, and that 22...Nhg5! was correct. 23.h4 (23.Rxa6 fxe3 24.Qxe3 Rb8! is also not so clear) 23...fxe3 24.fxe3 Nh3+!!



25.gxh3 Rb8 26.Rb6 Qxh4



The engine says that Black has enough resources to hold the position, although it still remains complex. At least this would have been a good practical try. This missed opportunity made me realise a few things about my chess:

1. My mindset is often too negative. 22... Nh8?, instead of playing 22... Nh5!, indicates a pessimistic mindset. When under pressure my tendency is to knee-jerk and respond to my opponent, rather than to try and dictate the tempo of the game myself.
2. I can no longer analyse effectively. Ironically, it was the engine that pointed out this 22...Nh5 possibility, but the problem is probably over-use of engines to analyse my games in the first place, which meant that I was unable to see this possibility at all during the game; it was beyond the scope of my normal thinking.
3. I should have followed the Kramnik advice given in his Chessable course on strategy: place your pieces close to your opponent's king. The logic of this advice is that you will probably always gain some counterplay. In any case,

this idea of playing Nh5 and giving your piece up for just one pawn is highly instructive, and who knows, I may be able to use it in future.

23.Rxa6 Qg5 The problem is now that Black lacks enough resources to create serious counterplay on the kingside. I just don't have enough pieces to throw at White's position; the knight on f8 is doing a defensive job, when I need it for the attack.

24.Rxa8 Rxa8 25.a6 Bh6



26.Ra5!+- I had seen this coming, and now realised I was cooked. White starts to create threats like Nxe4.

26...fxe3 After 26...f3 I assumed he would just give up a piece with 27.Nxf3 exf3 28.Bxf3+-.

27.Nxe4 exf2+ 28.Kf1 Qf4 29.Qxd5 Rc8 30.Rc5 30.Ra1 was also good enough, even if allowing the rook into c2 looks a bit scary for White. 30...Rc2 31.a7 Qe3 32.Bb5+-.

30...Rd8 31.Qe5 Nxc5 32.dxc5 Qxe5 33.Bxe5 Bg7 34.Bc4+ Kh8



35.Bd6 35.Bxg7+ Kxg7 36.c6 seemed like a cleaner win during the game, but in any case Black's task seems hopeless after the move played in the game as well. White just has too many threats in this endgame, and the black

king is too far away from the kingside. Perhaps finally my pessimistic mindset was justified.

35...Ra8 36.Kxf2 Bd4+ 37.Ke2 Nd7 38.Kd3 Bg7 39.Bb5 Nb8 40.Bxb8 Rxb8 41.Nd6 Ra8 42.Kc4 Bb2 43.Kd5 Kg7 44.c6 1-0

Perhaps I was too harsh on myself for this loss; after all, my opponent Renier played at 98 percent accuracy according to Lichess, and made zero inaccuracies and mistakes. He's been doing this for a while. Some years ago Jacob Aagard decided that Renier needed the grandmaster title by his name if he was going to be one of the main coaches on Killer Chess training, and since then Renier's chess has gone up a level. This is what I have been missing, this regular training. I have the talent; it's just that something isn't quite there, a consistency of work ethic perhaps. The idea of having a chess camp in a holiday resort was an idea of Jacob's wife, Kallia, but prices for the camp weren't cheap, somewhere north of 1,000 euros, although this included the hotel as well, which in my view was an excellent deal. It's true that the reviews on Tripadvisor were mixed. Some pointed out that the hotel had a high number of elderly Spanish visitors, and that the food in the main buffet was repetitive. You have to be careful not to put on weight at these all-inclusive hotel events. There is the yoghurt/pastry option at breakfast, and then you can have dessert at lunch and dinner as well. So after the first few days when I got fatter and fatter, I decided to turn the tide and did a lot of walking. Even on one of the final days when there were two games in one day I made sure I did 10,000 steps. It is so easy to just slob around the hotel when you have two games in one day, so I was proud of this effort. All this walking led to higher energy levels and a greater sense of purpose, and this paid off in round 8 when I had my cleanest game of the event against the famous American streamer Kostya Kavutskiy.

Gormally, Daniel W (2443) - Kavutskiy, Kostya (2356)
Round 8: Gormally, Daniel W - Kavutskiy, (8.4), 14.05.2025

1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 d6 3.Bb5+ Nc6 4.0-0 Bd7 5.c3 Nf6 6.Re1 a6 7.Bxc6 Bxc6 8.d4



When I checked the database before the game I noticed that he had not faced this variation before, which is one of the critical lines of this entire system. White sacrifices a pawn for active development. Because this game was the only one on the day, and the game didn't start till 4.30 pm, I had plenty of time to prepare. However, the actual time I prepared for this game was probably only around 90 minutes, maybe less. I already knew this line fairly well, so didn't feel the need to prepare excessively. More and more, I'm coming to the conclusion that it is important to prepare yourself mentally, rather than chess-wise, before the game.

8...Bxe4 8...cxd4 9.cxd4 Bxe4 10.Nc3 d5 11.Bg5 e6 is another line. Really, White doesn't have much here if Black knows what he is doing, although it looks scary for Black with the king in the centre.

9.Bg5 Bg6 I briefly checked this line before the game, and was now regretting not checking it in even more detail. Perhaps too much time spent on Disney+, and not enough time on ChessBase!

9...Bd5 is the main line. **10.Nbd2 e6 11.c4 Bxf3 12.Qxf3 cxd4 13.Bxf6 gxf6 14.Qxb7**



This has been played a few times, when White has compensation for the pawn.

10.d5 Qd7 11.Nbd2 h6?! After this Black comes under obvious and heavy pressure.

11...0-0 12.b4 Nxd5 13.Nc4 e6! 14.Bxd8 Qxd8



This is one line suggested by the engine, when Black gives back some material to solve their immediate problems. 11...Bd3!? 12.Re3 c4 is another possible line.

12.Bxf6 gxf6 13.Nc4 Rb8 During the game I wondered about 13...Rg8, with the idea of sacrificing material for a kingside attack, but further analysis confirms this is bonkers. 14.Nb6 Qg4 15.h3 Qf4 16.Nxa4 Bh5 17.Re3! wins for White.

14.Nh4 Rg8 15.Qf3 White's initiative is obvious, and my moves are easy to play. For Black, however, it is awkward, as his king is stuck in the centre.

15...Kd8



16.a4! This was my star move of the game. I am showing that there is no need to rush, and that Black's problems aren't going away.

I wanted to go 16.b4 to open up the position, but rejected it for some reason. 16...Bh7! creates a strategic threat of ... Qg4, exchanging queens (16...Qc7 17.Rac1). 17.h3, however, maintains the advantage.

16...h5 My last move was partly played to discourage 16...b5, which can now be met by 17.axb5 axb5 18.Na5, with a crushing advantage. Perhaps Black can handle the knight going into c6, but not with the a-file being open as

well; the more or less forcing variation 16...Bc2 17.h3 to prevent ... Qg4 17...Bxa4 18.Nb6 Qc7 19.Nxa4 b5 20.Nxc5 Qxc5 21.Rxa6 doesn't really work for Black; during the game I felt that his best chance was to play 16...e5 sooner or later, even at the cost of a pawn. 17.dxe6 fxe6 and if White now takes on f6, ... Be7 will be a decent reply. 18.b4! threatens to expose the black king, and keeps a large advantage.

17.h3 Preventing Black ever playing ...Qg4.

17...Bh6 18.Nb6



This was another reason why it was useful to play a4, as now Black no longer has ... Qb5 available. After the game in our brief chat Kostya admitted that he wanted to resign at this moment. White's positional advantage is too overwhelming.

18...Qe8 18...Qc7 19.a5, and Black can hardly move anything - the black queen is snookered.

19.b4 c4 20.Nxg6 Rxg6 21.Re4 e6



22.Rxc4 Unsurprisingly, the computer wants to get all brutal with 22.dxe6 fxe6 23.Rd1, but I had missed that after 23...Qc6 White can simply play 24.Rxe6! Qxf3 25.Rxd6+ Kc7 26.Rd7#.

22...Qe7 23.Qxh5 e5 24.Qf5 Ke8 25.Rc8+ Rxc8 26.Qxc8+ Qd8 27.Qxb7 f5



28.Qc8! Snuffing out any counterplay on the kingside, and the game is practically decided.

28...Qxc8 29.Nxc8 Bd2 30.b5 Kd8 31.Nb6 Kc7 31...axb5 32.axb5 Bxc3 33.Rc1 Bd4 34.Rc8+ Ke7 35.Nc4 should also be an easy technical conversion for White.

32.Nc4 1-0

Gormally, Daniel W (2443) - Del Rio De Angelis, Salvador G. (2402)

Round 4: Gormally, Daniel W - Del Rio De (4.2), 11.05.2025

I sensed that the small field in the Peter Long Memorial was partly due to the fact that the cost of staying in the hotel was rather high for your average chess player, and that the town wasn't particularly easy to get to. Was it wide of the mark to suggest that perhaps Spanish players were also wary of attending a tournament run by an outsider, given that Jacob Aagaard is originally from Denmark? Or it could just be that the hotel had limited space. All mere speculation on my part! Two of the invited grandmasters, Arizmendi and Del Rio De Angelis, were both from Spain and born in 1976 like me, so in a sense these games against them were like 'pre-seniors'. As already established, I tend to perform fairly well when I have a good position, but when under psychological stress I often tend to collapse, and rush through the key moments. I doubt I am alone in this regard. A lot of these 'collapses' are in fact directly linked to poor calculation, and not being as exhaustive as possible. In Ramesh's book on calculation at some point he writes something like: 'The chess player needs to be as exhaustive as possible with their calculation, and also calculate as quickly as possible.' Easier said than done, as can be seen in the next game against Del Rio.

It was only in the last round that I faced Arizmendi. With the white pieces, and trailing him and Girel for a potential

podium finish, I made a pathetic quick draw, because I was concerned that if I lost the game I wouldn't win a prize at all (there were only five prizes.) This cynical decision bagged me 500 euros for fourth place; however, once you deduct all the travel costs, it was clear that I made a financial loss on the event. These Spanish events are tremendous fun, but it's also clear that they aren't a long-term career option – not least with EasyJet and Ryanair cabin luggage charges as they are. It should also be noted that the organisers tried to discourage the players from taking quick draws with the stipulation that it would harm your tie-break if you drew in 30 moves or fewer. So fortunately, that quick draw in the final round was my only one of the event.



29...Bc5 The interesting thing about this game was what I would have done if he had simply snapped off a pawn with 29...Rxa2. During the game it was my intention to go for active counterplay with 30.Rh8+? (30.g5!, creating the threat of a mating net with Rh8+ followed by Reh4, is a much tighter defence - 30...Ke8 31.Rh8+ Kd7 32.Ra8, with excellent chances to hold) 30...Kg7 31.Re8, but in fact this line is more or less losing for White: 31...Bh4! puts White in trouble.



I had seen this in my calculations, but just underestimated how bad this whole line was for White. 32.g5 (I also thought I had a back-up variation with 32.Bc5, but this is also bad, as Black has a couple of ways to refute this: 32...g5!+ or 32...Rd8 are good) 32...Rxe3!. Again, I even saw this sacrifice, but just assessed it as unclear, which is

very generous towards White's position: 33.Rxe3 Rxf2+ 34.Kg1 Rf5



and White is simply in trouble, as too many pawns are dropping off. The interesting question is whether I would have slowed down if he had grabbed the pawn, or bashed out Rh8–e8 fairly quickly. I had over 20 minutes plus increments to get to the time control, so the scary thing in my mind is that I'm almost certain that I would have blundered with this Rh8+ idea, rather than sitting on my hands and coming up with a better defence. During the game, I could sense the level of my nervous anxiety rising.

30.Rh8+! Still, I did have a good think before playing this, rather than rushing. I think I was helped recently by playing the online game Spelling Bee. The idea is to get as many words as possible, and one thing I've noticed is that if I leave the game for a few hours and come back, suddenly I'll see a lot more words. That means my subconscious has been working on it in the background - an interesting phenomenon. Clearly, in a chess game you can't just leave a position alone for a few hours, but the principle is still the same. If you don't give yourself the time to let stuff seep in, you won't see different ideas.

30.Bxc5+ Rxc5 31.Rhe1 Rc2 32.R1e2 Rdd2 33.Rxd2 Rxd2 34.a3 bxa3 35.Ra4 Rd5! leaves White struggling.

30...Kg7 31.Rc8



This was the idea I didn't see initially when he played the bishop to c5. As soon as I spotted it I realized this was the path to equality.

31...Rdc3 32.Bxc5 Rxc5 33.Rxc5 Rxc5 34.Re2 g5 35.Kf3

The king will go to e4, after which it is difficult to see how either side can make progress, so I decided to offer a draw, which was accepted by my opponent. ½–½

STUDIES AND PROBLEMS

Monthly Conundrum by Christopher Jones

Last time I left you with this problem:



Byron Zappas

1st Prize, *The Problemist* 1978(/1)

Mate in 2

White will win by Zugzwang, but has to take care not to jeopardise any of the mating responses to Black's moves in the diagram position; not 1.Ke7? (1...dxe4 2.Red8#) 1...Nxb1!; nor 1.Qf1? (1...dxe4 2.Qc4#) 1...f5!; nor 1.Bf7? (1...dxe4 2.Rc4#) 1...Ne6!. So 1.Re6!, which *does* work! (1...dxe4 2.Rd6#)

Over two days of the Easter weekend the British Chess Problem Society staged an 'e-weekend', the brainchild of my fellow *ChessMoves* columnist Ian Watson, and run by him with invaluable technical support from David Hodge. Some fifty chess problem enthusiasts from around the world registered, and at any given time there were as many as thirty taking part on a Zoom connection. There were three lectures, as well as time for participants to share their favourite problems, and there was even a solving tournament. We hope to repeat the experience next year.

One of the lecturers was Jonathan Mestel, a double GM

(both for over the board chess and for chess problem solving), who shared a number of insights into the thoughts of a successful competitive chess problem solver, one of which was exemplified in the following problem.



Petko Petkov
1st Prize=, *Problemas* 1980
Mate in 3

In his lecture (whose text appears in the May issue of *The Problemist*), Jonathan said that he ‘found that any rook - pawns on the board can give vital hints about the solution’. We must remember that problem composers don’t add any units to the diagram just to make the position look prettier, or purely to misdirect the solver. Here, there must be a positive purpose in placing a white pawn at a4; and that seems as though it must be to guard b5, which implies that there will be a line of play in which the black king goes to c4. Jonathan therefore surmised that the black knight would somehow be induced to leave b3, whereupon 2.Nb7+ would lead to mate: 2...Kxc4 3.Na5#.

But that leaves the critical question as to what White can threaten which might induce that move from b3. Here Jonathan noted that the white bishop at d8 isn’t doing anything useful, so the solver will suspect that it makes the key move; and reflecting on the role of the black pawn on h6 then comes into play. It appears to prevent 1.Bg5, but in fact there is the nice point that after 1.Bg5 hxc5 the g5-square is now available to be occupied by the d6-knight: 2.Nf7+ Kxe4 3.Nxg5#.

The solver will feel that they must be on the right track here. And indeed it turns out that 1.Bg5! threatens 2.Ne2+ (2...Rxe2 3.Rd3#; 2...Bxe2 3.Be3# - a *Nowotny* interference). This is where the move from b3 comes in – 1...Nc1 defends against the threat, but fails, as we’ve seen, to 2.Nb7+. Other lines are 1...Rxe4/Bxc4 2.Nb5+/Nf5+, and 1...Ng4 2.Rd3+.

The Problemist strives to hit a balance between the

interests of those primarily enthused by solving and those whose primary interest is the composing of beautiful strategic problems. (Some readers, of course, combine both interests.) From the same May edition here is another problem that comes in the ‘beautiful strategic problems’ category, but which may serve as an enjoyable test of your solving skills.



Marko Klasinc and Fadil Abdurahmanovic
The Problemist 2024
Helpmate in 4

‘Helpmate in 4’ means that you are looking for a sequence of moves in which Black collaborates in letting White achieve mate on the fourth move, so bwbwbwbw#. I guess that a good starting point is to see what configuration (not far removed from the diagram set-up) of these pieces would constitute mate, and then to exercise your imagination to see if there is any way in which this checkmate position can be reached.

I’ll give the solution next time. In this case I can’t add the rider that otherwise you can ask your computer (unless you have specialist software), but if you find the task tantalizing you can email me!

Christopher Jones
cjajones1@yahoo.co.uk

Winton British Chess Solving Championship 2025/2026 – Starter Problem

The starter problem for this championship, again sponsored by Winton, is shown below. White, playing up the board, is to play and force mate in two moves against any black defence.

WBCSC Starter 2025-2026

Black (8 Men)



#2

White (9 Men)

There is no entry fee, and the competition is open to British residents only. Competitors need send only White's first move, known as the key-move. Postal entries should be sent to:

Nigel Dennis, Boundary House, 230 Greys Road, Henley-on-Thames, Oxon, RG9 1QY

... or by email to: winton@theproblemist.org

All entries should be postmarked or dated no later than **31st July 2025** and must give the entrant's name and home address. Juniors under the age of 18 on 31st August 2024 must give their date of birth.

Please mention that you saw the starter problem in ChessMoves.

Receipt of the solution to the starter will only be acknowledged after the closing date, when all competitors will receive the answer, and those who get it right will also receive the postal round, which will contain eight more difficult and varied problems. In due course the best competitors and the best juniors from the postal round will be invited to the final at Harrow School on 21st February 2026. The ultimate winner of the final will win

the right to represent Great Britain at the World Chess Solving Championships later in 2026.

How to Solve a Study by Ian Watson

Centenary Homage

We have a newly-composed study for you to solve, but first let's look at one from exactly a century ago. It's quite well known - with justification. Indeed, we could call it a classic. Even if you've seen it before (and can remember the solution!), it's worth considering what is a good way to go about solving it.

L Kubbel 150 Endgame Studies 1925



White to play and win

This seems impossible to solve: White has plentiful plausible moves, and a plethora of possible follow-ups too. We need to find a plan, or else we'll be wasting the whole weekend analysing options. OK, then - what strategic factors are there? White's queen and knight are a formidable attacking force, but not enough to be able to mate Black's king without any support, bearing in mind that Black can start checking as soon as he gets a free move. Also, those pawns on the queenside must have some function, and it isn't to prevent Black giving checks. So maybe they are they to help make a cage for the black king. Can that be? They're a long way from the action. Our plan would have to be to force the black king right across the board; then it'll be near the white king and perhaps also inhibited in its escape by the pawns too. Well, yes, it seems like a long shot, but at least it's a plan...

We'll need the white knight to stay fairly close to the black king, so 1.Nf6+/Nh6+/Ne5+ don't seem likely; also, 1.Nf2+ Kg2, 1.Qh5+ Kg3, and 1.Qf3+ Kh4 are dead ends, so 1.Ne3+ seems like the most promising, or rather the least hopeless. Black has to play 1...Kg3, and White only has 2.Qg4+ Kf2 3.Qf4+, but then 3...Ke2. Ah ha! Now we have

4.Qf1+, with a skewer after 4...Kxe3. At last some elegance - maybe this might even be the solution line. 4...Kd2 5.Qd1+, using the skewer again, and we are beginning to gain confidence that we're on the right track. 5...Kc3 6.Qc2+ Kb4, or else White has a knight fork, and now what? Black runs away to a5 if we try 7.Qc4+; similarly, 7.Qd2+ Kb5. That only leaves 7.Qb2+, meeting 7...Ka5 with 8.Nc4+, but Black has 7...Nb3, and 8.Nc2+ can be met by any king move... well, not *any* king move - not 8...Kc5, which gets skewered by 9.Qa3+, but the other options will defend. That thought *might* get you to the solution - the queen sac 8.Qa3+ wins the black queen, or else White mates with his lone knight. That combo is a one-mover, so should be obvious, but for humans it's nearly invisible.

The full solution is **1.Ne3+ Kg3 2.Qg4+ Kf2 3.Qf4+ Ke2 4.Qf1+ Kd2 5.Qd1+ Kc3 6.Qc2+ Kb4 7.Qb2+ Nb3 8.Qa3+ Kxa3 9.Nc2** mate. A striking king hunt, with a stunning climax.

This is the new composition; it's by Paul Michelet.



White to play and win

The answer is given after the calendar at the back of the magazine.

Ian Watson

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EVENTS CALENDAR

The full events calendar is updated daily, and can be found at <https://www.englishchess.org.uk/event-calendar/>

Week Beginning 30 June 2025	
1 July 2025	UKCA Tuesday Blitz, London
2 July 2025	Coulsdon Chess Daytime Chess Club Summer 2025
2 July 2025	First Wednesday Chess, Hertsmere
3 July 2025	13th Pimlico Summer Tournament 2025, London
3 July 2025	Newcastle Summer Blitz Round 3/5
5 July 2025	ECF Counties Championship – Finals
5 July 2025	Earlsfield FIDE Rapidplay, London
5 July 2025	Birmingham FIDE Rapid 15+5
5 July 2025	Golders Green FIDE Rapid Open
5 July 2025	Maidenhead Junior Tournament July 2025
5 July 2025	Birmingham FIDE Blitz 5+3
5 July 2025	London Women Chess Club – Weekly Social Chess
6 July 2025	Coulsdon Chess Rapidplay
6 July 2025	South Shields FIDE Rated Blitz 2025
6 July 2025	Ealing Broadway FIDE Rapidplay
Week Beginning 7 July 2025	
8 July 2025	Muswell Hill FIDE Chess
8 July 2025	UKCA Tuesday Blitz, London
9 July 2025	Coulsdon Chess Daytime Chess Club Summer 2025
9 July 2025	AlphaChess North London FIDE Rapid
10 July 2025	13th Pimlico Summer Tournament 2025, London
10 July 2025	London Nine Elms FIDE Blitz 5+3
11 July 2025 - 13 July 2025	EJCOA National Youth Championship Finals, Nottingham
11 July 2025 - 13 July 2025	3rd Kent FIDE Congress, Royal Tunbridge Wells
11 July 2025	Earlsfield Junior FIDE Rapidplay, London
12 July 2025	Southall Junior Rapidplay
12 July 2025	2025 UKCC Northern Gigafinal (U8, U10), Gorton
12 July 2025	III Milton Keynes FIDE Rapid Tournament
12 July 2025	Dartford Junior Chess Open 2025
12 July 2025 - 13 July 2025	Southall FIDE Congress
13 July 2025	2025 UKCC Northern Gigafinal (U12, U14, U18), Gorton
13 July 2025	Berkshire Open Event - Chess Tournament, Finchampstead
Week Beginning 14 July 2025	
15 July 2025	Muswell Hill FIDE Chess
15 July 2025	UKCA Tuesday Blitz, London
18 July 2025 - 21 July 2025	English Chess Championship 2025, Kenilworth
18 July 2025 - 21 July 2025	English Women's Chess Championship and English Women's U1700 Competition 2025, Kenilworth
18 July 2025 - 19 July 2025	Earlsfield FIDE Congress, London
19 July 2025 - 26 July 2025	BCA Chairman's Cup, Bournemouth
19 July 2025 - 20 July 2025	1st Glossop Chess Congress
19 July 2025	2025 UKCC Southern Gigafinal (U8, U10), Esher
20 July 2025	2025 UKCC Southern Gigafinal (U12, U14, U18), Esher
20 July 2025	5th Ashton Rapidplay Congress, Ashton-under-Lyne
20 July 2025	11th Graeme Thomson Memorial Rapid, Hotwells
20 July 2025	Thamesmead London Blitz OPEN 2024
Week Beginning 21 July 2025	
22 July 2025	UKCA Tuesday Blitz, London
24 July 2025	Newcastle Summer Blitz Round 4/5
24 July 2025	Hendon FIDE Rapid, London
26 July 2025	Poplar Rapid Tournaments - 15th Series, London
27 July 2025	Eccles Fundraising FIDE / ECF Classic Chess Event 2025

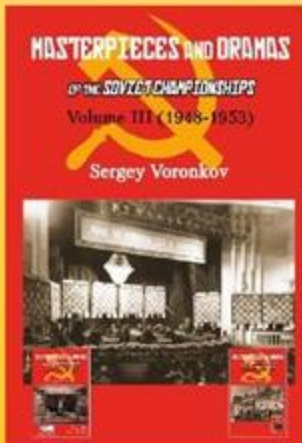
How to Solve a Study – Answer

(Michelet)

1.Ne3 Qxc5 2.Be7 Qxe7 3.Qxb2+ Kb4 4.Qa3+ mates or wins.

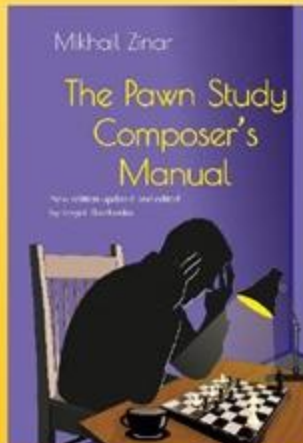
Tempting is 1.Be3?, threatening 2.Nxb3, but Black can defend successfully with 1...Qa8 (eyeing the h1-square), so my computer says: 1.Be3? Qa8 2.Nxb3 Qh1+ 3.Nc1 bxc1Q+ 4.Bxc1+ Kb4, and Black's king escapes.

Without having seen the Kubbel, I think this study would be near impossible to solve. Even with the Kubbel clue, 2.Be7 is truly hard to find.

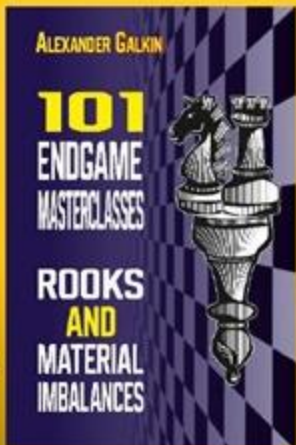


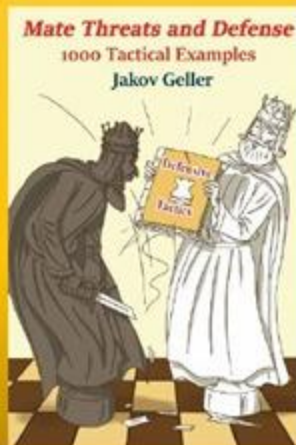
New books from Elk and Ruby

- Masterpieces and Dramas of the Soviet Championships: Volume III (1948-1953) by *Sergey Voronkov*
- The Pawn Study Composer's Manual by *Mikhail Znar*
- 101 Endgame Masterclasses: Rooks and Material Imbalances by *Alexander Galkin*
- Mate Threats and Defense - 1000 Tactical Examples by *Jakov Geller*



Available in the UK
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